GNAMMA RESEARCH

الضَّرُورِيُّ فِي أُصُولِ الْفِقْهِ

Al-Ḍarūrī fī Uṣūl al-Fiqh

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English reading edition

Complete English translation · Qur’an footnotes
Bidāya applications · subject index · technical dictionary

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GNAMMA RESEARCH · ENGLISH READING EDITION

Guide to this edition

This edition presents the complete English translation. The text is followed by illustrative Bidāya applications, a subject index and a technical dictionary.

The reading text derives from the al-ʿAlawī 1994 edition, with comparison to Bou Akl's printed 2015 Arabic edition, French translation and apparatus. The Escorial manuscript has not been independently inspected. English translation and vocalization are editorial.

Numbering. R identifies this edition's 258 reading units; BA identifies Bou Akl's 311 numbered units. These are reference systems, not original chapter numbers. The later copyist's colophon and ownership notice remain separate.

Two complementary contents lists

1. Recorded parts and chapters translates the 46 headings in the Arabic edition and preserves their hierarchy. **2. Editorial section guide** gives our descriptive titles for all 258 numbered reading units. These titles are editorial aids, not headings in Ibn Rushd's text; they are confined to the guide and its detailed bookmarks.

The body gives prominence to the recorded rubrics, with small section references for lookup. The opening discussion has no separately recorded heading. A printed rubric alone does not establish manuscript provenance.

Qur'an references

Numbered page footnotes identify quoted verses and explicit Qur'an references. Qualifications distinguish the verse itself from paraphrase, combined wording or a reported reading.

Contents 1 · Recorded parts and chapters

The headings recorded in the Arabic edition, translated in their established hierarchy. Section references identify this edition's reading units; they are not original chapter numbers.

Opening discussion (unheaded) (§§1–9) **8**

Discussion of the First Part of This Book (§10) **10**

First Section (§11) 10

Discussion of the Second Section of the First Part (§17) 11

Chapter (§18) 12

Chapter (§23) 13

Second Question (§26) 13

Third Question: The Forbidden Is the Contrary of the Obligatory (§28) 14

Fourth Question (§32) 15

Discussion of the Third Section of the First Part (§36) 15

Discussion of the Fourth Section (§54) 19

First Chapter: Causes That Manifest Rulings (§55) 19

Second Chapter: What 'Validity' and 'Nullity' Signify in Rulings (§56) 19

Third Chapter: Describing Worship as Timely Performance, Make-Up Performance, and Repetition (§57) 20

Fourth Chapter: The Original Requirement and the Concession (§60) 21

Discussion of the Second Part of This Book (§62) **22**

The First Source (§63) 22

Discussion of the Second Source: The Sunna (§66) 23

First Chapter: The Legal Admissibility of Acting on a Solitary Report (§81) 26

Second Chapter: The Transmitter's Condition and Character (§83) 27

Third Chapter: Criticism of Transmitters and Attestation of Their Probity (§94) 29

First Section (§95) 29

Second Section: Stating the Grounds for Criticism and Attestation of Probity (§96) 29

Third Section: Attestation and Confirmation of Probity Themselves (§97) 29

Fourth Section: Attestation of the Companions' Probity, May God Be Pleased with Them (§98) 30

The First Level (§101) 30

The Second Level (§102) 30

The Third Level: Authorization (§103) 30

The Fourth Level: Handing Over a Written Text (§104) 30

The Fifth Level: Reliance on Handwriting (§105) 31

On the Abrogating and the Abrogated (§115) 34

On the Third Source of Proofs: Consensus (§130) 37

On the Fourth Source (§141) 40

On the Third Part of the Abridgment (§148) **42**

1. On Unambiguous and Indeterminate Wording in Respect of Verbal Form (§151) 42

2. On Apparent and Interpreted Wording in Respect of Verbal Form (§164) 45

3. On specific expressions (§191) 50

4. On expressions signifying through their understood meaning (§193) 51

5. On commands and prohibitions (§197) 52

6. On qiyās: analogy and syllogistic inference (§210) 55

7. On tacit approval (§227) 59

8. On action (§228) 59

Part Four (§230) **60**

Chapter One. On independent juristic inquiry (§231) 60

Chapter Two. On following authority (§249) 63

Section (§252) 64

Chapter Three. On weighing transmission routes (§256) 65

Later copyist's colophon and ownership notice **66**

Reference tools

Applications in the Bidāyat al-mujtahid 67

Subject index 73

Technical dictionary 89

Next: our numbered editorial section guide

Contents 2 · Editorial section guide

Our descriptive labels for all 258 numbered reading units. These are editorial reading aids, not headings in Ibn Rushd's text. The recorded parts and chapters appear in Contents 1; both lists lead to the same passages.

Introduction

1. Purpose, brevity, and the craft of legal reasoning 8
2. Three kinds of knowledge: belief, action, and rules of inquiry 8
3. Why later jurists need an explicit method 8
4. Implicit competence and induction from early legal opinions 8
5. The four parts of the discipline 9
6. The proper subject of uṣūl and a comparative method 9
7. Retaining al-Ghazālī's arrangement 9
8. The introductory questions a learner needs 9
9. Why the logical prolegomenon is omitted 9

Part I · Legal judgements

10. Definition, divisions, elements, and manifestation of rulings 10
11. Revealed judgement and intrinsic or relational goodness 10
12. Why general acceptance does not establish rational necessity 10
13. The obligation to inquire and the challenge to revealed authority 10
14. An objection from infinite regress 11
15. Miracles, assent, and necessary knowledge 11
16. The status of acts before revelation 11
17. The five rulings and the distinction between farḍ and wājib 11
18. Obligations with alternatives and extended times 12
19. Alternative duties, welfare, and divine foreknowledge 12
20. Legal examples suffice without resolving the metaphysics 12
21. When does an extended-time obligation become binding? 12
22. Intention distinguishes postponement from abandonment 12
23. Necessary means and the minimum sufficient performance 13
24. From definitions to universal questions 13
25. Death during the time and reasonable postponement 13
26. Abrogation of obligation and the logic of opposites. 13
27. Is the permissible commanded or legally burdensome? 14
28. Can one act be obligatory and forbidden in different respects? 14
29. Prohibitive wording versus a qualified prohibition's meaning 14
30. A methodological objection to the placement of the question 14
31. Forbidden places of prayer and prayer on usurped land 15
32. Does a ruling about an act determine its contrary? .. 15
33. Legal contrariety versus physical incompatibility 15
34. When prohibiting one contrary obliges the other 15
35. Conclusion of the classification of rulings 15
36. The three elements of a legal judgement 15
37. Divine authority and delegated human obedience ... 16
38. Understanding the address: children and impaired reason 16
39. A defective reading about partial intoxication 16
40. Addressing the sober about later intoxication 16
41. Eternal command and the limits of the present discipline 16
42. Puberty as a practical legal sign 16
43. The voluntary act and intention of obedience 16
44. Choice, necessary assent, and the will to obey 17
45. Human agency and the impossibility of burdens beyond capacity 17
46. Further questions concerning responsible action 17
47. Coercion, intention, and degrees of harm 17
48. Active restraint and mere non-performance 18
49. Commands before fulfilment of their conditions 18
50. Legal conditions are not conditions of physical possibility 18
51. Conversion, apostasy, and a distinct command to make up acts 19
52. No demand to combine or abandon exhaustive contraries 19
53. Hard cases: usurped fields and unavoidable injury ... 19
54. Manifesting causes and the attributes of rulings 19
55. Legal signs and perceptible causes 19
56. Validity in worship and the validity of contracts 19
57. Timely performance, repetition, and making up 20
58. The traveller's fast: concession or an alternative duty? 20
59. Does an expectation of death shorten the prescribed time? 20
60. Original requirements and concessions under necessity 21
61. The first part concluded 21

Part II · Sources of proof

62. The four sources and original negation 22
63. Divine speech and the bounds of theological inquiry 22
64. The Qurʾānic corpus, variant additions, and the basmala 22
65. Literal, figurative, arabicized, and ambiguous expressions 23
66. The authority of the Sunna and the routes of transmission 23
67. First rank: explicit attestation of direct hearing 23
68. Second rank: "The Messenger said" 23
69. Third rank: reporting a command rather than its wording 23

70. How linguistic usage is established 24
71. Fourth rank: “We were commanded” and “It is Sunna” 24
72. Fifth rank: practices in the Prophet’s lifetime 24
73. The reporting formulas concluded 24
74. The degrees of assent yielded by transmission 24
75. Recurrent transmission: certainty without a fixed number 24
76. How premises produce assent, even when unarticulated 25
77. Sensory actuality, contextual evidence, and common legal knowledge 25
78. The conditions of certainty from mass transmission 25
79. Can a solitary report ever produce certainty? 26
80. Four questions governing solitary reports 26
81. The rational and legal warrant for acting on a solitary report 26
82. Does the command to warn establish the duty to accept a report? 26
83. One transmitter need not satisfy the numerical rules of testimony 27
84. Hearing in childhood and transmitting after puberty 27
85. Accurate retention, religious identity, and transmission 27
86. Probity as a disposition rather than a mere label 27
87. How much moral integrity must a transmitter possess? 28
88. Unknown character and the presumption of trustworthiness 28
89. The Bedouin’s crescent testimony and an uncertain printed reading 28
90. Probity aims at probable truthfulness, not an arbitrary threshold 28
91. Wrongdoing based on interpretation and the acceptance of reports 28
92. Probable wrongdoing: the example of disputed nabīdh 28
93. Minimum conditions differ from grounds of preference 29
94. Four questions about criticism and attestation 29
95. How many people must attest a narrator’s probity? . 29
96. Stating grounds and resolving conflicting evaluations 29
97. What conduct counts as an attestation of probity? ... 29
98. The majority position on the Companions’ probity ... 30
99. The civil wars and interpretive error 30
100. Five levels of receiving a report 30
101. Hearing the teacher read 30
102. Reading before a silent teacher 30
103. Authorization without a reading 30
104. Handing over a book with permission to transmit it 30
105. Handwriting, accurate copies, and acting without direct hearing 31
106. The narrator’s certainty is not the recipient’s probability 31
107. When a teacher denies or forgets a report 31
108. An addition reported by one reliable narrator 31
109. Reporting meaning: synonymy and translation 32
110. Why an independent jurist needs the Lawgiver’s wording 32
111. Omitted links, connected chains, and “from” formulae 32
112. Solitary reports concerning matters of widespread need 33
113. Neither universal acceptance nor universal rejection is justified 33
114. Both Qurʾān and Sunna are subject to abrogation .. 34
115. Does abrogation remove a ruling or reveal its time limit? 34
116. What the jurist needs to know about abrogation 34
117. Removing a part, a condition, or a recommended observance 34
118. When an addition changes the identity of an obligation 35
119. Abrogation without a substitute 35
120. Replacing a lighter duty with a heavier one 35
121. Abrogating recitation, ruling, or both—and the demand for proof 35
122. Consensus reveals earlier abrogation but cannot itself abrogate 36
123. The unequal force of reports during and after the Prophet’s life 36
124. May mass-transmitted Sunna abrogate the Qurʾān? 36
125. Certainty itself can admit degrees 36
126. Analogy may clarify a text but may not repeal it 37
127. A Companion’s assertion of abrogation needs a transmitted basis 37
128. Conditions implicit in the definition of abrogation .. 37
129. How the later of two conflicting texts is established 37
130. Consensus as certainty beyond surviving explicit texts 37
131. Cumulative scriptural evidence for the authority of consensus 38
132. Why consensus is not merely a rational inference from numbers 38
133. Why lay agreement adds no independent proof 38
134. All qualified jurists of one age, not every age 38
135. Can later agreement override an earlier disagreement? 39
136. Why the Ẓāhirīs restrict consensus to the Companions 39
137. Unanimity, majority, and the evidential limits of silence 39
138. Medinan practice must be traced as transmission .. 39
139. Must an agreeing generation die out before consensus binds? 40
140. The essential account is enough to understand further objections 40
141. Original freedom from liability and the burden of proof 40
142. Five forms of continuity and the problem of a changed subject 40
143. Conclusion of the four sources 41

144. A Companion’s opinion attracts weight but is not infallible ... 41
145. Earlier revealed laws are not an independent source ... 41
146. Preference and welfare require a recognized legal warrant ... 41
147. Conclusion of Part Two ... 41

Part III · Meaning and inference

148. The distinctive task: understanding prophetic indications ... 42
149. Verbal form and intelligible import ... 42
150. Action and approval as nonverbal indications ... 42
151. Four classes of verbal indication ... 42
152. Simple expressions, compounds, and complete utterances ... 42
153. Original assignment, transfer, and specialized legal usage ... 42
154. Omission, addition, and substitution in figurative speech ... 43
155. Clarity and obscurity arise from meaning as well as form ... 43
156. A classification useful for legal inference ... 43
157. Unambiguous expressions and determinate pronoun reference ... 43
158. Equivocation: qurʾ, ʿayn, and the marriage bond ... 43
159. Clarification encompasses every valid means of understanding ... 43
160. May clarification be delayed when action is required? ... 43
161. How speakers rely on context and hearers seek clarification ... 44
162. A figurative meaning needs an intelligible indication ... 44
163. Partial knowledge can precede a more specific explanation ... 44
164. Transfer through resemblance, relation, and indirect expression ... 45
165. Substituting a universal for a particular, or the reverse ... 45
166. Why apparent meanings bind and interpretation needs proportionate proof ... 45
167. Three degrees: clothing, the balance, and touching women ... 46
168. Established usage, ambiguity, and certain interpretation ... 46
169. General meaning is a real feature of language ... 46
170. Forms of generality and their unequal apparent force ... 46
171. A remote restriction of the guardian-permission report ... 47
172. Restricting the requirement of a nightly fasting intention ... 47
173. Does the tithe report include vegetables? ... 47
174. General wording with a known or unknown specific intention ... 47
175. Disputed boundaries of generality ... 47
176. A particular occasion does not confine a general answer ... 47
177. Equivocation is not the generality of a universal ... 47
178. Who is included by “people” and by a masculine plural? ... 48
179. Can a plural be restricted below its minimum? ... 48
180. Three is the normal plural; two or one requires a clue ... 48
181. Specification or contradiction? The importance of chronology ... 48
182. Specific evidence can govern without a known chronological order ... 48
183. Why an exception must accompany its statement ... 49
184. Connected and disconnected exceptions; one or several sentences ... 49
185. How can an exception belong to another genus? ... 49
186. A disconnected exception belongs to the understood wider meaning ... 49
187. How far does an exception reach over coordinated clauses? ... 50
188. An exception larger than the remainder ... 50
189. Unqualified and qualified wording in the same or different contexts ... 50
190. From general to specific expressions ... 50
191. Specific expressions may stand for an intended universal ... 50
192. From verbal form to understood meaning ... 51
193. Context determines the force of an implied meaning ... 51
194. Omitted meanings: villagers, marriage, fasting, and a prayer cycle ... 51
195. Description, condition, restriction, and endpoint ... 52
196. From assertions to prescriptions ... 52
197. Command, request, and supplication depend on the relation of speakers ... 52
198. Questions about obligation, timing, and repetition ... 53
199. Linguistic convention and legal usage must be distinguished ... 53
200. The imperative’s legal force must be learned from revelation ... 53
201. Neither timing nor repetition follows from the form alone ... 53
202. Further questions about command forms ... 54
203. A command after prohibition may merely remove the restriction ... 54
204. Does making up a timed observance need a new command? ... 54
205. Compliance discharges a duty only when all its conditions are met ... 54
206. Does prohibition entail invalidity? ... 54
207. Returning to the earlier account of the forbidden ... 54
208. Absolute prohibition and dislike: the need for an indication ... 54
209. From commands to the contextual indications called qiyās ... 55
210. The jurists’ definition of analogy: original, derivative and ground ... 55
211. Nonexistence, negation and the scope of the definition ... 55
212. Most legal qiyās is substitution within an understood meaning ... 55

213. What warrants substitution: relevant contextual indications ... 56
214. Certain, probable and indeterminate extensions ... 56
215. The stronger case: a fortiori indication ... 56
216. Equal extension: the legal meaning beyond a named individual ... 56
217. Suitable grounds, recognised goods and the limit of legislation ... 56
218. Resemblance and uncertainty about the operative ground ... 57
219. Analogy in fixed penalties and expiations ... 57
220. Testing, division and concomitance ... 57
221. Eliminating candidates for the universal meaning ... 57
222. Positive and negative concomitance are not enough ... 57
223. Why much juristic qiyās is not a syllogism ... 58
224. Meaning can be apparent without an apparent verbal form ... 58
225. The disputed claim of Companion consensus on qiyās ... 58
226. The class and limits of qiyās; action and approval remain ... 59
227. What tacit approval establishes ... 59
228. Actions that explain a revealed command ... 59
229. Peculiar, unexplained and conflicting Prophetic actions ... 59

Part IV · Juristic reasoning

230. Inquiry, authority and weighing evidence ... 60
231. The jurist, the question and the act of inquiry ... 60
232. How much Qurʾānic knowledge is required? ... 60
233. Hadith competence, collections and transmitter evaluation ... 60
234. Consensus and the indispensable knowledge of Arabic ... 60
235. Theology and detailed fiqh: what is actually required? ... 60
236. Issue-specific independent inquiry ... 61
237. Is there a determinate ruling to be found? ... 61
238. Essential attributes, Ẓāhirī restraint and determinate rulings ... 61
239. Ibn Rushd's answer: discourse determines the ruling ... 61
240. Al-Ghazālī's first argument for universal correctness ... 61
241. Evidence signifies; inclination does not make a ruling ... 62
242. Al-Ghazālī's second argument: absence of sin ... 62
243. An error can be pardoned without becoming correct ... 62
244. Degrees of culpability and the clarity of evidence ... 62
245. Attainable truth and merciful pardon ... 62
246. Conflict: suspension, caution or free choice? ... 62
247. The Ẓāhirī response: return to original nonliability ... 63
248. From independent inquiry to following authority ... 63
249. Trust, probability and following the Prophet ... 63
250. Why juristic expertise is a collective obligation ... 63
251. May a mujtahid follow a more knowledgeable jurist? ... 64
252. Memorised school doctrine is not an independent source ... 64
253. Why inherited opinions cannot replace living inquiry ... 64
254. No period should lack an active mujtahid ... 64
255. The valid and invalid uses of following authority ... 64
256. Why an exhaustive catalogue of preferences is unnecessary ... 65
257. The obligation to follow the stronger judgement ... 65
258. An abridgement completed and supplemented: 552 AH ... 65
Later copyist's colophon ... 66

Opening discussion

R 1 · BA 1

To proceed, after praising God, who teaches articulate expression[1], makes inquiry (النظر) and inference (الاستدلال) obligatory, and singles out the human being for establishing conclusive arguments[2] and setting forth examples; and after invoking blessings upon Muḥammad, the seal of the messengers[3] and the culmination of completeness and perfection: my purpose in this book is to set down for myself, as a reminder, a sufficient account of what is necessary in this craft (الصناعة), drawn from Abū Ḥāmid's book on the principles of jurisprudence entitled al-Mustaṣfā—may God have mercy upon him. In doing so we shall seek the briefest and most concise expression, and what seems to us most technically appropriate to this disciplined art. Before this, let us offer a useful introduction concerning the purpose and benefit of the knowledge sought here. We say:

R 2 · BA 2

Forms of knowledge and the sciences are of three kinds. There is knowledge whose end is simply the belief it produces in the soul: for example, knowledge that the world has come into being, the doctrine of the indivisible part, and similar matters. There is knowledge whose end is action. Some of this is universal (كلية), and its benefit for action is indirect, while another part is particular (جزئية) and its benefit for action is more direct. Particular knowledge includes knowledge of the rulings governing prayer and almsgiving, and similar particular obligatory and customary observances. Universal knowledge includes knowledge of the principles on which these branches are built—the Book, the Sunna, and consensus—and knowledge of the rulings derived from these principles in general, their divisions, and what attaches to them insofar as they are rulings (أحكام).

There is also knowledge that provides the rules and conditions through which the mind is guided towards correctness in these two forms of knowledge: for example, knowledge of indications (الدلائل) and their divisions, of the conditions under which they are indications and those under which they are not, and of the cases in which the passage from the observed to the unobserved is employed and those in which it is not. Let us call this a probe and a rule. Its relation to the mind is like that of the compass and straightedge to sense perception in matters where error cannot be ruled out.

R 3 · BA 3

It is clear that the more ramified the sciences become, and the more those investigating them must resort, in order to apprehend them, to matters to which their predecessors did not have to resort, the greater their need for rules that protect their minds during inquiry.

It is also clear that the craft called jurisprudence (الفقه), both at present and in the past since the death of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—the dispersal of his Companions through the lands, and the divergence of what was transmitted from him—God bless him and grant him peace—exhibits these two conditions. For this reason the Companions—may God be pleased with them—had no need of this craft, just as the Bedouin Arabs had no need of rules to protect them in their speech or their metres.

R 4 · BA 4

What we have said makes the purpose of this craft intelligible and disposes of the objection that the people of the earliest generation did not investigate it. We do not, however, deny that they employed its capacity: you can discern this from their legal opinions—may God be pleased with them. Indeed, many of the universal notions (المعاني الكلية) laid down in this craft were established only by induction (الاستقراء) from their legal opinions, case by case.

1. Cf. Qurʾān, al-Raḥmān 55:4 ↗.
2. Cf. Qurʾān, al-Anʿām 6:149 ↗. Compare the verse's singular al-ḥujja al-bāligha with the author's plural expression.
3. Cf. Qurʾān, al-Aḥzāb 33:40 ↗. The verse has "seal of the prophets"; this is an allusion, not its exact wording.

R 5 · BA 5

The parts of this craft, according to its division in this book, are four. The first part comprises inquiry into rulings (الأحكام); the second, into the sources of rulings; the third, into the proofs (الأدلة) employed to derive each ruling from its respective source, and how they are employed. The fourth comprises inquiry into the qualifications of the practitioner of independent judgement (المجتهد), who is the jurist.

R 6 · BA 5–7

From our preceding account of the purpose of this craft and the genus of sciences to which it belongs, you know that its proper inquiry lies only in the third part of this book. The other parts belong to the kind of knowledge whose end is action. Hence they named this craft after some of what they made a part of it, calling it 'the principles of jurisprudence' (أصول الفقه). Inquiry conducted according to the requirements of the craft demands that this third part receive a separate treatment, since it differs in genus from those other parts, and that, concerning those, one of two courses alone be adopted. Either they should be posited according to the most widely accepted doctrines concerning them—for example, the views of the People of the Sunna.

Or the disagreements concerning them should be outlined and enumerated, and the conditions and rules provided through which rulings are derived according to each opinion about those principles. This would explain, generally, how some of those opinions follow from others and how they correspond to the branches: one would explain, for example, how derivation proceeds according to the Ẓāhirīs (أهل الظاهر, commonly called Literalists) and according to those who affirm analogy (القياس)—in general, according to each of the widely accepted opinions. This course is more useful in this craft. Through such inquiry this kind of knowledge would possess a craft that is complete, universal, and sufficient for the inquiry of all who practise independent judgement (الاجتهاد).

R 7 · BA 8

We have nevertheless decided to follow the customary practice of those who discuss this craft and, in dividing it, to seek the arrangement found in this book, since it is the best considered and the most likely to conform to the requirements of the craft. We shall, however, indicate something of that purpose.

R 8 · BA 9

Our preceding account makes clear this book's purpose, its relation to the other sciences, its rank, what its name signifies, and its divisions. These are the general matters that it is useful to present to the learner when beginning the craft. Let us begin where he began.

R 9 · BA 10

Before this, Abū Ḥāmid placed a logical introduction. He stated that he was led to discuss it by the inquiry of those treating this craft into certain logical matters, such as their inquiry into the definition of knowledge and other things. For our part, let us leave each thing to its proper place. Anyone who attempts to learn more than one thing at a time will be unable to learn even one of them.

Part I

Discussion of the First Part of This Book

R 10 · BA 11

This first part is divided into four parts: inquiry into the definition of a ruling (الحكم), its divisions, its constituent elements, and what manifests it.

First Section

R 11 · BA 12–14

According to the People of the Sunna, a ruling (الحكم) is defined as the address of the Law (خطاب الشرع) when it concerns the acts of legally responsible persons by requiring an act or its omission. Where this address has not occurred, no characterization as good or bad attaches to acts; on this account, goodness and badness are not intrinsic attributes of acts.

The Muʿtazilites held that goodness and badness are intrinsic attributes of acts. Some are apprehended through rational necessity, as with lying and thanking a benefactor; others, with the Law's assistance, as with ritual purification and prayer, because of, for example, the utterance that restrains indecency[4] and the cleanliness they involve. The benefit of knowing this disagreement within this craft becomes apparent when investigating analogy from a suitable, plausible ground (القياس المناسب والمخيل), with all its kinds, and when investigating whether those exercising independent judgement are correct or mistaken.

The argument of the People of the Sunna is that ‘good’ and ‘bad’ have several meanings in the usage of speakers. The first and most familiar is what accords with or opposes the purpose of the person judging it good: one person, for instance, may find a dark complexion good and another find it bad. This is a relational matter, unlike the blackness and whiteness belonging to things in themselves. The second is what the Law has declared good or bad. The third meaning of ‘good’ is what a person is permitted to do. All these are relational, not intrinsic, attributes. This means that goodness and badness have no existence ‘outside the concrete entity.’

R 12 · BA 15

The Muʿtazilites, for their part, argued that goodness and badness are intrinsic attributes of things from the agreement of rational persons in affirming them without qualification by a relation—for example, the goodness of truthfulness and the badness of lying; in general, from these propositions' being widely accepted and agreed upon. It is evident that intelligible matters may also happen to be widely accepted, but that the converse does not hold.

R 13 · BA 16–17

Discussion of this question does not belong to the science with which we are engaged. Neither of these two arguments seems sufficient to settle it. The Muʿtazilites argued that obligation in certain matters—thanking a benefactor and the like—is apprehended by reason. Restricting its apprehension to the Law would leave the messengers unable to answer when they call people to inquiry (النظر). Unless we know that inquiry is obligatory, we shall not inquire; unless we inquire, we shall not establish the Lawgiver's claim concerning that to which he calls us; and unless we establish his claim, there is no way to believe what he calls us to. Whether what we are called to is true in itself or not, on this account there is no way for us to attain knowledge of it.

4. Cf. Qurʾān, al-ʿAnkabūt 29:45 ↗. The verse speaks of prayer restraining indecency; the author’s wording is retained.

R 14 · BA 18

The theologians pressed a difficulty upon the Muʿtazilites concerning their claim that the obligation to inquire is apprehended rationally. If this obligation is rationally apprehended, that must be either necessarily or through acquisition. If necessarily, no one would be heedless of the knowledge of God. If acquired by inquiry, the question turns back upon them: how is the obligation to undertake the inquiry leading to the obligation to inquire into the Law's claim apprehended? And so on without end.

R 15 · BA 19

What should be said here, in my judgement, is that assent (التصديق) to the Lawgiver's claim when a miracle appears in accordance with it belongs to the kind of necessary knowledge. Assent arises necessarily from witnessing this, or through the miracle's being established by recurrent transmission (تواتر). The question whether inquiry is obligatory or not arises only where knowledge is gained through inquiry and inference (النظر والاستدلال). Straining after any further account here merely confuses beliefs or causes needless trouble. If each person called to the Law were to take upon himself such difficulties when considering what the Law calls him to, the faith of many people would never arise, or would arise only rarely.

In general, God's calling people to faith in the Law by such paths would, for most people, amount to imposing what is beyond their capacity. That knowledge of this is necessary does not entail that no one can fail to acknowledge it. Just as being necessary is not a condition of what is agreed upon, so being agreed upon is not a condition of what is necessary. None of this belongs to the present science.

R 16 · BA 20

Those Muʿtazilites who held that acts are permissible before the advent of the Law intended by this only acts concerning which reason judges neither goodness nor badness. Those among them who spoke of suspension of judgement seem to me to have had in view acts whose goodness or badness is apprehended only when the Law is joined to reason, as previously stated among their opinions. As for those who say that acts are prohibited before the advent of the Law, this assertion has no meaning and is manifestly untenable in itself.

Discussion of the Second Section of the First Part

R 17 · BA 21–24

This section comprises inquiry into the divisions of rulings (الأحكام), their definitions, and questions attaching to them. We say: the ruling whose description was given above is divided into a demand to act, a demand to omit, or a choice between the two; the last is called permissible (مباح). The demand to act is divided into obligation and recommendation; omission, into prohibition and disapproval.

The obligatory (الواجب) is defined as that whose performance the address of the Law prefers, with a threat of punishment for omitting it insofar as this constitutes its unqualified omission. We added ‘with a threat of punishment for omitting it’ because, according to the People of the Sunna, obligation cannot be conceived apart from harm or benefit. We further added ‘insofar as this constitutes its unqualified omission’ as a precaution concerning an obligation that permits a choice.

The threat of punishment may be established with certainty or by probable judgement (ظنا). Abū Ḥanīfa's followers reserve the name farḍ for the first and wājib for the second. There is no dispute over names once their meanings are understood.

The recommended (الندب) is defined as that whose performance is preferred without a threat of punishment for its omission. From the definition of the obligatory we apprehend that of the prohibited, its opposite; likewise, from that of the recommended we apprehend that of the disapproved. The permissible is that concerning which the Law indicates equality between performance and omission. This occurs either through an address allowing a choice between them, through removal of blame from both, or through a rational indication that original freedom from liability (البراءة الأصلية) remains because there is no legal proof attaching a ruling to it, as will be explained later.

Chapter

R 18 · BA 25

The obligatory is divided into what is determinate and what allows a choice among a limited set of alternatives, either concerning the act or concerning the time. They call an obligation whose act is not fixed, but admits a limited set of alternatives, an obligation allowing a choice (الواجب المخير); one whose time is not fixed, an obligation with an extended time (الواجب الموسع).

R 19 · BA 26

The Muʿtazilites denied both the rational possibility of such an obligation and its occurrence in the Law. They said: if the three alternatives in expiation are equal in their character with respect to the servant's welfare, all ought to be made obligatory because they are equally conducive to it. This is based on their doctrine of welfare and the best possible welfare.

Yet, even if this principle were granted, the contrary of what they posit would follow: if each alternative equals the others in bringing about welfare, employing all of them is pointless, as is selecting one particular alternative; and they do not allow such purposelessness in God. They appear not to have guarded their own principles in this question. They also argued that God's knowledge concerns the alternative the servant will perform, which is therefore necessarily determinate in itself; no choice is conceivable in such a case.

R 20 · BA 27

Discussion of this question does not belong to the science with which we are engaged. Here it is enough to say that such a thing does occur in the Law, as with the alternatives in expiation and the established consensus that most prayers have extended performance periods. The Muʿtazilites are bound to encounter the same difficulty they raised here in the case of the permissible. In general, this objection attaches to the possible insofar as it is possible.

R 21 · BA 28–29

Some jurists rejected calling such a thing obligatory. They said that, with respect to time, it is characterized by obligation only at the end of the period, since punishment attaches to failing to perform the prayer then. At the beginning of the period, however, they call it recommended, since omitting the prayer at that point incurs no penalty. A similar objection applies to an obligation offering a choice: no individual alternative can be considered obligatory, as the final moment of the prayer period can, unless the other two alternatives become unavailable; only then does the obligation of the third become conceivable. What should be said of such a case is that it resembles obligation in one respect and recommendation in another. Its resemblance to obligation lies in the discharge of the duty by praying at the beginning of the period; its resemblance to recommendation is that mentioned in the objection.

R 22 · BA 29

This dispute is verbal; hence it was called an obligation with an extended time. It also differs from recommendation in that its omission is allowed only on condition of resolving to perform it while mindful of it, since resolving to omit it altogether is forbidden.

Chapter

R 23 · BA 30–31

They likewise disagreed whether that without which an obligation cannot be fulfilled should itself be called obligatory. The proper account is that this is divided into what the servant has no choice in producing—for example, the capacity to walk—which is not characterized as obligatory but is a condition of imposing an obligation; and what the servant can produce by choice, which should be characterized as obligatory, such as the ritual purity required for prayer. The obligation of such a thing seems to be for the sake of something else, not for its own sake. Another division of the obligatory therefore emerges: some things are obligatory for the sake of something else, and some are obligatory in themselves.

The obligatory is also divided into what is measured by a determinate amount and what is not, such as wiping the head and remaining still in bowing. In the latter case, the obligatory amount is the least to which the name applies; what remains is recommended. This is conceivable only for acts occurring successively or following one upon another—in general, where their parts do not occur simultaneously.

R 24 · BA 32

Such is the account of the definition and division of the kinds of rulings (الأحكام). There remains the discussion of universal questions attaching to them.

R 25 · BA 33

The first question is this. If the legally responsible person dies during the allotted period without having discharged the duty, he does not die disobedient: the early generations agreed on this. Whoever declares him sinful is mistaken, for we know with certainty that they did not declare sinful someone who died after enough time had elapsed to perform the prayer.

If it is asked how omission with a resolve to act can be allowed when he does not know whether the outcome will be safe, we answer: such omission is allowed only until a time he judges it more probable than not that he will survive to, just as one administering discretionary punishment may strike up to a point at which death is not the predominant probability. Hence Abū Ḥanīfa—may God have mercy upon him—said that pilgrimage may not be postponed for a year, since survival until then is not predominantly probable; fasting and almsgiving, however, may be postponed for one or two months. Al-Shāfiʿī—may God have mercy upon him—regards survival for a year as predominantly probable for young people.

Second Question

R 26 · BA 34

Rulings are divided, as previously explained, into the obligatory and, at the opposite extreme, the prohibited, which is the forbidden. Between them lie two intermediates: the recommended and the disapproved. It is clear that where opposites admit an intermediate, removing one does not entail the existence of the other. Whoever claimed that when obligation is abrogated a thing returns to its previous prohibition was therefore mistaken. That would follow only if there were no intermediate between the obligatory and the forbidden. More evident still [is the error of supposing] that it returns to its previous permissibility, since permissibility is not contained within the genus of these opposites, namely demand (الطلب).

R 27 · BA 35

Here the untenability of the claim that the permissible is commanded becomes clear. It is likewise clear that it does not belong to the imposition of legal responsibility (التكليف), since this is the demand for something involving a burden. Whoever calls it an imposition of responsibility, meaning that we are obliged to believe it permissible in the Law or obliged to believe that it belongs to the Law, strains the terminology. In general, this is a linguistic inquiry more suited to another place. The preceding account also makes clear that the recommended is commanded, since it involves a certain demand and requisition. As for the claim that ‘command’ applies only where omission incurs punishment, that is a linguistic claim; its proponent must establish it through either legal usage or linguistic convention.

Third Question: The Forbidden Is the Contrary of the Obligatory

R 28 · BA 36–37

If contraries are defined as two things that cannot coexist in one numerically identical thing, at one time and in one respect, then prohibition and obligation cannot in the Law attach to one thing in one respect at one time. Their attachment to two things or at two times is, however, undisputed; prohibiting one does not invalidate the other, whether the distinction concerns two things or two times. The same must hold when prohibition and obligation attach to one thing in two respects—for example, when something is commanded without qualification, and then that very thing is prohibited as qualified by an attribute or on account of an expressly stated cause.

In cases of this kind, however, they disagreed whether the prohibition invalidates the originally obligatory act insofar as it is qualified. Abū Ḥāmid—may God have mercy upon him—stated that they divide this into what concerns something other than the prohibited act, owing to an external cause, and what concerns an attribute of the thing itself. What concerns something other than the prohibited act does not invalidate the original act. Concerning what relates to an attribute of the prohibited act, al-Shāfiʿī held that it invalidates the original act; where he gave effect to divorce during menstruation, he referred the prohibition to the infliction of harm and included it in the first division.

Abū Ḥanīfa does not consider the prohibition to invalidate the original act in either case, whether the prohibited act is qualified by an attribute or by an external cause. He held that ritual impurity's invalidation of prayer was established only by the proof of consensus.

R 29 · BA 38

I consider that inquiry into this question concerns only the verbal form of prohibition. For one who understands the form of prohibition to signify that an act is forbidden, a prohibition applying to that act under a particular qualification, after its unconditional obligation has been established, is a contextual indicator (qarīna) that turns the apparent prohibition from strict forbiddance into disapproval. This is more clearly so if a prohibition attaches to the act on account of some external matter after the act has been enjoined without qualification. We shall discuss this later.

If, however, the question is considered from the standpoint of meaning, prohibiting a thing as qualified by some matter—whether a cause or an attribute—after making it obligatory without qualification invalidates the original act insofar as it is qualified. Precisely what you have understood here concerning a qualified prohibition issued after an unqualified obligation should be understood concerning a qualified obligation issued after an unqualified prohibition.

R 30 · BA 38

It is surprising that Abū Ḥāmid treated inquiry into this question as belonging to this part of this book.

R 31 · BA 39–40

Whoever permits prayer in a valley, a bathhouse, or camels' resting places should interpret the prohibition concerning these as disapproval rather than forbiddance, following the doctrine that prohibiting something as qualified by an external matter, after permitting or commanding it without qualification, supplies a contextual indicator shifting the expression of prohibition from forbiddance to disapproval. This applies if he holds that the form of prohibition entails forbiddance. For someone who does not hold this, the matter is easy.

Whoever invalidates prayer on usurped land because it consists of prohibited movements and spatial positions does so through ignorance of the definitions of contraries: obligation and prohibition attach to it in two different respects. That is why the Companions—may God be pleased with them—agreed not to command wrongdoers to repeat their prayers upon repentance. These movements and spatial positions are commanded in one respect and prohibited in another. Similarly, prostration before an idol without intending [worship of it] is forbidden in one respect and an act of drawing near [to God] in another.

Fourth Question

R 32 · BA 41

People have disagreed whether making something obligatory prohibits its contrary, and whether prohibiting it makes its contrary obligatory. We say:

R 33 · BA 41

As for when the two contraries are defined according to their proper definition and the term is not used loosely, making a thing obligatory prohibits its contrary. For, as previously explained, whatever is indispensable to fulfilling an obligation is obligatory, whether it is an act or an omission. This question is conceivable only in legal contrariety (التضاد الشرعي). As for perceptible contrariety, abandoning the contrary is indispensable for the imposition of responsibility to be possible: it belongs to the conditions of the act.

R 34 · BA 42

As for the prohibited, if it has no contrary, or has a contrary but admits an intermediate between them, prohibiting it does not entail making anything obligatory. If, however, the thing cannot be without one of the two and there is no intermediate between them, prohibiting it makes its contrary obligatory. This too applies where the contrariety is legal; if it is perceptible, it belongs to the conditions of legal responsibility.

R 35 · BA 43

This is how the question and its answer should be interpreted. Here the discussion of the second section of this part ends.

Discussion of the Third Section of the First Part

R 36 · BA 44

This section comprises inquiry into the constituent elements of a ruling (الحكم). They are three: the one who rules, the person subject to the ruling, and that concerning which the ruling is made.

R 37 · BA 45

The one who rules is the speaker whose address imposes obligation. In addition to being a speaker, he must possess unrestricted authority for the ruling to take effect. This holds only between owner and owned, creator and created; the ruler is God Most High. Everyone whose obedience is obligatory—the ruler, the father, and the like—is owed obedience only because God Most High has made it obligatory. He has the power to punish and reward, since obligation or prohibition cannot be conceived as proceeding from one without power over them. This is established in theology (علم الكلام).

R 38 · BA 46–48

Two conditions apply to the addressee; one is understanding the address containing a command or prohibition, since an obligatory demand cannot properly be directed to someone who does not understand the address. If it is objected that alms and financial liabilities have been imposed upon children, we answer: the legally responsible person is the guardian, subject to readiness to receive reason. Likewise, in requiring children to pray before puberty, it is the father who is commanded. For only one who knows the Lawgiver (الشارع) understands the Law's address, and only one who knows God knows the Lawgiver. This condition is apprehended by reason.

From this it becomes clear that legal responsibility lapses for the forgetful, the heedless, the insane, and the intoxicated. If it is asked why an intoxicated person's divorce takes effect according to those who allow it, we answer that this is a measure of severity: he has brought the harm upon himself by his own choice, after [possessing] reason, the condition of legal responsibility. Such a case cannot be conceived for an insane person. As for appealing, in support of the possibility of addressing the intoxicated, to His words—blessed and exalted is He—'Do not approach prayer while you are intoxicated'[5]: even if this apparent meaning is conceded in the verse, apparent meanings (الظواهر) are not set against certainties. The verse admits interpretations:

R 39 · BA 48

One interpretation is that the address is directed to a person in the early stages of intoxication.

R 40 · BA 48

Another is that what was prohibited was excessive drinking at the times of prayer: the address was issued while the hearers were in a sound state, before wine was prohibited.

R 41 · BA 49

They append the objection: how can God eternally command His servants, when a condition of commanding is that the commanded person exist? Similarly, how can He command the intoxicated while intoxicated, or the insane and the child, on condition that the first recover consciousness, the second become sound, and the third reach puberty? An answer is not possible in this place, nor is the question peculiar to this inquiry. Discussing it rests on principles requiring lengthy preparation and extensive examination. As we have said, we should not investigate everything, or many things, in a single place; each should receive its own treatment in the place appropriate to it. What prompts this practice is a love of multiplying material that serves no purpose.

R 42 · BA 50

The second condition is puberty, and this condition is apprehended through the Law. If it is asked whether a boy is not rational shortly before his first nocturnal emission, since the emission of semen does not add to his reason, we answer: because the attainment of reason is difficult to discern in each individual and its timing varies, the Law appointed a sign that indicates it in most cases.

R 43 · BA 51

That concerning which the ruling is made, namely the act, is what can be acquired by the servant through his choice, while believing that its acquisition is obedience and compliance.

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5. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:43 ↗.

R 44 · BA 51–53

It should be understood that the things a human being acquires are those in which he may perform whichever of two contraries he wishes: standing, for example, is acquired by him, and he may stand or sit. If this is the meaning of acquisition (الاكتساب), there is no point in their purported exception for the obligation of inquiry that leads to knowledge, on the ground that one cannot intend to perform it as obedience before knowing it to be obligatory. For, as we have said, the obligation to inquire arises necessarily because the object of inquiry is necessarily known. A person has no choice in assenting to its obligatoriness when the miracle appears.

Nor is there any point in their exception for the will to obey, or their saying that if willing required a will, that will would require another will, producing an infinite regress. Will is desire (شوق), and the arising of desire in a human being is something like a necessary occurrence, since its producer is assent involving hope and fear. Thus the condition of a legally prescribed act is, first, that it be acquired; and second, that the cause in acquiring [the act] be belief in the command's obligatoriness, [rather than] other things he may do.

R 45 · BA 54–55

For the shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan, however, being acquired is not a condition of an act. He holds that there is no act acquired by the human being at all: what makes the human being appear to be an agent of something is an accompanying and incidental matter, without the human being being either its proximate or its remote cause. Thus, for example, the relation of someone with two feet to walking would be exactly that of someone without feet. This contradicts sense perception and is a view exceedingly foreign to human nature. Abū al-Maʿālī, in al-Risāla al-Niẓāmiyya, explained the respect in which one may properly say, within the Law, that human beings possess capacity and acquisition (اقتدارا واكتسابا).

Whoever denies human beings capacity for anything allows the imposition of what is beyond their capacity; he is right to do so on his own account, since on his view nothing is within their capacity. What we should say here is that imposing what is beyond capacity is impossible both rationally and legally. Legally, because of His saying, 'God charges no soul beyond its capacity.'[6] Rationally, because the impossible cannot be present in the soul, and because a condition of what is commanded is that it be understood and its possibility conceived by both the commander and the commanded.

R 46 · BA 56

Several questions may be appended to the end of this part:

R 47 · BA 57–58

One question is whether someone coerced into compliance with, or violation of, a legal requirement (التكليف) acts by choice, so as to be rewarded for the one and punished for the other. We say: someone coerced into compliance may reasonably be thought to act by choice insofar as he can do otherwise and endure the means of coercion. This varies with the harm inflicted upon him. Yet if he does not perform the act believing it to be obedience and compliance, he receives no reward; if he does believe this, he is rewarded. Even when coercion initially moves him to act, if, upon undertaking the act, he believes its performance to be obedience, he is rewarded.

It is in this respect that coercing unbelievers to faith by [the threat of] killing occurs in the Law. In general, threatening punishment is a kind of coercion in this respect. Such a case is conceivable when obstinacy or some other impediment prevents a person from complying. In general, the soul that commands evil[7] often turns a person away from a duty even while he believes it obligatory.

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6. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:286 ↗.
7. Cf. Qurʾān, Yūsuf 12:53 ↗.

As for someone coerced into violating the Law—for example, into killing a Muslim or omitting prayer—there are two questions. First, does he sin if he acts as the coercion demands? Second, if he endures the coercion and does not act as it demands, is he rewarded or does he sin, given that a person's own life has a claim upon him?

What should be said is that coercion varies in degree according to its means. Apprehending these degrees, comparing them with violation of the command, and preferring one over the other are matters apprehended through the Law, especially when the means of coercion is of the same kind as the act demanded—for example, coercion by killing into killing. In general, this question is a matter of independent judgement (اجتهادية).

R 48 · BA 59

Another question is whether the imposition of legal responsibility (التكليف) requires restraint just as action is required. The answer is that omission is of two kinds. In one, a person, when omitting something, engages in its contrary; this is rewarded, as in fasting. In the other, omitting something does not involve engagement in a contrary; this is not rewarded. Assigning each individual case to one of these two kinds belongs to inquiry into the branches of law.

R 49 · BA 60–61

Another question is whether the command to do something, such as the command to pray, applies before its condition is fulfilled, so that omission is punishable even without fulfilment of the condition. This concerns a legal condition: for example, commanding a ritually impure person to pray while impure. Or does the command apply only after the condition is fulfilled, as when prayer is commanded in a state of purity?

We say: if a person can acquire the condition by choice, he may be commanded to perform the act on the supposition that its condition is fulfilled and punished for omitting it even if he has not fulfilled the condition. Someone who omits prayer is punished for it even if he has never performed ablution. So the Law has prescribed.

The proof of consensus indicates that punishment attaches to one who denies the messengers even before knowing God, although such knowledge is a condition of faith in the messengers. Some appealed here to His words—mighty and exalted—'What brought you into Saqar? They said: We were not among those who pray.'[8] They sought to establish that the verse contains unambiguous wording (نص) on this. Although it is not unambiguous, this is its apparent meaning (ظاهرة), since 'those who pray' may here mean believers, as in his saying—peace be upon him—'I have been forbidden to kill those who pray.' Anyone who considers such a case rationally impossible interprets the apparent meaning otherwise, as is usual with an apparent expression that admits alternatives.

R 50 · BA 62

Those who disallow imposing responsibility in such a case argued that there is no meaning in obliging almsgiving and the discharge of prayer when their occurrence is impossible: how can something be obligatory when it cannot be complied with? These people have confused a legal condition (الشرط الشرعي) with a condition of actual existence (الشرط الوجودي). The matter is otherwise. The command applies to this responsible person before its condition is fulfilled only on the supposition that the condition will be fulfilled; this is within his capacity and can be acquired, unlike a condition of actual existence.

8. Qurʾān, al-Muddaththir 74:42–43 ↗.

R 51 · BA 63

Their argument that, when an unbeliever becomes Muslim, the obligation concerning [past] prayer and almsgiving falls away contains no proof. We hold that this obligation lapses upon conversion only on the basis of a legal proof. We require make-up performance (القضاء) from an apostate but not from an unbeliever because make-up performance becomes obligatory only through a separate command; the legal proof must therefore be followed. Thus someone not commanded to perform an act within its time (الأداء) may be commanded to make it up, while someone commanded to perform it within its time may not be commanded to make it up.

R 52 · BA 64

They append a fourth question to this topic: just as a command to combine two contraries is inadmissible, so is a command to abstain from both when there is no intermediate between them.

R 53 · BA 64–66

They claim, however, that certain particular cases cast doubt on this universal proposition. One concerns someone in the middle of a usurped cultivated field: both remaining and leaving are forbidden, since each damages another person's crop, and whichever he does he is disobedient. Another concerns someone who falls on the chest of a child surrounded by children, knowing that if he remains he will kill the child beneath him, and if he moves he will kill those around him.

Such questions are matters of independent judgement. They cast no doubt on the inadmissibility of a command to abstain from both contraries. It may plausibly be said that the person is not legally responsible in this condition. Or it may be said that in the first case he should leave to reduce the harm, and in the second remain, since moving is a new act that can proceed only from a living person. It is also possible to say that he has a choice, especially if neither act is preferable to the other in causing less harm. Here the discussion of the act, the third section of this book's first part, ends.

Discussion of the Fourth Section

R 54 · BA 67

This section discusses the existence of causes that manifest both rulings and attributes characterizing rulings (أسبابا مظهرة للأحكام ولصفات), such as validity and invalidity. It also explains what these names signify. It consists of four chapters.

First Chapter: Causes That Manifest Rulings

R 55 · BA 68

Know that the Law has appointed signs for rulings that entail their occurrence as perceptible causes entail their effects. Through these causes we come to know that rulings obtain; otherwise establishing them would be impossible. The detailed account of the conditions under which they entail rulings belongs to the third part of this book.

Second Chapter: What ‘Validity’ and ‘Nullity’ Signify in Rulings

R 56 · BA 69–70

Know that these terms are applied to acts of worship in different ways. For theologians, validity (الصحة) applies to what occurs in conformity with the Law, whether make-up performance is obligatory or not; for jurists, it applies to what suffices and removes the requirement of make-up performance. Thus the prayer of someone who thought himself ritually pure is valid in the theologians' terminology, since make-up performance is required by a renewed command. These are terminological conventions about which there is no dispute once the intended meaning is understood.

In contracts, invalidity (الفساد) applies to every legal determination lacking something indispensable to its completion, whether a condition or a cause; validity is its opposite. Abū Ḥanīfa's followers, however, reserve ‘defective’ (الفاسد) for what is authorized in its foundation but prohibited in its attribute. We have already said that everything prohibited through its attribute is prohibited in its foundation and invalidated insofar as it bears that attribute. In general, rulings are characterized by validity only when carried out with the matters and conditions that the Law requires for their performance; invalidity is the contrary.

Third Chapter: Describing Worship as Timely Performance, Make-Up Performance, and Repetition

R 57 · BA 71–72

Know that when an obligation is discharged within its time, it is called timely performance (أداء). If performed once with some defect and then performed again, it is called repetition (إعادة). If discharged after its restricted or extended time has elapsed, having been deliberately omitted, it is called make-up performance (قضاء). The name qaḍāʾ is also applied to other meanings, some closer to this meaning and some more remote. One concerns what is omitted inadvertently until its time elapses. This too is properly called make-up performance, but differs from the first case in that its performer is relieved of sin.

Another concerns cases where timely performance is not obligatory, such as fasting for a menstruating woman. This puzzled some people to the point that they inferred an obligation to fast during menstruation from the obligation to make up the fast. Consensus refutes this: if she died before becoming ritually pure, she would not have sinned. Another concerns the sick person and the traveller. Since they are permitted to fast, their duty resembles an obligation with an extended time. This ought not to be called make-up performance, just as praying at the end of the allotted period is not called make-up performance. Such usage is figurative, because the familiar first period has been missed.

R 58 · BA 73

There are two other doctrines concerning the traveller and the sick person. The Ẓāhirīs hold that if they fast, their fast is invalid, because of His words—mighty and exalted—‘then a number of other days.’[9] Al-Karkhī holds that the obligation concerns other days, but that fasting during Ramaḍān is valid, like advancing the alms before the year's completion. Both doctrines rest upon declining to recognise an ellipsis in the verse, whose understood wording is ‘and he breaks the fast, then a number of other days,’[9] and to construe it as a concession (رخصة). This question will become clear from the discussion in the third part of this book.

Someone who construes it as a concession might be asked about the validity of fasting by a sick person who fears death or severe harm to himself. That is a matter of independent judgement admitting either answer, and lies outside the present purpose.

R 59 · BA 74

The Qāḍī—may God have mercy upon him—applied the name ‘make-up performance’ to what a person deliberately omits while predominantly expecting death before performing it, if events subsequently contradict that expectation. His reason is that the time is assessed according to the predominant probability. This is meaningless, since expecting death does not cause the allotted time itself to elapse.

9. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:184–185 ↗. The clause occurs in both verses. The later “and he breaks the fast” is an explanatory addition, not Qurʾānic wording.

Fourth Chapter: The Original Requirement and the Concession

R 60 · BA 75

Know that the original requirement (العزم) in the Law designates what binds servants through God's imposition of obligation. A concession (الرخصة) designates the latitude granted to a legally responsible person in acting because of an excuse or incapacity, while the prohibiting cause remains in place: for example, permitting a draught of wine to someone choking, or carrion to someone compelled by necessity. ‘Concession’ may also be applied to other meanings, some closer to this meaning and some more remote.

R 61 · BA 76

Here inquiry into the first part of this abridgement ends. The book on the sources of rulings follows.

Part II

Discussion of the Second Part of This Book

R 62 · BA 77

This part comprises inquiry into the sources on which these rulings rest and from which they are derived. They are four: the Book, the Sunna, the community's consensus, and reason's indication of original negation (النفي الأصلي). Calling the last a source is figurative, since it indicates the absence of rulings rather than rulings themselves. The status of a Companion's statement and the law of those before us is disputed. Let us begin with the Book, examining first its reality, then what delimits it, then its expressions, and then its rulings.

The First Source

R 63 · BA 78

As for its reality and meaning, ‘it is the speech subsisting in the essence of God Most High, an eternal attribute among His attributes.’ Establishing this attribute and distinguishing it from the other attributes by what is peculiar to it belongs to theology (علم الكلام).

R 64 · BA 79–81

Its limits comprise what has been transmitted to us between the two covers of the codex in the seven well-known aḥruf (الأحرف السبعة, modes of recitation), through recurrent transmission (نقلا متواترا, tawātur), also called mass transmission. We specified the codices because the Companions—may God be pleased with them—took the utmost precaution in transmitting it in writing. We required recurrent transmission because it yields certainty. What lies outside this and has not been recurrently transmitted is not part of it. It is impossible according to ordinary experience that any portion should be neglected or transmitted only by isolated reports, despite its wide circulation within a community incapable of such neglect or omission, whose transmission establishes recurrence.

Hence, contrary to Abū Ḥanīfa, most scholars hold that additions not recurrently transmitted do not require action—for example, consecutiveness in expiation[10] and similar matters. These additions do not stand in the position of solitary reports (أخبار الآحاد), since a report has neither a contrary indication nor evidence that it is false. If these additions are not considered Qurʾān, they may represent a Companion's doctrine or may be a report; action may not be based on something hovering between these two possibilities.

For this reason the Qāḍī—may God have mercy upon him—declared al-Shāfiʿī—may God have mercy upon him—definitely mistaken in treating ‘In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate’[11] as a verse of every sūra, although it is a verse of al-Naml. Had that been so, an explicit statement of its being Qurʾān would have been transmitted to us and no disagreement would have arisen. Al-Shāfiʿī can argue that its placement at a sūra's beginning by the command of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace— and its revelation at the beginning of each sūra, are contextual indicators suggesting that it belongs to the Qurʾān; if it did not, this would have been stated expressly.

The invocation of refuge, the qunūt supplication, and similar expressions whose being outside the Qurʾān was not expressly stated are not in the same position. In general, this is a question for independent judgement, which is why the Qāḍī did not pronounce unbelief on its account. Even so, it has little usefulness for deriving rulings. Al-Shāfiʿī required recitation of ‘In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate’[11] in prayer only because of reports transmitted to that effect.

10. Cf. Qurʾān, al-Māʾidah 5:89 ↗. The passage concerns a reported reading adding “consecutively”; that addition is not in the verse’s muṣḥaf text.
11. Qurʾān, al-Naml 27:30 ↗. This is the basmala’s occurrence in al-Naml; the discussion concerns its status at the beginnings of sūras.

R 65 · BA 82–84

As for its expressions, some are literal (حقيقة) and some figurative (مجاز). Their presence is evident, since it is in the Arabs' language and tongue. In general, I do not think any tongue or language lacks them, though languages differ in this regard. Some deny, and others allow, that its vocabulary contains anything outside Arabic; determining this contributes little to our present undertaking. In general, if Arabic contains an expression originally foreign to it, the Arabs have Arabized and altered it in a manner entitling it to count as part of their language and to be attributed to it.

Its expressions include determinate and ambiguous wording (محكم ومتشابه), as He—mighty and exalted—has said[12]. People have disagreed about the ambiguous. It is preferable to consider ambiguous expressions to be those capable of bearing more than one meaning; or those whose apparent interpretation suggests a contradiction among them; or expressions for whose meanings the Arabs had no prior convention or established usage, such as the letters at the beginnings of sūras; or all of these.

Discussion of the Second Source: The Sunna

R 66 · BA 85

The saying of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—is an authoritative proof (حجة), because the miracle indicates his truthfulness. It is a proof in itself for anyone who heard him directly. We, however, receive his sayings—God bless him and grant him peace—only through transmitters, either by recurrent transmission (التواتر) or through solitary reports (الآحاد). The discussion of reports therefore divides into these two sections. Common to both is an explanation of the ranks of the expressions used by the Companions—may God be pleased with them—in transmitting reports from him—God bless him and grant him peace. These ranks are as follows:

R 67 · BA 86

The first is for the Companion to say, ‘I heard God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace,’ ‘He related to me,’ ‘He informed me,’ or ‘He spoke to me directly.’ This admits no alternative possibility.

R 68 · BA 87

The second rank is to say, ‘God's Messenger said such-and-such,’ or ‘He related such-and-such.’ When this comes from a Companion, its apparent meaning is direct transmission, but it is not explicit, unambiguous wording (نصا صريحا), since the Companion may have been told it on the authority of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace. Most nevertheless regard acting on such a report as permissible because of the contextual indicators supporting it, especially when it comes from someone whose companionship with him was extensive.

R 69 · BA 88

The third rank is for the Companion to say, ‘God's Messenger commanded such-and-such,’ ‘prohibited such-and-such,’ ‘prescribed such-and-such,’ or ‘made such-and-such obligatory.’ Two possibilities arise: one concerns whether he heard it, as with the expression ‘he said’ [the printed cross-reference is defective]; the second concerns his understanding the address as command or obligation, since the imperative form is disputed. Hence Dāwūd and those Ẓāhirīs who followed him held that the Companion's statement is no authoritative proof unless he transmits the actual words of the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace.

It has been argued against them that this is an inquiry into understanding expressions. Disagreement about them arises among us because we are neither masters of eloquent Arabic nor authorities for Arabic speech. But since the Companion is an Arab, how could he be suspected of error concerning the imperative form, when his usage itself supplies authoritative evidence in a dispute about it?

12. Qurʾān, Āl ʿImrān 3:7 ↗.

R 70 · BA 89

We consider that establishing correct expressions in a language for someone who is not a native speaker occurs in one of two ways: by induction from its speakers' discourse, or by transmission from them where the usage is widespread among them. Accordingly, one person's statement cannot serve as authoritative evidence until it becomes widely circulated. Whether recurrent transmission is required in transmitting a language, or solitary reports suffice, is disputed. It seems that solitary transmission suffices for much of it; otherwise there would be no way to ascertain most verbal significations if recurrent transmission were required for each expression.

R 71 · BA 90

The fourth rank is to say, ‘We were commanded to do such-and-such,’ or ‘We were prohibited from such-and-such.’ Besides the preceding possibilities, this admits another: the person issuing the command may have been someone other than the Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace—among the leaders and rulers. Their expressions ‘Such-and-such belongs to the Sunna’ and ‘The Sunna proceeds in such-and-such a way’ have the same import.

R 72 · BA 91

The fifth rank is for a Companion to say, ‘They used to do such-and-such,’ relating the practice to the time of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace. This too admits the possibility that the practice reached the notice of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—and he approved it, which is the more apparent possibility; it also admits the possibility that it did not reach him.

R 73 · BA 92

From this it has become clear what constitutes reporting from God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—and what does not.

R 74 · BA 93

It remains now to explain how reports reach us: either through recurrent transmission or through solitary transmission. Let us discuss both and the rank of the assent (التصديق) arising from each, beginning with recurrent transmission. We say:

R 75 · BA 94–95

Recurrent transmission (التواتر) is a widely circulated report from which certainty arises about certain matters and under certain conditions, without our knowing whence, how, or when it arose. We said ‘about certain matters’ because it does not arise concerning intelligibles that are not by nature perceptible, or things whose analogues are perceptible but which cannot exist—such as a goat-stag and other things having no existence outside the soul. Nor does it arise concerning something possibly existent that is to be perceived in the future.

Rather, it yields certainty only about what has determinate existence now, or had determinate existence in the past, among things we have not yet ourselves perceived. Recurrent transmission has no use concerning what we have perceived or can apprehend through a certain syllogism (قياس يقيني), such as the world's coming into being and other matters. For if what is recurrently reported accords with what we perceived or established syllogistically, it is superfluous for us; if the contrary is recurrently reported, no assent arises in us from it.

Our phrase ‘under certain conditions’ guards against cases where reports are recurrent but certainty does not arise. On recognising this, some sought to require a number of transmitters from which certainty follows essentially and primarily, so that the number itself causes certainty and necessitates it as causes necessitate their effects. When they could not ascertain such a number, they defined it as that from which certainty arises, supposing that it has a determinate existence in itself even though it remains unknown to us.

Observation shows otherwise. The number from which certainty arises evidently increases and decreases from one case to another. If there were some number that by nature produced certainty essentially and primarily, we would perceive and identify it. In general, a multiplicity of informants is one of the contextual indicators (القرائن) producing assent. The number must therefore increase or decrease according to the other contextual indicators joined to it.

R 76 · BA 96–97

If this is so, we cannot say that assent to this conclusion is produced, in the primary sense, by premises; rather, it comes about in the manner in which the first intelligibles are said to arise from sense perception. Anyone who supposes that recurrent transmission is like experiential premises—whose universality becomes certain through deliberately perceiving their particulars—is definitely mistaken. Rather, the assent arising from recurrent transmission is an act of the soul, and its relation to the soul resembles that of ⟨the first intelligibles to sense perception⟩.

In general, [no one has disputed that recurrent transmission produces certainty except those who deserve no consideration, namely the sophists. Someone who denies it needs punishment, since his tongue lies about what is in his soul. The disagreement concerns only how certainty arises from it: some hold that it arises essentially (بالذات), some incidentally (بالعرض), and some through acquisition.] Such is the view held here by Abū Ḥāmid and those following him: certainty arises only after two premises. The first is that, despite their differing circumstances, nothing unites these informants in falsehood; the second, that they have agreed in reporting this event.

Abū Ḥāmid nevertheless concedes that these two premises were never actually formed in the mind, and that a person did not need to summon them when assent arose through recurrent transmission.

R 77 · BA 97–98

If this is posited—and it is undoubtedly what is observed in recurrent transmission—it is evident that these two premises play no useful part in producing certainty. What does not actually exist in the soul cannot cause what is potential in it to exist by bringing it into actuality. If the major premise in the first figure were not actually present in the soul, it would not cause the conclusion to arise from it, although that conclusion was potentially contained within it.

What benefit, then, is there in requiring something that exists in this manner to produce assent? Hence we stipulated in the definition of recurrent transmission that we do not know how or whence it arose. In general, reports and testimonies generally yield only probable judgement (ظنا), varying with the contextual indicators until, in some cases, certainty arises. People therefore differ about the ranks of assent produced by reports according to their accompaniments. For example, some place a single person's report before a group at the level of recurrent transmission if the group refrains from contradicting him, its numbers ordinarily preclude collusion in sanctioning falsehood, and they have apprehended the reported matter through sense perception.

There are also contextual indicators that weaken the probable judgement arising from reports until, in some cases, their falsehood becomes almost certain. An example is someone reporting that the city's king was killed in the marketplace, after which the people of the market pass by without speaking of it. Of this kind is Abū Ḥanīfa's rejection—may God have mercy upon him—of solitary reports concerning rulings of widespread practical concern: he considers that matters of such concern ought to be widely transmitted. Likewise, Mālik rejected many reports when practice did not accompany them.

R 78 · BA 99

This is what should be said about the rank of assent arising from reports, and about the cases in which they are useful and those in which they are not.

R 79 · BA 100

As for a solitary report (خبر الآحاد), according to its definition in this craft, it is what has not reached the point of yielding certainty … [the construction is defective] … in some case through a single person's report, according to the contextual indicators accompanying it. We answer: although this is not impossible, it occurs rarely, perhaps for a particular person in a particular case. Because the probable judgement arising in the soul varies when contextual indicators accompany solitary reports, some held that a single person's report may yield certainty.

R 80 · BA 101

After defining a solitary report, its discussion also includes whether the Law permits acting upon it, the conditions of its transmitters, criticism and accreditation (الجرح والتعديل), and the manner in which a transmitter reports from his source.

First Chapter: The Legal Admissibility of Acting on a Solitary Report

R 81 · BA 102–104

Acting upon solitary reports is rationally possible and actually occurs in the Law. As for its admissibility in the Law, it is not impossible for God Most High to appoint predominant probability (غلبة الظن) as a sign of a ruling, just as He appoints other things as signs. On this basis one can conceive adjudication through witnesses, judgement by legal opinion, and facing the Kaʿba when it is not visible. Some held that appointing predominant probability as a sign of a legal ruling is rationally necessary; otherwise most rulings would lapse for anyone who had not heard God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—directly.

Abū Ḥāmid says this argument is not strong, since one could say that rulings lapse for those whom recurrent transmission has not reached, just as they lapse for those who have neither heard of the Law nor received it by recurrent transmission. I do not find this satisfactory. The Law's remaining hidden is exceedingly rare, scarcely occurring over a long period; its recurrent transmission to the entire inhabited world has necessarily taken place. Such concealment might plausibly have occurred at the beginning of Islam. Acting on solitary reports is different: not every report must necessarily be recurrently transmitted, and requiring recurrence before acting would suspend most rulings for most legally responsible persons.

In general, if adjudicating through witnesses and oaths, and judging by independent judgement, were not obligatory, there would be no way to redress wrongs and secure rights. Its occurrence in the Law can also be inferred from the Companions' consensus on acting upon such reports. Their hesitation concerning some reports was merely their independent assessment of the routes of transmission. The fact that God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—sent governors to the provinces and charged people to accept their reports establishes its occurrence in the Law with certainty.

R 82 · BA 105–106

Some regard His words—mighty and exalted—'Why should not a group from every division of them go forth, to gain understanding in religion and warn their people when they return to them?'[13] as decisive concerning acting upon solitary reports. A 'group' can mean a few people whose statements do not yield certainty. Abū Ḥāmid considers the verse decisive only concerning the obligation to warn. He says that their obligation to warn does not entail an obligation to act upon it, just as a single witness must testify although his testimony is not acted upon.

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13. Qurʾān, al-Tawbah 9:122 ↗.

He adds that the same objection weakens appeals to His words—mighty and exalted— ‘Those who conceal what We have sent down of clear proofs and guidance,’[14] and to the saying of the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace— ‘May God make radiant one who hears my words, retains them, and conveys them as he heard them,’ and the rest of the report. This statement of his has no meaning. What is the benefit of requiring warning if acting on their transmission is not obligatory? It is not like a witness's case: he is obliged to testify in the hope that another person with matching testimony will come forward, allowing it to be acted upon.

One might reply that warning was perhaps required of individuals only so that their numbers would increase until their statements produced necessary knowledge. But this is refuted by the preceding point: it would suspend most rulings. It is more plausible to regard the verse as neither decisive nor unambiguous wording (نصا) for acting upon solitary reports because ‘group’ applies both to a few people and to a large number whose statements can yield certainty, as indicated by the saying, ‘A group of my community will continue …’ and the rest of the report. The verse's more apparent meaning, however, is that ‘group’ here does not mean people whose transmission produces knowledge.

Second Chapter: The Transmitter's Condition and Character

R 83 · BA 107–108

Since acting on a solitary report has been established, the conditions under which it is accepted and must be acted upon must be stated, for not every report requires action. First, a single person's report is acted upon even where his testimony is not. Once acting on such a report is established, whoever requires a plurality must prove that requirement from the Law; it cannot properly be assimilated to testimony by analogy (قياسا). The Companions—may God be pleased with them—sought corroboration through numbers on two or three occasions as their independent judgement in circumstances particular to those cases. In general, we do not require a plurality as a condition.

R 84 · BA 109

The first condition is that we do not accept a child's report, because he does not fear God and we cannot be assured against his lying. If, however, he was a child when he heard the report and transmits it after puberty, it is accepted. The proof is the Companions' consensus on acting upon reports without distinguishing whether they were heard in childhood or after puberty. Those who accept children's testimony concerning injuries occurring among them are led to do so by inference from contextual indicators arising from their numbers; hence they require their testimony to be given before they disperse.

R 85 · BA 110–111

Another condition is accurate retention (ضابطا), since someone inattentive will usually fall into error. There is no disagreement about requiring the transmitter to be Muslim: an unbeliever's transmission is not accepted because he is suspect concerning religion. Although Abū Ḥanīfa accepts unbelievers' testimony concerning one another, there is no dissent from rejecting their transmission. In general, the basis for rejecting it is consensus.

R 86 · BA 112

The requirement of probity (العدالة) is undisputed, but what its name signifies is disputed. Some, who are the majority, hold that probity is a state of the soul (حالة في النفس) from which follows avoidance of what the Law prohibits, whether by forbiddance or disapproval, and performance of what the Law commands, whether by obligation or recommendation, without falling short in this.

14. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:159 ↗.

R 87 · BA 112

In general, he must avoid everything that impugns his religion and whose commission leaves lying open to him. This varies according to the assessments of those exercising independent judgement. There is, however, no disagreement that sinlessness is not required, just as avoiding grave sins is not sufficient. Some hold that probity consists in manifesting Islam while not being known as morally transgressive, without investigation into one's conduct or inward condition.

R 88 · BA 113

The proponents of the first doctrine argued: just as transmission is inadmissible from someone whose status concerning unbelief is unknown, so it is from someone whose status concerning moral transgression is unknown. Their opponents may reply that, in the former case, no state is known that produces predominant confidence in his trustworthiness, whereas a person known to manifest Islam is different. The first group also appealed to the Companions' rejection of reports from unknown persons—ʿUmar's rejection—may God be pleased with him—of Fāṭima bt. Qays's report and ʿAlī's rejection of al-Ashjaʿī's statement—and to the evident demand of God's Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—for probity and trustworthiness in those he sent to the provinces.

R 89 · BA 113

The second group appealed to the fact that the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—accepted a Bedouin's testimony that he had seen the crescent, although nothing was known of him except his Islam. Their opponents need not concede that he was unknown to the Prophet himself. They also argued that the Companions accepted the statements of people whom they knew as Muslims and did not know to be morally transgressive.

R 90 · BA 114

In general, each group has advanced arguments that, although apparently supporting its claim, still admit interpretation. The question concerns independent judgement, not certainty. What is intended by probity, it appears, is simply a predominant probability of truthfulness; this varies with the contextual indicators supplied by the circumstances.

Where the Law has not established with certainty a determinate sign of predominant probability concerning truthfulness, we should therefore impose no fixed limit. The matter should be entrusted to the inquiry of those exercising independent judgement. Contextual indicators may come together for one such jurist that make a person's truthfulness predominantly probable to him, while they do not come together for another.

R 91 · BA 115

They have disagreed about a morally transgressive person who acts on an interpretation (الفاسق المتأول), meaning someone who does not recognise his own transgression. Whoever holds that transgression prevents acceptance only because it arouses suspicion cannot conceive rejecting him unless his transgression consists in permitting lying. Whoever holds that transgression in itself defeats acceptance, ⟨not⟩ because it arouses suspicion, permits their testimony concerning one another. The first is al-Shāfiʿī's doctrine; the second, the Qāḍī's. Al-Shāfiʿī's doctrine seems more consistent with the reasoning, and is supported by the Companions' acceptance—may God be pleased with them—of reports from the Khārijites.

R 92 · BA 115

The transgression of someone acting on an interpretation may be known through a certain proof or through a probable proof. Acceptance of the transmission of someone whose transgression is established by a probable proof should be more appropriate. Hence al-Shāfiʿī says: ‘I judge the Ḥanafī who drinks nabīdh morally transgressive, but I do not reject his testimony.’

R 93 · BA 116

These are the conditions required in a transmitter. As for the considerations through which preference (الترجيح) is established, they are almost without limit.

Third Chapter: Criticism of Transmitters and Attestation of Their Probity

R 94 · BA 117

This comprises four sections.

First Section

R 95 · BA 117

Some require more than one person to attest a transmitter's probity, by analogy with testimony; others do not, by analogy with the acceptance of a report transmitted by a person of probity. The latter is the more evident view.

Second Section: Stating the Grounds for Criticism and Attestation of Probity

R 96 · BA 118

Al-Shāfiʿī says that the grounds for criticism must be stated, whereas the grounds for attesting probity need not be: one person may regard as a fault something that another does not, while probity has only one basis. Some hold the reverse, because people are quick to praise on the strength of appearances. The Qāḍī says that the grounds need not be stated in either case, reliance being placed on the person giving the attestation. Others say that the grounds must be stated in both cases. This is, in my view, the more cautious course, since assessments of probity and the weighing of evidence are both disputed, as was explained earlier.

When criticism conflicts with an attestation of probity, criticism takes precedence, because it discloses additional information unknown to the person attesting probity—unless the latter specifically addresses the very matter asserted by the critic. In that case, criticism and attestation stand in conflict.

Third Section: Attestation and Confirmation of Probity Themselves

R 97 · BA 119

This can take four forms: through an explicit statement, through transmitting a report from someone, through acting upon his report, or through giving judgement on his testimony. The highest is an explicit statement explaining the basis of his probity; below this is transmitting a report from him. The latter is valid only on the view that an attestation by itself suffices to establish probity, and only when the transmission is understood as an explicit declaration of the narrator's confidence in the person from whom he reports. Acting upon a report, however, does not attest the transmitter's probity, since the action may rest on another proof—unless we know that he acted on that report as received through that particular transmitter. This, too, follows the view that the grounds for criticism and attestation need not be stated.

Giving judgement on someone's testimony is stronger than merely attesting his probity. Declining to give judgement on his testimony or report is not, however, a criticism of him: one may withhold acceptance of an upright person's testimony or report for reasons other than an objection to his probity. In general, when no other reason presents itself for rejecting his testimony and transmission, the rejection is equivalent to an unspecified criticism.

Fourth Section: Attestation of the Companions' Probity, May God Be Pleased with Them

R 98 · BA 120

The position of the great majority of the community and its acknowledged authorities is that the Companions' probity is established with certainty, through God's attestation of it—majestic and mighty is He—and that of His Messenger, in numerous verses of the Book of God, majestic and mighty, and numerous reports from the Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace.

R 99 · BA 121

Groups among the Khārijites, Muʿtazilites, and Qadarites—in general, the people of innovation and deviation—have rejected the Companions' testimony and transmission after dissension arose among them and wars and disputes broke out. The people of the Sunna understand these events on the basis that every practitioner of independent judgement is either free of sin or correct, according to the two respective positions. Some of the people of the Sunna maintain that ʿUthmān's killers were certainly mistaken, but did not recognise their error and were acting on an interpretation. According to the majority, the testimony of a wrongdoer acting on an interpretation is not rejected.

R 100 · BA 122

Our account of the solitary report still requires a discussion of the manner in which a transmitter reports from the person who is his source. This can occur at five levels.

The First Level

R 101 · BA 123

The teacher reads to him so that he may transmit from the teacher. He may then truthfully say, in the literal sense, 'He related to us,' 'He informed us,' and 'I heard him.' This is the highest level.

The Second Level

R 102 · BA 124

The report is read to the teacher while he remains silent. Some Literalists dispute this, but the majority consider his silence and approval equivalent to his speaking, provided there is no reason to suppose that his silence results from inattention, coercion, or the like. They disagree, however, about whether the transmitter may say without qualification, 'He related to us,' or 'I heard so-and-so.' The correct position is that he may not, since this is plainly false—unless a contextual indication (قرينة حال) or an explicit statement makes it known that he means a reading before the teacher.

The Third Level: Authorization

R 103 · BA 125

This is for the teacher to say, 'I authorize you to transmit from me such-and-such a book,' or 'Whatever you have reliably identified among the reports I have heard.' In such a case, 'He related to us' or 'He informed us' may be used without qualification only in an extended sense.

The Fourth Level: Handing Over a Written Text

R 104 · BA 126

Its form is for the teacher to say, 'Take this book and transmit it from me.' Merely handing it over without speaking has no significance; the physical handing over is therefore an additional formality, and the transaction is in reality an authorization. Although it does not yield knowledge of the precise route of transmission, it does yield knowledge of the report's authenticity.

The Fifth Level: Reliance on Handwriting

R 105 · BA 127

He finds a statement in the teacher's handwriting: 'I transmitted such-and-such from so-and-so.' He may not transmit it from the teacher, because handwriting can be confused with other handwriting. If the teacher says, 'This is my handwriting,' his statement is accepted, but one may not transmit from him unless he gives permission verbally or by a contextual indication.

If a person of probity says, 'This is an accurate copy of al-Bukhārī's book,' and one sees in it 'He related to us,' one still may not transmit from its author. But must one act upon it? If one follows another's judgement, one must ask a practitioner of independent judgement; this is undisputed. If one exercises independent judgement oneself, some say that one may not act upon it without having heard it. Others say that one may act upon it once the copy's accuracy is known, since the Messenger's Companions, God bless him and grant him peace, carried written sheets to the provinces, and people relied upon them on the testimony of their bearers.

In general, however, one should transmit only what one has heard and ascertained: the person who transmitted to them entertained no doubt about anything they received from him. If he doubted anything, its transmission was abandoned.

R 106 · BA 128–129

Several questions branch from this. Suppose that among the reports recorded as having been heard by a transmitter there is one that he strongly believes he heard: may he transmit it? If he is in doubt, there is no disagreement that he may not. If he strongly believes that he heard it, some say that it may be received from him, since this field rests on predominant probability. This is implausible: predominant probability concerns the teacher's truthfulness. Likewise, in testimony, predominant probability concerns the judge; the witness, however, should testify with certainty wherever certainty is possible. The same applies to a transmitter.

R 107 · BA 130

Another question arises when the teacher denies the report categorically, affirming that the transmitter has spoken falsely. The report is then not acted upon, but the transmitter is not thereby discredited, because they are two persons of probity whose statements conflict. If, however, the teacher's denial expresses uncertainty, the report is acted upon: the transmitter is certain that he heard it, while the teacher does not categorically declare him false, and both possess probity.

Al-Karkhī holds that the teacher's forgetting the report invalidates it. He argues that the teacher is not obliged to act upon it when a person of probity transmits it back to him from him and he does not remember it. The transmitter cannot be in this position, since he is certain; the position of someone other than these two lies between theirs.

It seems that the report's recipient is more likely to believe the transmitter truthful, given how commonly people forget and the fact that the teacher does not categorically declare him false. This is the position of Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī, and the great majority of the theologians. In their view, it resembles the teacher's uncertainty about an addition to a report or its grammatical inflection.

R 108 · BA 131

Another question concerns a trustworthy transmitter who alone reports an addition to a report transmitted by a group of trustworthy persons with exact memories. Some say that the addition is accepted: if he alone had transmitted an entire report, it would have been accepted, and the addition is no different. You know that this is not so. His being alone in reporting an addition to a report they have also transmitted, despite their exact memories, is an indication (قرينة) weakening the probability of the addition's authenticity. This does not apply when he alone transmits an entire report.

Accordingly, some reject the addition; others accept it, though not for the reason just given. Their reason is that the others do not categorically deny the addition. They may have entered the gathering after part of the report had already been related, or they may have been present but failed to hear it because of some distraction or accident. In general, this is a matter for independent judgement, and its probability varies from case to case and report to report.

R 109 · BA 132

Another question is the transmission of a report's meaning without its wording. Some permit this for a learned person who understands the applications of speech. Others allow only the substitution (الإبدال) of an expression synonymous with and equal in meaning to the original: for example, replacing quʿūd with julūs, both meaning 'sitting,' where their synonymy is beyond doubt, and not where establishing it requires inference.

The first group appeals to the consensus permitting the meanings contained in the Law to be explained to non-Arabs in their own languages. They say that if Arabic may be replaced by synonymous non-Arabic wording, replacing it with Arabic wording is all the more permissible. They do not distinguish between a substitution whose validity is self-evident and one requiring inference. They add that the Messenger of God's emissaries, God bless him and grant him peace, likewise conveyed his commands to non-Arabs.

R 110 · BA 133–134

I hold that when understanding what expressions signify is a matter for independent judgement, a practitioner of independent judgement may not act upon a reported meaning until the Lawgiver's wording has been transmitted to him. Otherwise, in the very capacity in which he exercises independent judgement, he becomes a follower of someone else's judgement. An exception might be made where that meaning is stated by a Companion; discussion of this returns to the disagreement mentioned earlier. A practitioner of independent judgement whose judgement others follow may, in my view, substitute one expression for another for those who follow him, since this itself is a kind of independent judgement. Consequently, explaining Arabic expressions and rendering them in another language are permissible.

As for permitting the transmission of only part of a report, [I consider this permissible if that part conveys a meaning, is self-sufficient, and does not require what precedes it in order to be understood, or if omitting the excised portion does not leave what remains susceptible to two or more meanings. This applies equally whether [we permit] the procedure on the view of those who allow transmission of a report's meaning without its wording, or of those who do not].

R 111 · BA 135

Another question concerns transmission with an omitted link and transmission with a connected chain. Opinions differ: Mālik, Abū Ḥanīfa, and the majority accept and act upon a report with an omitted link, whereas al-Shāfiʿī and the Qāḍī reject it. Its form is for someone who was not his contemporary to say, 'The Messenger of God said'—God bless him and grant him peace—or for someone who was not Abū Hurayra's contemporary to say, 'Abū Hurayra said.'

The first group argues that transmission by a person of probity attests his source's probity, especially when he states this explicitly, as in 'from a trustworthy person,' in their usage. The reply is that his transmission does not attest probity unless his circumstances indicate that he transmits only from persons of probity, or he expressly attests his source's probity; and even then it does not establish probity unless he states what probity means to him. In my view, this last requirement does not follow from the positions of al-Shāfiʿī and the Qāḍī, as explained earlier. Perhaps, however, they concede unspecified attestation only where the person is identified: an unidentified person might, if named, be someone we know to be morally unreliable.

The first group also argues for accepting reports with omitted links from the consensus of the Companions and Successors permitting action upon them. But the alleged consensus itself is disputed, because this position has not been transmitted from all of them, and the silence of those who said nothing does not have the standing of an express statement, especially in matters open to independent judgement, as will be explained later.

Some who reject reports with omitted links nevertheless accept such a report from a Companion, because he generally relates only from another Companion, and all of them possess probity. The same is said of the Successors' reports with omitted links, since they generally transmit from a Companion. The preferred position among those who reject such reports, however, is to accept one from neither a Companion nor a Successor until his explicit wording or a contextual indication makes it known that he transmits only from a Companion.

An argument might be brought against those who refuse such reports from chains expressed simply by 'from,' which are treated as connected despite the possibility of an intermediary between the transmitter and his source. They may reply that a chain expressed by 'from' is treated as connected only where accompanying indications show that the transmitter heard directly from his source, or where he explicitly says so. In the absence of either an explicit statement or such indications, the report remains uncertain between an omitted-link report and a connected report.

R 112 · BA 136

As for accepting a solitary report about something of widespread occurrence, such as the report concerning touching the penis and similar reports, the grounds for suspecting it have already been explained: what commonly affects people normally becomes widely circulated and known. Those who permit acting on solitary reports in such matters reject this indication. They say that widespread transmission is required only for what the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, was charged to disseminate among everyone; it is not required for what he was charged to convey to individuals while referring others to their reports.

To justify referring people to solitary reports in some cases even though widespread transmission would be possible, they invoke the permissibility of referring them to analogy where an express ruling could have been given, as in the question of usury and similar matters. They say that widespread occurrence is not the cause of dissemination and wide transmission; the cause is the manner in which the duty is imposed.

R 113 · BA 137

I hold that his conveying, God bless him and grant him peace, one of God's individually binding obligations to a single person, while refraining from conveying it to the Companions who attended him morning and evening—may God bless them and grant them peace—would involve his relying, God bless him and grant him peace, on their acting upon the report if it reached them and on the obligation's lapsing for them if it did not. Nothing in his circumstances, God bless him and grant him peace, indicates this, given his eagerness to teach and explain.

Whether or not such a thing is rationally possible, examining his conduct, God bless him and grant him peace, in explaining and clarifying the Law brings one close to certainty that it could not have occurred in the revealed dispensation.

The truth is that some reports can reach us only through solitary routes, even if their subject was formerly widespread and the reports widely circulated. Others can reach us by either route, and still others cannot reach us except through mass transmission. This varies from case to case and issue to issue, according to time, place, and other obstacles.

Accordingly, in some reports a practitioner of independent judgement may find grounds for rejection because of widespread occurrence, while in others he may find no such grounds, especially in collective obligations. In each instance one should judge according to what the matter under discussion admits. Rejecting solitary routes in every case of widespread occurrence is incorrect, since the matter varies with the accompanying indications; acting upon them without qualification is likewise incorrect.

This division does not have the nature of logical opposition, so that its two sides could be made contradictories and each party discuss them as though truth were confined to one side. You know how often they proceed in this way in many of these questions.

R 114 · BA 138

Here the examination of the second source, the Sunna, comes to an end. You should know that both these sources are subject to abrogation; let us now discuss it.

On the Abrogating and the Abrogated

R 115 · BA 139

There is disagreement over the definition of abrogation. The theologians define it as discourse indicating the removal of a ruling established by earlier discourse, such that the ruling would remain in force without it, with the discourse indicating its removal occurring later. They include these qualifications because they allow that God Most High may remove a ruling at some time after, for example, commanding it in perpetuity. In general, they allow abrogation before performance has become possible. Others define it as discourse disclosing when the term of an act of worship expires, because they believe that abrogation merely clarifies a prescription that was never intended from the outset to apply generally to, or encompass, all time.

Still others define it as discourse indicating that a ruling like the one established by the text ceases to hold, such that it would remain in force without that discourse. This definition is somewhat clumsy, because it makes what is removed a ruling like the original rather than the ruling itself. They were driven to this formulation only because they do not allow that God Most High may prohibit the very same thing after commanding it.

R 116 · BA 140–141

In general, inquiry into which of these things may or may not be attributed to God Most High does not belong to the jurist as jurist. It is sufficient for the jurist to concede and believe that the Law contains rulings removed after they had been commanded, whether or not this removal disclosed the expiry of the term of an act of worship, and that the occurrence of such abrogation in the Law is established by mass transmission. Inquiry into its rational possibility, or the manner of that possibility, does not belong specifically to him. Let us therefore begin with what is necessary in this discipline. The discussion comprises several questions.

R 117 · BA 142

If part of an act of worship, one of its conditions, or one of its recommended observances is abrogated, does this abrogate the act of worship itself? Opinions differ. The truth is that removing a part removes the whole, because a whole is a whole through its parts, and an act of worship is commanded insofar as it comprises all its parts. In general, removing a part removes the whole, since it no longer remains a whole; this applies to what cannot be divided into independent parts. Removing a condition seems to have the same effect, since it is through that condition that the act of worship is complete. Removing a recommended observance, however, does not entail removing the act's obligatory character.

R 118 · BA 143

Question. Some regard an addition to a text as abrogation; others do not. The preferred position is that an addition constitutes abrogation when it makes what receives the addition different from what it was before and numerically a second thing. An example is prayer, if it is correct that two cycles were originally prescribed and further cycles were then added.

If, however, the addition differs in kind from the act of worship to which it is added, it clearly is not abrogation—for example, prescribing prayer and then prescribing almsgiving. Likewise, if the addition and what receives it are one in kind, but the addition does not make the latter a different individual thing, it is not abrogation: for example, adding twenty lashes to a prescribed punishment of eighty. Abū Ḥanīfa, God have mercy on him, nevertheless regards such a case as abrogation.

R 119 · BA 144

Question. Abrogation does not require establishing a substitute for the abrogated ruling to take its place and occupy its position. Abrogation without such a substitute is permissible according to the people of the Sunna and has occurred in the Law, as in the abrogation concerning storing sacrificial meat and giving charity before private consultation[15].

As for God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'Whatever verse We abrogate or cause to be forgotten, We bring one better than it,'[16] although its apparent meaning establishes a substitute taking the abrogated verse's place, 'We bring one better than it'[16] may be interpreted to mean 'We bring another verse,' even if this does not contain a replacement for the abrogated verse in respect of its ruling, but instead contains another ruling that is not a substitute for the one removed.

R 120 · BA 145

Question. Abrogation may replace a ruling with a lighter or a heavier one. This is rationally possible and has occurred in the Law. Examples of replacing a lighter requirement with a heavier one are replacing the choice between fasting and feeding others as compensation with fasting alone[17]; prohibiting wine and temporary marriage; and replacing the fast of ʿĀshūrāʾ with the obligation to fast Ramaḍān.

R 121 · BA 146

Question. When a verse contains a ruling, its recitation may be abrogated while its ruling remains, its ruling may be abrogated while its recitation remains, or both may be abrogated. This is rationally possible and has occurred in the Law. Its rational possibility follows because recitation comprises two aspects: first, reading the verse, writing it in the codex, and reciting it in prayer; second, the rulings it contains. A person may be charged with either aspect without the other, and both may be removed together, according to what the doctrines of the people of the Sunna entail.

Evidence from revelation that this has occurred is God's saying, 'For those who are able to bear it, a compensation: food for needy people,'[18] and the rest of the verse. Its ruling was abrogated by making fasting the sole requirement, while its recitation remained[19]. Likewise, 'A bequest for parents and close relatives'[20] is abrogated by his saying, peace be upon him, 'No bequest for an heir.' This requires examination, however, because some do not permit the Qurʾān to be abrogated by the Sunna.

As for abrogating recitation while retaining the ruling, reports corroborate one another that the recitation of the stoning verse was abrogated while its ruling remained. Yet this, too, requires examination in my view: it should not be accepted that such wording was once part of the Qurʾān until it is established by mass transmission, and this should not be accepted through solitary routes.

15. Qurʾān, al-Mujādilah 58:12–13 ↗.
16. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:106 ↗.
17. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:184–185 ↗. These are the verses invoked in the author's abrogation example.
18. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:184 ↗. "Food for needy people" follows a transmitted construct/plural reading; the printed wording is retained.
19. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:185 ↗. This identifies the fasting command invoked here; the account of abrogation is the author's.
20. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:180 ↗.

R 122 · BA 147

Question. Consensus (الإجماع) does not abrogate, because there is no abrogation after revelation has ceased. If something is supposed to have been abrogated by consensus, that consensus is evidence of an earlier abrogating text that has not reached us.

R 123 · BA 148

Question. There is no disagreement over abrogating a Sunna established by mass transmission through another such Sunna, solitary reports through solitary reports, or solitary reports through mass transmission. Opinions differ about abrogating what is established by mass transmission through solitary reports. The preferred position is that this is rationally possible and occurred in the Law during the Prophet's lifetime, God bless him and grant him peace: the people of the mosque at Qubāʾ turned toward the Kaʿba on a solitary report, although their facing Jerusalem had been established by a decisive route. In general, the Messenger of God's sending emissaries to the outlying regions with abrogating and abrogated rulings, God bless him and grant him peace, is itself established by mass transmission.

Its occurrence after his death, God bless him and grant him peace, is excluded by the Companions' consensus that the Qurʾān—and, in general, what is established by mass transmission—is not set aside by a solitary report. The reason seems to be indications accompanying reports from the Messenger of God during his lifetime, God bless him and grant him peace, which do not accompany reports from him after his death, God bless him and grant him peace: the possibility of going back to him, questioning him, and the like.

R 124 · BA 149

As for abrogating the mass-transmitted Qurʾān through a mass-transmitted Sunna, it is reported that al-Shāfiʿī and some Ẓāhirīs did not permit this, on the evidence of God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'Whatever verse We abrogate or cause to be forgotten, We bring one better than it or like it.'[21] Although the apparent meaning of this verse supports their view, we have already said that the new verse may contain no replacement for the abrogated verse's ruling, while the Sunna supplies the replacement for that ruling.

Those who permit this invoke the abrogation of God's saying, 'A bequest for parents and close relatives,'[22] by the Prophet's saying, peace be upon him, 'No bequest for an heir.' They also invoke his saying, peace be upon him, 'God has now appointed a way for them: for the never-married with the never-married, a hundred lashes and a year's banishment; and for the previously married with the previously married, a hundred lashes and stoning.' This abrogates 'Confine them in the houses.'[23] These arguments admit possible alternative interpretations and are not decisive.

R 125 · BA 149

Besides the argument already mentioned, what seems to have led those holding this position to exclude such abrogation is the greater weight we find them giving to the assent (التصديق) produced by the Book's mass transmission: this is the highest degree of mass transmission. As for other reports, even when mass-transmitted, assent to them may fall short of assent to the Book. Contrary to what many think, it is not impossible for certain assent to admit degrees, especially where it rests on transmission. As for the report that al-Shāfiʿī, God have mercy on him, did not permit a mass-transmitted Sunna to be abrogated by the Qurʾān, this has no intelligible basis if taken in its apparent sense—unless it is interpreted otherwise, for the possibilities of interpretation are ample.

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21. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:106 ↗.
22. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:180 ↗.
23. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:15 ↗. The Arabic li-imsākihinna is a paraphrase of the verse's fa-amsikūhunna; the author's wording is retained.

R 126 · BA 150–151

Question. A decisive, mass-transmitted text may not be abrogated by probable analogy, just as it may not be abrogated by a solitary report. Those who permit this argue from the permissibility of restricting the scope of a mass-transmitted text through analogy. Even if conceded, this is no proof: specification clarifies, whereas abrogation removes.

The proof here is the Companions' consensus invalidating every opinion contrary to a text, all the more a mass-transmitted text; and the report of Muʿādh, when he said, 'I exercise my judgement' in the absence of a text, and the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, commended him for it. If two decisive texts contradict one another and the matter is unclear, may a solitary report determine that one is later? This requires examination; the question is open to independent judgement.

R 127 · BA 152

Question. A ruling is not abrogated by a Companion's saying, 'Such-and-such a ruling was abrogated,' unless he says, 'I heard the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, say this.' That applies when the ruling was established by a solitary report, because what is not abrogation is often thought to be abrogation, as some have regarded an addition to a text as abrogation. If the ruling was established through mass transmission, a Companion's statement does not abrogate it even if he transmits the Messenger of God's own words, God bless him and grant him peace, since solitary transmission does not abrogate mass transmission, as explained earlier.

R 128 · BA 153

In general, you should know that abrogation has conditions contained implicitly in the definition given earlier. First, what is removed must be a revealed ruling, not a rational judgement such as original freedom from liability (البراءة الأصلية), which is removed by the prescription of acts of worship. Second, abrogation must take place through discourse, rather than the discourse whose ruling is removed being limited by a time whose arrival itself entails this. In general, according to each of the definitions of abrogation we have enumerated, some conditions apply and must be considered, while others fall outside it.

R 129 · BA 154

Question. If two decisive texts conflict and it is unknown which abrogates the other, this can be established only by transmission. There are several possible routes. First, the wording of one may indicate the abrogation of the other, as in his saying, peace be upon him, 'I used to forbid you such-and-such; now do it.' Second, their respective dates may be known. This may also be known through the community's consensus that one of them has been abrogated. Other circumstances thought to establish abrogation do not do so, such as a transmitter's later conversion to Islam, his younger age, or the ending of his companionship with the Prophet.

This concludes the discussion of the abrogating and the abrogated.

On the Third Source of Proofs: Consensus

R 130 · BA 156

Consensus (الإجماع) is the agreement of the practitioners of independent judgement within Muḥammad's community, God bless him and grant him peace, on a revealed ruling. This applies whether the bearer of the Law, God bless him and grant him peace, expressly stated the ruling but it was lost and not transmitted, or did not expressly state it, and they reached agreement through a contextual indication, a proof, or something else producing agreement. Consensus adds nothing to the authentication of what the Prophet, peace be upon him, expressly stated and which was transmitted by mass transmission. What was transmitted through solitary routes, however, consensus raises from the level of probability to that of certainty.

Where a ruling was not expressly stated, or was expressly stated but has not reached us, consensus is used as a decisive proof establishing it. Such consensus has in fact occurred in the Law. We can learn of it in one of two ways: if those agreeing are our contemporaries, by meeting them; if they belong to earlier generations, through widespread transmission that produces assent (التصديق).

R 131 · BA 157

The proof that consensus is authoritative is drawn from transmitted revelation, the Book and the Sunna. Among its texts is God's saying, 'Whoever opposes the Messenger after guidance has become clear to him and follows a way other than that of the believers, We shall turn him toward what he has chosen,'[24] and the remainder of the verse. This is the strongest verse supporting reliance on consensus. There are also His sayings, blessed and exalted: 'Thus We made you a community of the middle, so that you may be witnesses over humankind and the Messenger a witness over you'[25]; 'You are the best community brought forth for humankind'[26]; and 'Among those We have created is a community that guides by truth and acts justly by it.'[27]

Although none of these verses taken separately is unambiguous wording (نص) establishing consensus as a revealed proof, together they require this community to be esteemed and honored, its way followed and agreement maintained with it, and they forbid opposing it and departing from its congregation.

In general, when these verses are joined to the transmitted reports affirming that this community is protected from error—reports mass-transmitted in meaning even if not in wording—consensus is established with certainty as a revealed proof. Such reports include his saying, peace be upon him: 'My community does not agree upon error'; his saying, peace be upon him, 'God would not bring my community into agreement upon error; whoever delights in the spacious heart of Paradise should keep to the congregation'; and his saying, peace be upon him, 'God's hand is with the congregation,' together with the other reports of this kind.

R 132 · BA 158

An argument establishing the authority of consensus through reason is weak. Although it is unlikely that many people would agree upon a lie, their agreeing upon an error is not unlikely. Indeed, we say that if only two or three practitioners of independent judgement remained and agreed on an opinion, consensus would be established through them, because the Law attests their protection from error insofar as the name 'community' applies to them at that time.

R 133 · BA 159

We specified practitioners of independent judgement in its definition because, although ordinary people can be conceived as participating in consensus, this is only in matters transmitted by mass transmission, such as the five prayers, fasting, and almsgiving, or in matters in which they are included as followers of the consensus of those practitioners. Their agreement therefore adds nothing to establishing the correctness of anything. Ordinary people always follow practitioners of independent judgement and agree with them, since this is their duty. There is no objection to calling this consensus, but such consensus is not a source used by a practitioner of independent judgement.

R 134 · BA 160

As for the number of those agreeing, there is no condition except that they comprise all qualified practitioners of independent judgement existing in a single age. If we required the agreement of people of every age—past, present, and future—no consensus could occur.

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24. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:115 ↗.
25. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:143 ↗.
26. Qurʾān, Āl ʿImrān 3:110 ↗.
27. Qurʾān, al-Aʿrāf 7:181 ↗.

R 135 · BA 161

If the people of our age agree on something about which their predecessors did not agree, is consensus established? This requires examination. If the preceding generation was silent and no opinion on the matter has been transmitted from it, the consensus of later generations is necessarily established. Discussion arises when a disagreement has been transmitted from the predecessors. Opinions differ, and the question is determined through the verbal forms of the statements affirming this community's protection from error, such as his saying, peace be upon him, 'My community will not agree upon misguidance,' and the other reports we have cited.

Although these cannot be understood with unrestricted generality, since the term 'community' cannot here include those yet to come, the term remains authoritative with respect to the generality of what remains within its scope. On what grounds, I wonder, can the preceding generation be excluded from the requirements of consensus, when the remaining general scope of the expression includes them? This is possible only for someone who holds that a general expression (العام), once specified, is no longer authoritative for the generality of what remains.

R 136 · BA 162

This disagreement cannot arise for the Ẓāhirīs, because they consider consensus to be solely the Companions' agreement on a ruling, may God be pleased with them. This follows necessarily from their principles, since they do not allow consensus based on analogy. On their view, consensus therefore arises either from a report that has disappeared and has not reached us, or from indications and circumstances witnessed in the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace. Such a basis is conceivable only among the Companions. Those who permit consensus to arise from analogy must, however, confront the disagreement just mentioned. We shall explain this in the book on inference, when the meaning they intend by analogy in this discipline has become clear.

R 137 · BA 163–164

Does the term 'community' also include every individual practitioner of independent judgement in that age, so that a single dissenter prevents consensus, or does it mean the majority? The apparent sense of the transmitted formulas includes them all. In general, examination of these conditions of consensus seems to be a matter for independent judgement. There is also disagreement when an opinion is transmitted from most of them and the rest are silent. The more evident view, as al-Shāfiʿī says, is that a speaker's position should not be attributed to someone silent—unless the silent persons' circumstances indicate that their silence may have expressed approval of, and agreement with, that opinion.

A person may remain silent for many reasons: he may have no opinion on the matter at that time; or, if he has an opinion, obstacles may prevent him from stating it. He may think that the ruling is open to independent judgement, or that every practitioner of independent judgement is correct; he may be inhibited by awe, or by other accompanying circumstances.

R 138 · BA 165

Since this is so, and consensus requires agreement among all practitioners of independent judgement existing in the age, there is no basis for treating the agreement of the people of Medina as authoritative because they were the majority at the beginning of Islam.

The discerning Mālikīs, however, regard it as authoritative on the ground of transmission. If an argument for its authority is to be built on this, it seems to me that the transmission of the practice must be explicitly stated, generation after generation, until it reaches the Messenger of God's time, God bless him and grant him peace. It would then be authoritative through his approval, God bless him and grant him peace. For example, they would say, 'This is how we found our fathers acting,' tracing this back to the Messenger of God's time, God bless him and grant him peace.

Such was the encounter between Mālik and Abū Yūsuf in al-Rashīd's presence concerning the ṣāʿ measure. If this requirement is neither imposed nor carefully maintained, their agreement may concern a practice forced upon them by some caliph or governor. In general, it is clear that reaching a legal judgement on this basis does not refer back to a source established with certainty in the Law, as a probable indication ought to do—unless transmission of the practice is explicitly stated as we have described, in which case it belongs to transmitted evidence.

R 139 · BA 166

The requirement that the generation of practitioners of independent judgement must die out without disagreement intervening is not entailed by the wording of the reports establishing the authority of consensus. Rather, anyone who dissents after consensus has existed for even a single moment is disregarded and is certainly in error.

R 140 · BA 167

This is our account, as concise as we could make it, of what consensus is and of its requirements. Someone who has grasped consensus to the extent set out here can readily understand the further questions and objections connected with it, which Abū Ḥāmid has discussed at such length.

On the Fourth Source

R 141 · BA 168

This is rational evidence for presuming the continuation (الاستصحاب) of freedom from obligations and the absence of blame for people where no command or prohibition has been received: for example, the absence of an obligation to perform a sixth prayer, eating during Shawwāl, and the like. In general, calling this a proof is a loose use of language. They were led to it by straining to make revealed matters require proof for both negation and affirmation, just as rational matters do. Thus you see them wavering: sometimes they say, 'The absence of proof is proof'; sometimes, 'It is established by analogy or consensus that anything for which no proof is found in the Law original freedom from liability is presumed to continue.'

The correct view is otherwise. Anything whose existence can be established only by revelation is presumed absent until something to the contrary is received; its absence is the better-known state. In such a case, either no proof at all should be demanded from people, or, if proof is demanded, it should be less than that demanded from someone affirming its existence, as with a claimant and a defendant.

R 142 · BA 169–170

Presumption of continuity (الاستصحاب) has several applications in this discipline. First is the continuation of original freedom from liability (البراءة الأصلية), discussed earlier. Second is retaining general scope until a specification is received. Third is retaining the text until abrogation is received. Fourth is retaining a ruling when the circumstance to which the Law attached it recurs. Fifth is retaining consensus—or, more generally, a revealed ruling established by transmission—in a case where the subject's ruling is thought to have changed because the subject itself has changed, as with selling a slave woman who has borne her master a child, and similar cases.

The Ẓāhirīs accept this presumption of continuity and thereby remain consistent with their principles. Those who do not allow in the Law the kind of reasoning called analogy by practitioners of this discipline hold that things remain in their original freedom from liability until revealed evidence is received. Similarly, once revealed evidence is received, the subject retains its ruling even if its attributes change, until evidence removing the ruling is received.

It is as though the situation here were the reverse of presuming original freedom from liability. There, absence was more evident, so proof was required from whoever affirmed; here, existence is more evident, so proof is required from whoever denies. Someone who accepts analogy in the Law must reject this kind of continuity, since he can say: we are charged to reason by analogy where there is no text. This subject's attribute has changed, so it has the status of a case for which no text has been received, because a change of attribute requires a change of ruling.

R 143 · BA 171

Here the discussion of the fourth source ends, and with it the discussion of the second part of this book, which comprises the sources of proofs.

R 144 · BA 172

Other sources may be supposed to exist, and we shall mention them. One is a Companion's statement, which is thought authoritative but is not. One may not follow uncritically someone whose protection from error has not been established; such protection is established only by a miracle, or by the bearer of a miracle declaring that the person is protected from error. Opinions differ: some confine this authority to particular Companions; others extend it to every Companion. In general, a Companion is one practitioner of independent judgement among others. The mind nevertheless inclines more readily to their opinions because of the indications accompanying them, and these indications led those who regard their statements as authoritative to that view.

R 145 · BA 173

Another is the law of those before us. The proof that this is not a source is that, were it a source, transmitting it would be a collective obligation. It cannot be right that the community should, at any time, lose knowledge of a collective obligation, given the proof of its protection from error. Had its transmission been a collective obligation, the Companions would have reported it and it would have been transmitted down to the present. As for provisions of earlier laws contained in the Book and commanded of us, they are commanded of us insofar as they are in the Book, not insofar as they are the law of those before us.

R 146 · BA 174

Others are juristic preference and consideration of welfare. If these mean a kind of analogy, evident or subtle, permissible in the Law in the manner allowed by its proponents, then it is a source on their view. If they do not mean that, they are not a source. In general, the Law has encouraged consideration of benefits, but to a certain extent and within a certain limit: where it has attested that they, or their kind, constitute a benefit. Whether analogy itself is a source will be discussed later.

R 147 · BA 175

Here the examination of the second part of this science ends. Praise be to God.

Part III

On the Third Part of the Abridgment

R 148 · BA 176

This part concerns the inquiry most distinctive of this science, as we explained earlier. It is divided according to the things through which the Prophet's meaning is understood, God bless him and grant him peace: either wording or an indication (قرينة).

R 149 · BA 176

Wording is divided into what indicates a ruling through its verbal form, and what indicates it through its understood import and intelligible meaning.

R 150 · BA 176

Indication is divided into two kinds: one is his action, God bless him and grant him peace; the other is his approval of a ruling.

1. On Unambiguous and Indeterminate Wording in Respect of Verbal Form

R 151 · BA 177

Let us begin by examining wording. We say: practitioners of this discipline customarily divide expressions and statements into the indeterminate (المجمل), the unambiguous (النص), what has an apparent meaning (الظاهر), and what is interpreted beyond that apparent meaning (المؤول). We should examine each division and explain what they signify by each. We say:

R 152 · BA 178

Expressions are either simple or compound. A simple expression is a noun, a verb, or a particle. A compound expression is composed of these, with a part of it signifying part of its meaning. Some compound expressions do not independently convey a complete meaning; others do. The latter divide into statements whose composition admits truth or falsehood, and ⟨utterances which do not⟩. The latter include commands, prohibitions, requests, entreaties, and calls.

R 153 · BA 179–181

Among expressions—whether nouns, particles, or verbs, simple or compound—some invariably convey one meaning through their forms in every context. These constitute part of what is meant by unambiguous wording (النص) in this discipline; let us call it unambiguous wording in respect of form. Others can convey more than one meaning. If they signify all these meanings equally, so that one can be understood only through proof or an indication, they constitute part of what this discipline calls indeterminate wording (المجمل); let us call it indeterminate wording in respect of form.

Some expressions originally apply to one thing and signify it more commonly, but are later transferred to something else because it resembles the original meaning; or one expression is substituted for another, relying on an indication to disclose the transferred or substituted meaning. When such expressions occur without accompanying indications, they are understood according to their original assignment. These constitute part of what this discipline calls apparent wording (الظاهر); following our practice, let us call it apparent wording in respect of form. When indications establish transfer or substitution, this constitutes part of what the discipline calls interpreted wording (المؤول); let us call it interpreted wording in respect of form.

This class includes terms established by specialised usage: terms originally assigned to certain things, then transferred in the Law to other things because of their resemblance to the original meanings or some relation to them. When these occur in the Law, their apparent meanings are the legal meanings; they are understood in their ordinary linguistic meanings only through interpretation.

R 154 · BA 182

Some expressions and statements signify through their understood imports, rather than through their verbal forms, because they have been altered by abridgement and omission or addition, and likewise by substitution and transfer. This class of expressions is called figurative usage (مجاز).

R 155 · BA 182

Within these, too, there are counterparts to the unambiguous, the indeterminate, the apparent, and the interpreted; but they possess these characteristics through accompanying indications, not through their forms. Thus ‘unambiguous wording’ as used in this discipline signifies two kinds: what is unambiguous in respect of form and what is unambiguous in respect of understood import. The apparent, the indeterminate, and the interpreted admit the same division.

R 156 · BA 183

This division of expressions into these classes seems to be the useful one in this discipline. We should examine them following the practitioners’ customary procedure, explain the authority of each as a revealed proof, and investigate statements thought to be uncertain between more than one of these classes. Let us begin with the divisions belonging to an expression by virtue of its form, and among these with simple expressions and expressions compounded as assertions.

R 157 · BA 184

As we have said, wording is unambiguous only when it conveys one meaning in every context. This occurs in both simple and compound expressions. Examples of simple expressions are ‘human being,’ ‘horse,’ and ‘animal.’ A compound example is God’s saying, ‘Say: He is God, One.’[28] In general, this includes every expression composed of unambiguous simple expressions, provided that its pronouns cannot refer to more than one meaning.

R 158 · BA 185

Indeterminate wording in respect of form is the opposite. Among simple expressions, an example is ʿayn, used equivocally for a spring of water, the eye of a balance, the eye with which one sees, and other things. A term may even signify a thing and its opposite, as qurʾ sometimes means a period of purity and sometimes menstruation. Indeterminacy in composition occurs in expressions compounded from such terms, or where the pronouns connecting the statement are ambiguous. An example is His saying, blessed and exalted, ‘Or the one in whose hand is the marriage bond remits it’[29]: the pronoun here may refer either to the guardian or to the husband.

R 159 · BA 186

In this discipline they apply the term ‘clarification’ to everything through which rulings may be established and understanding produced: an expression’s form, its understood import, and the other things enumerated earlier, according to their degrees in producing assent (التصديق). We shall discuss the authority of each as a revealed proof.

R 160 · BA 187–188

Indeterminate wording is not clarification, by consensus, and establishes no ruling at all. A question arises here: may an instruction be addressed through indeterminate wording pending clarification, or through apparent wording pending specification, at the time when clarification is needed? This is the question they designate as the permissibility of delaying clarification beyond the time of need. Some permit it, while others forbid it. Our account is as follows.

28. Qurʾān, al-Ikhlāṣ 112:1 ↗.
29. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:237 ↗.

R 161 · BA 189

Inquiry into this question is linguistic, so we should examine it from the standpoint appropriate to language. Surveying Arabic speech shows that Arabs address others with an equivocal term only where evidence indicates the intended meaning from among its other meanings, whether through a readily available contextual indication or something present in the wording itself. In God's saying, blessed and exalted, 'Then it became like al-ṣarīm,'[30] preceding descriptions of the thing compared indicate that al-ṣarīm here means night. Similarly, when they mean morning by al-ṣarīm, they say 'the light of al-ṣarīm,' or something comparable.

In general, addressing someone with indeterminate expressions while knowing with certainty that they remain indeterminate has never occurred; if it did, it would be idle speech. A speaker may, however, use an indeterminate term believing it very likely that he will be understood, relying on accompanying indications, while the addressee fails to understand him. The addressee may then seek clarification, and the speaker provide it. If the addressee sees that fulfilment of what he was addressed with is not required at that moment, he postpones his question until the time of need, and clarification is correspondingly delayed.

But for a speaker to address someone in indeterminate expressions, knowing with certainty that they are indeterminate and that the addressee understands nothing by them, while relying on explaining the intended meaning when the time of need arrives—this, as we have said, has never occurred among Arabs or anyone else. In general, such indeterminate address occurs only when a riddle or mockery of the addressee's disposition is intended. The same holds of wording indeterminate in its understood import. The Law has introduced no specialised convention altering this.

R 162 · BA 190

Apparent wording in respect of form also has, in my view, the same status as an equivocal term. This concerns what originally applies to something and has its apparent meaning in it, but is later transferred to another thing because of resemblance to the first meaning or some relation to it. When an Arab uses the word 'sky' without qualification, he is invariably understood to mean the starry sky. If he means rain, he indicates this through a contextual clue, as in 'We kept treading the sky until we reached you,' or 'When the sky falls upon a people's land.'

Otherwise, whenever such terms are used without qualification while something other than their established meaning is intended, this can occur only as an error; if deliberate, it is misleading. This concerns the time of need. If it is not yet the time of need, what benefit is there in speech that makes a person believe the opposite of what the subsequent clarification will convey? Apparent wording in respect of understood import seems to stand on the same footing.

R 163 · BA 191–194

As for apparent wording involving substitution (الإبدال)—general expressions by which something falling under them is intended—addressing people with these expressions without qualification or an accompanying indication identifying the specific meaning intended, deliberately postponing clarification until the time of need, does occur in language and in the Law. This is so when the addressees understand from contextual indications that there remains a question to ask, and that the speaker did not intend to confine himself to what he has already said.

30. Qurʾān, al-Qalam 68:20 ↗.

God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'God commands you to slaughter a cow,'[31] was of this kind. They kept asking, and the answers supplied specifications until the particular cow was identified for them[31]. If the addressees do not know from contextual indications that there is a question to ask, this does not occur. It is permissible with general wording, but not with indeterminate wording or the first kind of apparent wording, because someone who knows a thing through a universal description (كلي) knows it in some respect, while awaiting a more specific knowledge of it.

Statements composed of such descriptions are often clearer than names, or indispensable for things that have no names, as with the cow they were commanded to slaughter. On this basis, terms established by specialised usage may be used before the meanings signified by them are understood, relying on the addressees' knowledge that those terms signify meanings additional to their original assignment. The benefit is to produce resolve to obey the command even while its detailed clarification is deferred until the time of need—as with commanding almsgiving and pilgrimage before they become obligatory.

If you examine the cases cited by those who permit delaying clarification until the time of need without distinguishing among cases, you will find them included in the classes we have enumerated. Likewise, if you examine the evidence cited by those who [do not] permit it, you will find that it concerns wholly indeterminate wording admitting alternatives, and the first kind of apparent wording. In general, both positions, taken without qualification, are partly false, as positions supported by an induction that does not exhaust all particulars are liable to be false. That clarification may not be delayed beyond the time of need, however, is undisputed.

Having discussed indeterminate and unambiguous wording, let us turn to apparent and interpreted wording.

2. On Apparent and Interpreted Wording in Respect of Verbal Form

R 164 · BA 196

As we have said, apparent wording in respect of form is of two kinds. The first comprises expressions originally applied to one thing, then transferred to another because of resemblance or some relation between them. Transfer through resemblance is exemplified by calling a bed a 'nest'; transfer through another relation, by calling vegetation 'dew,' because it arises from dew. This class includes indirect expression, such as referring to excrement as 'the low ground' and sexual intercourse as 'touching.'

R 165 · BA 197

The second class of apparent expressions consists of substituted expressions. By substitution here we mean placing the universal (الكلي) in place of the particular (الجزئي), or the particular in place of the universal. Strictly speaking, substitution applies to all transferred expressions, which are then divided into the classes we have enumerated. We have nevertheless chosen to reserve the name 'substitution' (التبديل) for this class, namely the universal and the particular, although in reality everything substituted is transferred, and everything transferred is substituted.

R 166 · BA 198–199

When these two classes occur without qualification in the Law, they are understood in their apparent meanings until evidence indicates otherwise—that is, indicates that they should be understood in a transferred meaning, which is what is called interpretation (تأويل). That these expressions have these apparent significations is known necessarily through a survey of language. Their authority as revealed proof is known through the Companions' consensus on adopting apparent meanings and through the fact that the Law has introduced no specialised convention altering this.

31. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:67–71 ↗. The quoted command is 2:67; the subsequent questions and specifications are in 2:68–71.

Moreover, if we did not adopt apparent meanings, many acts of worship would lapse, because unambiguous texts (النصوص) are extremely scarce. The necessity calling for action upon solitary reports is here the necessity calling for action upon the apparent meanings of expressions. These expressions admit degrees of apparentness: the stronger an expression's apparent meaning, the stronger the evidence required to interpret it otherwise; conversely, the weaker its apparent meaning, the slighter the evidence sufficient for interpretation. Let us give three examples, one at the first degree, a second at the intermediate degree, and a third at the last degree, for both classes of apparent wording.

R 167 · BA 200–202

At the first degree among transferred terms is the interpretation of God's saying, mighty and majestic, 'Children of Adam, We have sent down upon you clothing to cover your nakedness,'[32] as meaning rain by 'clothing.' Such an interpretation requires evidence, since 'clothing' very strongly signifies what covers a person. The second degree is exemplified by interpreting God's saying, 'We sent Our messengers with clear proofs and sent down with them the Book and the balance,'[33] as meaning justice by 'the balance.'

The third degree is exemplified by God's saying, 'Or you have touched women.'[34] Some jurists understand this as touching with the hand; others as sexual intercourse. Although its apparent meaning is touching with the hand, it can quite plausibly mean intercourse, since this accords with Arab usage, and God Most High has referred indirectly to intercourse by massīs[35], which has the meaning of touching.

R 168 · BA 203

In general, degrees of apparentness in expressions depend on frequency or rarity of use. If use in the transferred meaning becomes as frequent as use in the original meaning, the expression stands equivocally between the first and second meanings and is indeterminate. The less frequently it is used in the second meaning, the more apparent it is in the first.

Interpretation of apparent wording may be self-evident or may require an explanation; it may amount to predominant probability or to certainty. A self-evident and certain example is their saying, 'We kept treading the sky until we reached you.' An example made clear by decisive proof is God's saying, 'The All-Merciful is established over the Throne'[36]: decisive proof has established that 'being established' here is not occupying a place.

R 169 · BA 204

The second class of apparent wording, which we called substituted wording, also has two kinds: universal wording (الكلي) and particular wording (الجزئي). Let us first examine the universal, which is the general (العام). General wording has many forms. Some dispute that expressions signify generality and that, when unqualified, they apparently encompass everything falling under them. Their objection has no basis: the matter is evident, and indeed shared by all tongues and languages. The Law has introduced no specialised convention changing it. The argument establishing its authority as revealed proof is the argument establishing the authority of apparent wording as such, which has already been given.

R 170 · BA 205–206

These expressions have many forms. They include plural nouns, with or without the definite article; names of genera, species, and classes when they have the definite article and do not end in the feminine ending, such as 'the fruit,' 'the date palm,' and 'the woman'; man and mā ('whoever' and 'whatever') when used (in conditional and consequential clauses), together with ayna and matā ('wherever' and 'whenever'); negative particles; and emphatic expressions such as 'all of them' and 'every one.'

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32. Qurʾān, al-Aʿrāf 7:26 ↗.
33. Qurʾān, al-Ḥadīd 57:25 ↗.
34. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:43 ↗; al-Māʾidah 5:6 ↗.
35. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:236–237 ↗. These verses use forms of "touch" for sexual intercourse.
36. Qurʾān, Ṭā Hā 20:5 ↗.

When these forms are used without qualification, they are generally understood in their full generality until evidence establishes a specification. They, too, admit degrees of apparentness, as did the first class. Their interpretive proofs have corresponding degrees, because evidence for interpretation must always signify more strongly than the expression's form. Examples at the respective degrees follow.

R 171 · BA 207

At the first degree of apparentness is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'Any woman who marries without her guardian's permission, her marriage is invalid.' Some apply this to a slave woman. When that proved untenable because of his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'She is entitled to the dower'—whereas a slave woman's dower belongs to her master—they applied it to a slave woman under a contract for emancipation. This is a remote interpretation.

R 172 · BA 208

The second degree is his saying, peace be upon him, 'There is no fasting for someone who has not resolved upon the fast during the night.' Some apply this to a fast making up a missed obligation and to a vowed fast. This interpretation is closer than the first.

R 173 · BA 209

The third degree is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'On what the sky waters, a tenth; on what is irrigated by drawing water, half a tenth.' Some apply this to everything, even taking almsgiving from vegetables. Others say that it is confined to the various grains from which almsgiving is taken.

R 174 · BA 210

These are the kinds of general expressions and their degrees of apparentness. Sometimes general wording (العام) occurs with a specific meaning (الخاص) intended, and this is clear from the outset—as when someone beating his child says, 'There is no good in children.' This understanding may be predominantly probable or certain, according to the particular indication. It may also become clear through proof, which itself may be decisive or predominantly probable. Sometimes we know that general wording is intended specifically without knowing which specific meaning is intended; its force may then be that of indeterminate wording (المجمل).

R 175 · BA 211

It remains to discuss kinds of expressions thought to have general scope when they do not, or thought not to have general scope when they do. We shall set out several questions on this.

R 176 · BA 212

Question. Generality in wording occurs when the Lawgiver uses it in an independent statement, or in reply to a question arising from a specific circumstance but frames the answer generally. For example, when asked about the well of Buḍāʿa, he said, God bless him and grant him peace, 'God created water as purifying; nothing renders it impure.' This statement is understood to concern all water, not only that well. Some regard such a statement as specific and confine it to the thing asked about, even when it is framed generally. Their position has no basis, for the matter is clear.

R 177 · BA 213

Question. An equivocal term does not have general scope encompassing everything to which it applies. Some hold otherwise, as do those who understand 'Or you have touched women'[37] to cover both intercourse and touching with the bodily member, the hand. A survey of Arabic speech shows the contrary: Arabs do not use the term ʿayn, for example, intending their hearer to understand all the meanings to which it applies. This is clearest in terms used for opposites. Someone might claim that such an inclusive meaning is understood through a specialised legal convention, but anyone making that claim must establish it.

37. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:43 ↗; al-Māʾidah 5:6 ↗.

R 178 · BA 214

Question. The expressions ‘people’ and ‘human being’ include the slave, the unbeliever, the male, and the female. ‘The believers’ includes the slave but does not include women, since its form is specifically a masculine plural.

R 179 · BA 215

Question. General wording may be understood without exhaustive inclusion. Abū Ḥāmid claims, however, that it cannot be reduced to less than the minimum denoted by a plural, on the view that the least number a plural denotes is two. This requires examination.

R 180 · BA 216

Question. A plural expression, when unqualified, denotes at least three or more, and is more apparent in that sense than in the sense of two; it is understood as two only through an accompanying indication. It is remarkable that anyone should understand unqualified plural expressions as denoting two, when two has its own distinctive form. That a plural may be used figuratively to mean two is not denied, but this is substitution and extended usage, like what occurs with other expressions conventionally assigned to something. Examining the cases cited by those who permit this shows them to be of that kind.

Investigators in this field, however, customarily fail, when discussing verbal signification, to distinguish an expression’s established signification from what it signifies by extended use and transfer. Thus we see them saying that a plural applies to two just as it applies to three or more. This is what has misled those investigating this question in this discipline when they appeal to Sībawayh and other grammarians, and to examples occurring in Arabic speech.

Nor is this alone found in their speech—I mean using a plural form to signify two. They may also use it to signify one, but do so by way of magnification, as when they say, ‘He is all people,’ or ‘He is the young man, the whole of a young man.’

R 181 · BA 217–218

As explained earlier, these general expressions may occur with a specific meaning intended. Sometimes this is clear from the outset; sometimes it is not and requires evidence: wording, an action, an approval, or one of the other proofs used in this discipline. Accordingly, when one seeks to specify general wording through any of these, one must consider which has the stronger rank in producing predominant probability.

Opinions differ concerning the specification of general wording through these other revealed proofs. Some hold that when a general statement concerning something is received together with a specification —whether through verbal form, understood import, action, or approval—the two have the status of conflicting evidence. The general statement may, for example, have come later than the specifying evidence, whether wording, action, or approval, and thus abrogate it, unless it is known that the specification followed the general statement as clarification delayed until the time of need. This is the position of Dāwūd and his followers.

R 182 · BA 219

Those who permit specifying general wording through such proofs without knowing their chronological order appeal to the Companions’ practice of doing so and of making the specific govern the general. On this view, the general and specific have one of two relations: either the general expression comes after the specific, which then serves as an indication specifying the general, since the wording admits this; or the specific comes after the general and is acted upon.

In general, as we have said, whoever permits specification through such proofs should follow whichever ranks highest in predominant probability. This predominance may arise from the wording or from its transmission. Thus someone may permit specifying general wording through an unambiguous text, yet refuse this in the Qurʾān because the Qurʾān is established by mass transmission—when the specifying text is transmitted through solitary routes.

R 183 · BA 220

Exception is a kind of specification of general wording, but differs from specification in that it does not occur separately from the expression to which it belongs. There is therefore no basis for permitting an exception to be postponed. We should discuss this. The forms of exception are well known; the kinds that require examination here are the following.

R 184 · BA 221

An exception may be connected, where the thing excepted belongs to the same genus as that from which it is excepted; or disconnected, where it belongs to a different genus. Language specialists call the latter a discontinuous exception. An exception may also follow a single complete sentence, or several sentences. We shall examine both these divisions.

R 185 · BA 222

There is no disagreement over an exception belonging to the same genus as that from which it is excepted. Disagreement concerns an exception belonging to another genus. Some reject it, saying that there is no sense in excepting what the preceding statement did not include, and that calling such a thing an exception is idle speech. Those who permit it appeal to its occurrence in language, as in God's sayings, 'For they are enemies to me, except the Lord of the worlds,'[38] and 'Do not consume your wealth among yourselves wrongfully, except that it be an immediate transaction.'[39]

A comparable instance is the poet's saying, 'No one is at the campsite except the horse tethering places.' The term 'anyone' does not apply to tethering places. Another poet says, 'And a land with no companion in it, except gazelles and except white camels.' Arabs also customarily say, 'There is no man in the house except a woman.' In general, this is well known and frequent in their speech.

The first group rejects it on theoretical grounds; the second appeals to its actual occurrence, but has been unable to explain how it is valid in speech according to known Arab usage, and thereby resolve the difficulty raised earlier.

R 186 · BA 223

Our account is this: as explained earlier, Arabs customarily substitute the universal for the particular and the particular for the universal, relying on accompanying indications and extended usage. If a Bedouin says, for example, 'There is no man in the house,' his negation may be understood to extend beyond men; hence he adds the exception, 'except a woman.' The same holds of 'And a land with no companion in it.' On the account we have given, the thing excepted does not belong to a genus different from that from which it is excepted.

The difference from the first kind is that the first excepts something from the general scope conveyed by the expression's form, whereas this excepts it from the general scope conveyed by its understood import, not its form. If you examine the occurrences of such exceptions, you will find them to be as we have described; otherwise, the statement would be contradictory and idle, incapable of sustaining intelligible conversation.

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38. Qurʾān, al-Shuʿarāʾ 26:77 ↗.
39. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:29 ↗; al-Baqarah 2:282 ↗. The quotation combines wording from these two verses; "an immediate transaction" comes from 2:282. The author's wording is retained.

R 187 · BA 224

If an exception follows several sentences joined by ‘and,’ and ‘and’ makes them share or combine in one meaning, the more evident reading is that the exception refers to everything mentioned. If ‘and’ joins them without making them share one meaning, and the joined meanings are multiple, the case is different. An example is God’s saying, ‘Those who accuse chaste women and then do not produce four witnesses: lash them eighty times, never accept their testimony, and they are the wrongdoers—except those who repent thereafter and make amends.’[40]

Another example is His saying, ‘Its expiation is feeding ten needy people from the average of what you feed your families, or clothing them, or freeing a slave; whoever cannot find the means must fast three days.’[41] In such cases the more evident course is to suspend judgement until evidence, whether a contextual indication or something else, shows what the exception refers to.

R 188 · BA 225

As for whether the amount remaining after an exception may be smaller than the amount excepted, this is something that has not occurred in Arabic speech, since such an expression would almost amount to an inability to express oneself. It is an incongruous way of speaking to say, ‘I saw a hundred, except ninety-nine.’

R 189 · BA 226

Question. When general wording is qualified by an attribute or made conditional on something, there should be no disagreement about acting upon it subject to that condition. If it occurs unqualified in one context and then qualified in the same context—what they call construing the unqualified in light of the qualified—the majority adopt that construction. An example is his saying, peace be upon him, ‘There is no marriage without two witnesses,’ alongside his saying, peace be upon him, ‘There is no marriage without two witnesses of probity.’

Some hold that the unqualified statement retains its unqualified scope, that the qualification serves to emphasize, and that it conflicts with the unqualified statement only through contrary implication (دليل الخطاب). Generality is stronger than contrary implication—I mean the generality present in the unqualified statement. If, however, the general expression is qualified in a context different from the one in which it was unqualified, there is no basis for construing it as qualified without proof or a contextual indication.

R 190 · BA 227

This is the account of general verbal forms, and of the circumstances in which they are understood generally and those in which they are not. It remains to discuss the second class of apparent wording, namely specific expressions. Let us turn to them.

3. On specific expressions

R 191 · BA 228–233

Some of these are names of individuals, and others are names of genera and species. When we call such expressions “specific” (خاص), we do so relatively: something is called specific in relation to the general term above it, and general in relation to the specific term below it.

40. Qurʾān, al-Nūr 24:4–5 ↗.
41. Qurʾān, al-Māʾidah 5:89 ↗.

When these expressions name individuals, they are construed as bearing the specific meaning required by their forms, rather than a meaning encompassing that specific meaning. This is their prima facie import (ظاهر), just as expressions of generality prima facie retain their general scope until evidence of restriction appears. Similarly, names of genera and species prima facie encompass what falls under them, while delimiting the meanings their forms initially signify from anything more general, until evidence requires generalization. Here too there are degrees of prima facie clarity.

Just as speakers customarily substitute the general universal for the specific particular, so here they customarily substitute the specific particular for the general, relying on contextual indications (قرائن). This too may be evident in itself and certain, or it may rest on a preponderant probability, or it may not be evident in itself. Sometimes the occurrence of substitution is itself evident, while it remains unclear which universal the particular has been substituted for.

An example evident in itself and certain is His exalted saying, “Do not say ‘Uff’ to the two of them,”[42] and the Prophet’s saying, peace be upon him, “Hand over the thread and the needle.” Examples evident in themselves but not certain are the prohibition of entering the mosque smelling of garlic, and of drinking from silver vessels. An example not evident in itself is his prohibition, peace be upon him, concerning wheat exchanged for wheat—the four commodities mentioned. Some understood it as referring to staple nourishment, others to food, and others to goods measured by volume; others confined the ruling to the stated text.

R 192 · BA 234

This completes the discussion of indeterminate, unambiguous, prima facie, and interpreted expressions with respect to their forms. It remains to discuss them with respect to their understood meaning (مفهوم).

4. On expressions signifying through their understood meaning

R 193 · BA 235

As we said before, an expression signifies through its understood meaning when some of its parts are omitted, something is added to it, or it is used metaphorically or by substitution. In such cases its signification comes only through contextual indications. If the contextual indication is unvarying and decisive as to its understood meaning, the expression is again called unambiguous (نص). If it supplies a preponderant probability, it is called prima facie (ظاهر); if it supplies probability without preponderance, it is called indeterminate (مجمل), and evidence for it is sought elsewhere.

Examples involving metaphor and substitution have already been given. What remains for us here is the case in which this occurs through omission. We say:

R 194 · BA 236–239

An example having the status of an unambiguous expression is His exalted saying, “Ask the village in which we were.”[43] It is known with certainty that He means the inhabitants of the village. Likewise, in His exalted saying, “Forbidden to you are your mothers,”[44] what is certainly understood here is marriage.

An example in this class resembling a prima facie expression is his saying, peace be upon him, “There is no fast for one who has not resolved upon the fast overnight.” This may mean that the fast is not complete, or that the fast is not accepted at all; the latter is more apparent. An example thought indeterminate is his saying, peace be upon him, “Whoever has caught one cycle of the prayer has caught the prayer.” It is undecided whether this means obtaining the prayer’s merit, its legal effect, or its appointed time.

42. Qurʾān, al-Isrāʾ 17:23 ↗. The Arabic quotation has wa-lā where the verse has fa-lā; the author’s wording is retained.
43. Qurʾān, Yūsuf 12:82 ↗.
44. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:23 ↗.

A particularly well-known kind within this class is what they call inference from the discourse (دليل الخطاب). Something is mentioned subject to a qualification or condition, and a ruling is attached to it. It is then judged probable that the ruling belongs to it insofar as it bears that qualification or description, and that, when the description is absent, the ruling ceases to apply and its contradictory applies instead.

This class has several kinds. They disagree over whether these constitute legal evidence. Some have allowed none of them as evidence at all; some have allowed all of them; others have allowed some and denied others. We say concerning this:

R 195 · BA 240–241

Its kinds include mentioning something qualified by a description, as in his saying, peace be upon him, “Zakāt is due on grazing sheep.” Another is to make something conditional through one of the conditional particles, as in “Whoever enters the house, give him a dirham.” This, in their view, occupies a stronger rank.

Another restricts a ruling through a restrictive particle: innamā or the definite article al-, as in his saying, peace be upon him, “The rights of clientage belong only to the emancipator,” or in “The property belongs to Zayd.” Another qualifies something by an endpoint, expressed by “until” or “up to.” It seems that everyone has accepted this kind. Examples are His exalted sayings, “Do not approach them until they become pure,”[45] “until she marries a husband other than him,”[46] and His exalted saying, “Complete the fast until nightfall.”[47]

It is virtually known that night differs from day in that fasting does not extend to it; likewise the menstruating woman’s condition after purification differs from her condition beforehand, as does that of the divorced woman after marrying a husband. Within this manner of speaking and all its kinds, some cases must be recognised as resembling the unambiguous and possessing its force: those in which the ruling is known to depend on the qualification or condition. Others resemble the prima facie or the indeterminate. In the discussion of qiyās we shall indicate the ranks of contextual indications that establish these degrees of signification.

R 196 · BA 242

Here ends the discussion of assertions and their components. Let us now examine commands and prohibitions.

5. On commands and prohibitions

R 197 · BA 243

We must also examine whether these admit the preceding division: whether unambiguous, prima facie, and indeterminate cases occur among them; and, if so, whether this is through their forms or through their understood meaning.

Meaningful speech, as has been said, divides into assertion, command, request, address, and supplication. Plainly, Arabic does not possess a distinct form for each of command, request, and supplication: they are distinguished by circumstantial indications. Addressed by a superior to a subordinate, it is a command; by a subordinate to a superior, a supplication; and by an equal to an equal, a request. Each of these three has an opposite. The opposite of command is prohibition, but the opposites of request and supplication have no names.

45. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:222 ↗.
46. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:230 ↗.
47. Qurʾān, al-Baqarah 2:187 ↗. The Arabic quotation begins wa-atimmū; the verse has thumma atimmū.

R 198 · BA 244

Our purpose here is to discuss command and prohibition among these divisions. A legal demand (اقتضاء) cannot be conceived as taking the form of a request—unless "request" is taken here as a generic term divided into obligation and recommendation. It is preferable, however, that "command" should admit this division.

They have disagreed whether the meanings of commands [subsisting] in the soul have particular forms that signify them intrinsically and primarily. If they have forms, do these unambiguously require obligation or recommendation? Or is one of the two more apparent, with the form directed to the other by interpretation, in the manner of interpreting a prima facie expression? Or are the forms indeterminate between obligation and recommendation?

Those who hold that commands possess signifying forms also disagree whether those forms require immediate performance, allow delay, or remain undecided between these. Likewise, they disagree whether the forms require repetition or performance once.

R 199 · BA 244

We begin this inquiry by considering how these forms stand in linguistic convention and in legal usage. We say:

R 200 · BA 245–247

No one denies that Arabic has forms expressing a demand, such as "Go out! Depart!" These forms can nevertheless occur with the intention of threatening and deterring an action, as in His exalted saying, "Eat and enjoy yourselves a little."[48] Generally, however, permission is their more apparent import; they signify threat only metaphorically. Likewise, when speakers intend prohibition, they combine the particle lā with these forms, and the resulting combination signifies prohibition through its structure and form.

Whether these forms signify command intrinsically by linguistic convention is not evident from them; still less is it evident that there are forms signifying obligation or recommendation as such. These are legal meanings, not meanings of ordinary usage. By legal usage, however, the forms undoubtedly contain the meaning of command. Whether they contain obligation or recommendation is disputed. Most jurists hold that commands prima facie signify obligation in the Law, and are directed to recommendation by evidence. Some suspend judgement and regard them as indeterminate.

This should be investigated inductively in the Law, examining how the Companions, may God be pleased with them, received commands when they appeared without contextual indications. Construing them as obligatory seems more prudent, since the circumstances of the Law show that its commands have a firm and decisive character. There is no sense in assigning them what someone claims is the least that a command signifies—recommendation—on the alleged ground that this always accompanies command.

R 201 · BA 247–248

Obligation and recommendation are two distinct meanings. Either the expression is equivocal between them or one is its more apparent meaning. If no established legal convention can be shown for these forms, commands remain indeterminate between recommendation and obligation until evidence indicates one of them.

As for whether their forms signify immediacy or delay, this is not contained in them: the determination depends upon circumstantial indications. Hence, when the person commanded is uncertain, it is appropriate to ask "When?" Nor is repetition of the act required merely by the imperative. It requires at least one performance, and is as it were prima facie in that sense, and it is construed ⟨as repeated⟩ only when a further indication is subsequently supplied.

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48. Qurʾān, al-Mursalāt 77:46 ↗.

R 202 · BA 249

Several questions attach to this discussion; we shall set them out in their customary manner.

R 203 · BA 250

Question. When a command to do something follows a prohibition, some hold that this circumstance redirects the demand which, standing alone, would signify either [obligation] or recommendation, so that it now signifies permission. Others hold that this is not a contextual indication: the form of demand retains its original understood meaning.

Abū Ḥāmid says: The preferred view is that, when the prohibition arises for a particular ground and the imperative “Do!” is made conditional upon its cessation—as in His exalted saying, “When you leave the state of consecration, hunt”[49]—customary usage indicates the removal of restriction. It may admit recommendation or [obligation], but the meaning just mentioned is more apparent.

R 204 · BA 251

Question. The jurists’ position is that an obligation to make up a missed observance (قضاء) does not require a [renewed] command. Those who carefully distinguish the issues hold that a command to worship at a specified time does not require making it up. Specifying a time for worship—prayer at midday or fasting in Ramadan—is like specifying a place for pilgrimage or a direction for prayer. If the commanded condition is absent, the command ceases to apply, when it was on account of that condition that the command concerning the act was issued.

R 205 · BA 252

Question. The jurists hold that a command entails the sufficiency of the commanded act (إجزاء) when it is fulfilled, without an obligation to make it up. Others say that a command does not entail sufficiency: someone who has invalidated his pilgrimage is commanded to complete it, yet this does not suffice, and he must perform it again.

The correct formulation is that a command entails the sufficiency of the commanded act when it is performed completely, with its prescribed character and all its conditions. If a defect affects it, as with an invalidated pilgrimage, the command does not indicate sufficiency. This completes the discussion of command forms.

R 206 · BA 253

Know that the discussion of prohibitive forms parallels that of commands, and its questions correspond to theirs. Whoever construes a command form as imposing obligation construes a prohibitive form as imposing interdiction, and prohibition as indicating the invalidity of the prohibited act. Whether the prohibition concerns the act without qualification or with a description or condition, it renders the underlying act invalid insofar as it bears that qualification or condition.

R 207 · BA 253

This is the question mentioned earlier in Part One, where we said that the present place would be more appropriate for discussing it.

R 208 · BA 254

Anyone who considers a command form undecided between obligation and recommendation must likewise consider a prohibitive expression undecided between interdiction and disapproval. This holds whether it concerns the underlying act without qualification or with a description or a cause external to it.

49. Qurʾān, al-Māʾidah 5:2 ↗.

Some who hold that commands and prohibitions have forms requiring obligation and interdiction nevertheless treat their application to an act qualified by an external cause as a contextual indication. On this account the forms cease to convey obligation and interdiction and instead convey recommendation and disapproval. This completes the discussion of evidence received through expressions.

R 209 · BA 255

It remains for us to discuss signifying contextual indications, such as the Prophet's silence and tacit approval, God bless him and grant him peace. Before that, however, we must examine the evidence they call qiyās.

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6. On qiyās: analogy and syllogistic inference

R 210 · BA 256–257

We must examine whether qiyās is legal evidence and, if it is, whether it belongs to the kinds already discussed. Our approach will be to investigate what the term qiyās signifies for them in this discipline. We say:

They describe it as assimilating one of two things to the other in affirming or denying a ruling, when the affirmation or denial is more apparent in one than in the other, because they share a ground or attribute. They call the thing in which the ruling is more apparent the original case (أصل); the thing assigned the ruling because it holds in the original case, the derivative case (فرع); and the shared attribute or cause, the operative ground (علة).

R 211 · BA 258

One should not object to our saying "two things" rather than, as in their description, "two objects of knowledge," on the alleged ground that "thing" does not apply to the nonexistent: the nonexistent is scarcely ever made a basis of comparison. Even granting their point, nothing prevents calling the nonexistent a thing insofar as it exists in the soul. Some things are in the soul as they are outside it; others are in the soul without existing outside it. In general, the theologians should not have quibbled with the Muʿtazila over this.

Nor should one attend to their saying, "because of a common factor, whether an attribute or a cause, or the negation of these in both." Negation as negation does not require one ruling for two things—except where negation has the force of privation, and privation follows an attribute that requires a ruling for both things. Our discussion has carried us away from our initial purpose. Let us return to where we were and say:

R 212 · BA 259–260

Examining what they mean by qiyās here shows that it is not a syllogism, but belongs to using a particular expression in place of the intended universal. The evidence is that the original case receives its ruling through a text or consensus. If the operative ground requiring the ruling is expressly stated and is more general than the original case, this belongs to general expression. An example is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, concerning water left by a cat: "[The cat] is not impure, because it is among those that circulate around you, male or female." This too has degrees; many who reject qiyās allow such cases.

If the ground requiring the ruling is not expressly stated, but the expression's understood meaning requires it and it is more general than the original case, this is using a particular expression in place of the intended universal. We then assign the ruling to anything shown, through independent inquiry or sense perception, to fall under that universal. An example is his prohibition of drinking from silver vessels, God bless him and grant him peace. Extravagance is understood from it; hence we extend the ruling to gold vessels.

R 213 · BA 261

Since this is so, what they mean by qiyās in this discipline generally comes back to what expressions require through their understood meanings. Expressions require this only through accompanying contextual indications—not just any indications, but those whose kind the Law demonstrably takes into account. The situation is thus like that of ordinary communication.

Just as the contextual indications on which a Bedouin relies when addressing another must be known to the addressee, and the speaker's attention to them in speaking must be known, so it must be in the Law. We shall indicate them individually and arrange them according to the rank of each in clarity.

R 214 · BA 262

As we said, contextual indications can make a statement unambiguous through its understood meaning, when they establish its metaphor or substitution decisively; or prima facie through its understood meaning, when they are preponderant rather than decisive; or indeterminate, when they remain undecided. We should therefore indicate their ranks here, although they are difficult to delimit precisely. We say:

R 215 · BA 263

The first rank has the status of an unambiguous expression: the ruling applies with greater reason to the unmentioned case than to the stated one. Examples are His exalted saying, "God does not wrong anyone by an atom's weight,"[50] and His saying, mighty and exalted, "Do not say 'Uff' to the two of them"[51]; likewise the Prophet's saying, peace be upon him, "Hand over the thread and the needle," and similar expressions. This has a range of clarity. They call it the purport of the discourse (فحوى الخطاب), and most do not call it qiyās.

R 216 · BA 264

The second rank is where the unmentioned case has the same relevant meaning as the stated case with respect to the ruling. An example is his saying, peace be upon him, "Whoever emancipates his share in a slave must have the remainder assessed against him." The case of a female slave is included with that of a male slave, since it has the same relevant meaning. They call this analogy within the meaning of the original case (القياس في معنى الأصل). This too has a range of greater and lesser clarity.

R 217 · BA 265–266

The third rank is of the same kind as the second: it is prima facie. In most cases, however, its clarity is weaker, so we have placed it third. Here the unmentioned case is joined to the stated one because of a shared benefit (مصلحة), whose kind the Law has acknowledged as beneficial. They call this analogy from a plausible, suitable ground (القياس المخيل والمناسب).

This kind has degrees of proximity and remoteness. When it is very close, they call it a congruent suitable ground (المناسب الملائم); many proponents of qiyās stop here. When it is intermediate, they do not call it congruent, but suitable and plausible. When it is very remote and completely general, as when we simply say "benefit," many proponents of qiyās reject it. Some jurists reason in this way when holding that divorce pronounced by a sick man does not cut off inheritance.

This last kind rightly deserves rejection as legal evidence, since benefits often diverge and vary with each time and circumstance. Those who reason this way are in fact legislating, rather than deriving rulings from the Law. An example is someone's saying, "New rulings arise for people in proportion to the new wickedness they introduce," or words to that effect. Mālik, God have mercy upon him, has been reproached for this, because he often attends to this kind.

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50. Qurʾān, al-Nisāʾ 4:40 ↗.
51. Qurʾān, al-Isrāʾ 17:23 ↗. The Arabic quotation has wa-lā where the verse has fa-lā; the author's wording is retained.

R 218 · BA 267

The fourth rank is what they call analogy by resemblance (قياس الشبه). The unmentioned case is joined to the stated one neither because it has a stronger claim, nor because it shares the same relevant meaning, nor because of a suitable operative ground. Rather, a resemblance between them suggests that it contains a ground common to both cases and appropriate to the ruling, although that ground has not been identified.

Most cases of this kind seem indeterminate, unless they join the second rank, which is within the meaning of the original case. An example is his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, “Do not sell wheat for wheat—the four known commodities—except hand to hand.” Some say he intended staple nourishment, some food, and some goods measured by volume. All this is their probable judgement: nourishment, measure, or edibility circumscribes the suitable factor requiring prohibition. To me this seems the remotest contextual indication used to understand a universal meaning from a particular expression. Many therefore confine such a report to what its wording requires.

R 219 · BA 268–269

Know that the classes of prescribed matters differ in how clearly these contextual indications appear within them. Hence Abū Ḥanīfa did not permit qiyās in fixed penalties and expiations. It is clearer in matters of necessity, such as sale, marriage, and the like. As we said before, when an expression first appears it may be unknown whether it is a specific expression substituted for a general one. In some cases that is known, but the universal for which it has been substituted is unknown.

R 220 · BA 269

Here proponents of qiyās employ the kind of inference called testing and division (السبر والتقسيم). Some, though fewer, also employ positive and negative concomitance (الطرد والعكس). We must explain how they use these.

R 221 · BA 270

When it is unknown whether a particular expression has been used to express a universal meaning, testing and division proceeds as follows. We say: either this particular expression is used to express a universal meaning or it retains its original meaning. We then show that it does not retain that meaning. Next we must determine which universal is intended. We enumerate all the universal meanings probably intended by the particular expression, eliminate them one by one until only one remains, and judge that this is the universal intended by that particular.

If it is apparent from the outset that a particular expression has been substituted for a universal, but not apparent which universal, we employ testing and division to determine it.

R 222 · BA 271

Positive concomitance (طرد) occurs when a ruling is given concerning something and we assign it to another thing because of a resemblance we find between them, applying it uniformly to the latter. On this basis we judge that the expression has been cast in particular form while intending the universal in which the two resemble one another.

This procedure may be strengthened by considering both presence and absence: any universal whose presence brings the ruling and whose absence removes it is taken as the ground on which the ruling depends (مناط الحكم). This is what they call negative concomitance (عكس). Most proponents of qiyās agree in rejecting the determination of a ruling’s ground through positive and negative concomitance.

R 223 · BA 272–273

In general, it appears that in most cases proponents of qiyās in the Law do not use it to derive an unknown ruling from a known one, in the way an unknown conclusion is derived from intellectually apprehended premises. They use it to establish the correctness of substituting expressions in each context and case. What they call analogy from a plausible, suitable ground and analogy by resemblance are contextual indications of verbal substitution. They are not syllogisms and perform no syllogistic operation, although those studying this discipline have not clearly recognised the distinction.

This is evident from their arguments against those who reject qiyās, whom they call the Ẓāhirīs (أهل الظاهر, "People of the Apparent"). The latter confronted them with a difficulty they could not escape: where knowledge comes through revelation and God's command, intellects have no part in affirming or denying anything of it. Moreover, rulings are not attributes of things' essences that intellects can apprehend. In general, qiyās has no part in whatever depends upon authoritative instruction (توقيف); its means of knowledge is transmitted communication (سمع), as with languages and similar things.

This objection applies only to someone who reasons from an original case whose wording contains no indication pointing to the underlying ground—for example, analogising the penalty for wine drinking to that for an unsubstantiated accusation of illicit intercourse (قذف). It does not apply to someone whose original case includes its operative ground in the understood meaning, even if the verbal form does not contain it. Most legal instances of qiyās belong to this kind. Had they understood this point, they could have answered their opponents.

R 224 · BA 273

The Ẓāhirīs, and anyone allowing inference from expressions' prima facie forms, should therefore not deny analogy within the original case's meaning, or analogy from a plausible and congruently suitable ground, when the Law demonstrably attends to its proximate kind. These are all contextual indications that [make] expressions prima facie through their understood meanings, even when they are not so through their forms. There is no sense in recognising prima facie signification only in verbal form.

R 225 · BA 274

Proponents of qiyās have sought to establish it through the Companions' consensus. They transmitted statements from many Companions which, they claimed, support qiyās. The Ẓāhirīs challenged them on two grounds. First, consensus itself was unestablished: such statements were not transmitted from all the Companions, and, as explained earlier, a speaker's statement cannot be attributed to someone silent. Second, had consensus occurred, disagreement would not have been transmitted from the Successors. They also cited reports from the Companions rejecting qiyās. In general, its proponents could not establish their claimed consensus.

Moreover, the Companions' transmitted expressions about qiyās admit several interpretations. On examination they seem likely to disclose the meaning we have assigned to qiyās: the Companions were exercising independent inquiry into expressions' understood meanings. What the Ẓāhirīs seem entitled to resist is deriving substitution or metaphor through testing and division, or through other procedures, when none of the contextual indications we have enumerated is present.

Anyone who permits that procedure should permit it for all expressions involving substitution, metaphor, omission, or, generally, alteration. Just as these contextual indications can generalise a specific expression, they can also restrict a general one.

R 226 · BA 275

This discussion has shown what the term qiyās signifies in this discipline, which class of legal evidence it belongs to, and where it may and may not be used. Among the ways of legal evidence, there remain the Prophet's action and tacit approval, God bless him and grant him peace. These are evidence through their character as contextual indications, rather than through verbal forms or understood meanings. We shall discuss each of them and its force.

7. On tacit approval

R 227 · BA 276

As for his tacit approval, God bless him and grant him peace: when an act is done in his presence and it is certainly known that he saw and approved it, this shows that the act may occur in that manner and—if it is a legal judgement—that it is binding. Or it shows permissibility when the act had been supposed forbidden. This follows from his established protection from error in what he called people to and in what he approved, God bless him and grant him peace.

8. On action

R 228 · BA 277

His actions, God bless him and grant him peace, are of several kinds. One explains a general or indeterminate expression. Such an action by him, God bless him and grant him peace, bears the ruling of the general expression: if that is recommended, the action is recommended; if obligatory, the action is obligatory. The evidence is his saying, peace be upon him, "Pray as you have seen me pray, and take your pilgrimage rites from me."

R 229 · BA 278–279

The second kind is the opposite: it is known through a circumstantial or verbal indicator ⟨that the action is peculiar to him. The third is⟩ intermediate between these two: actions of his, God bless him and grant him peace, for which it is unknown whether they explain an indeterminate expression, clarify a general one, or are peculiar to him. Here people disagree. Some construe them as obligatory, others as recommended, and others withhold judgement. This is Abū Ḥāmid's preferred view, because an action has no verbal form.

Those construing the action as obligatory cite prima facie expressions that nevertheless admit other meanings, such as His exalted saying, "In God's Messenger you have a good example."[52] Those construing it as recommended appeal to the Companions' imitation of his actions, God bless him and grant him peace: removing their sandals in prayer when he removed his, and refraining from shaving in the year of al-Ḥudaybiyya until he shaved. Proponents of obligation can also appeal to these actions of the Companions, may God be pleased with them.

In reply, someone who holds that an action establishes no ruling may say: the Companions acted this way only where they knew, from either circumstantial indications or a statement, that he, God bless him and grant him peace, was explaining obligations or recommendations through his action. In general, the question admits independent judgement. The more apparent view is that no ruling can be assigned on the basis of this kind of action by him, God bless him and grant him peace, since it remains undecided between obligation, recommendation, permission, and being peculiar to him.

When his actions, peace be upon him, explain [an indeterminate expression] or clarify a general one and conflict, they have the same status as two conflicting statements. We shall discuss this later, as also the conflict of an action with a statement. Here ends the discussion in Part Three of this book.

52. Qurʾān, al-Aḥzāb 33:21 ↗.

Part Four

R 230 · BA 281

It comprises three chapters: one on independent juristic inquiry, one on following authority, and one on weighing the evidence.

Chapter One. On independent juristic inquiry

R 231 · BA 282

Its discussion divides into examination of the independent jurist (مجتهد), the subject of his inquiry, and independent inquiry itself (اجتهاد). Independent inquiry is the jurist's exertion of his utmost capacity in seeking an answer by means of the instruments required of him.

The definition of the independent jurist is that he knows the sources from which he derives rulings and possesses the rules and requisite conditions by which he derives them. Since the sources are three—the Book, the Sunna, and consensus—we must state how much knowledge of each suffices for him.

R 232 · BA 283

Sufficient knowledge of the Book consists in knowing the verses containing rulings and distinguishing the abrogating from the abrogated among them; they number about five hundred verses. This is a concession: knowing the whole Book is preferable. He is also excused from memorising the verses containing rulings if he knows where they occur, so that when a question arises he knows where to look for them.

R 233 · BA 284

Sufficient knowledge of the Sunna consists in knowing the reports that contain rulings. He may be excused from memorising them: it is enough to possess a corrected collection of all the reports containing rulings, to which he can refer when a legal opinion is needed. Memorizing them is preferable.

As for knowing the soundness of their transmission chains, if he relies on someone he trusts, such as al-Bukhārī or Muslim, he is following authority. Yet if he must himself establish the transmitters' uprightness and investigate their biographies, circumstances, and dates, the task becomes protracted and immensely intricate, especially as time grows distant. The concession is to accept a leading scholar's accreditation, provided he knows that scholar's approach to discrediting and accrediting transmitters and it agrees with his own.

R 234 · BA 285

As for consensus, he should know all the questions on which consensus has been reached. It may suffice that he knows his opinion on the question he is answering does not oppose consensus, by knowing that it agrees with an opinion someone has held. Before all this, he must possess enough knowledge of vocabulary and language to understand the Book of God, exalted is He, and the Sunna of His Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, without linguistic error.

R 235 · BA 286

They also require knowledge of theology (علم الكلام): possession of the evidence giving knowledge of God and His attributes, leading to knowledge of the world's origination, and the other matters theology contains. This is required only on the view that the first obligation is rational examination and inference. On the other view, faith based simply on the Law suffices without rational examination. As for the derived details of jurisprudence, he has no need of them, because it is the independent jurist who generates them.

R 236 · BA 287

These requirements as a whole apply to the independent jurist in the unrestricted sense, who can give a legal opinion in every case. Someone who possesses only some of them may exercise independent inquiry in a question for which the requirements he possesses are sufficient. His relation to that question is the same as that of the unrestricted independent jurist to all questions.

R 237 · BA 288

The subject of independent inquiry is every legal ruling for which there is no decisive evidence. We must consider whether the ruling sought is determinate in itself and one is charged with attaining it, or whether no determinate ruling exists toward which the inquiry is directed, the obligation resting solely on attaining a preponderant judgement. On the latter account, every independent jurist would be correct, even when their opinions on the same thing contradict one another. We say:

R 238 · BA 289

Whoever holds that rulings are attributes of things' essences—whether known when the Law is added, or beforehand, or with both kinds among them, as the Muʿtazila hold—cannot declare every independent jurist correct. The same applies to those rejecting qiyās in the Law. They too hold that whatever has received no legal discourse remains under original freedom from obligation, as permissible; whereas something receiving legal discourse has a determinate ruling.

R 239 · BA 290

Our own position has already been stated: legal rulings are apprehended through discourse, which sometimes requires a ruling through its form and sometimes through its understood meaning. What they mean by qiyās falls within this class. Both kinds divide, with respect to the obligation to act on them, into unambiguous and prima facie indications. Consequently, one cannot maintain that every independent jurist is correct, since rulings are received through the given discourse in all the kinds we have enumerated, whether verbal expression or contextual indication.

Where knowledge comes through discourse, there is undoubtedly a determinate ruling: that to which the discourse relates. What the given discourse does not contain, and no contextual indication signifies, remains under original freedom from obligation and is excused. This is one kind of permission ascribed to the Law. This is the meaning of His saying, mighty and exalted, "We have neglected nothing in the Book"[53]: nothing bearing a ruling is left uncontained there; whatever it does not contain through any of the forms of legal evidence is passed over.

R 240 · BA 291–292

Abū Ḥāmid holds here that every independent jurist is correct. He has enumerated and rejected the objections to that claim, but has not included the argument we have given. He follows two routes in establishing that every independent jurist is correct. We shall show that his alleged consequences do not follow.

His first route is this. He says: if there were a determinate ruling in matters whose path is independent inquiry, the obligation would concern attaining it. In that case there would be decisive evidence leading to it; otherwise this would impose an obligation beyond one's capacity, which has already been shown impossible.

He then attempts to show that the indications used in independent inquiry are probable, yield the two contradictories equally, and acquire preponderance only according to each person's natural inclination in each ruling and each case.

53. Qurʾān, al-Anʿām 6:38 ↗. The quotation ends here; what follows is Ibn Rushd's explanation.

R 241 · BA 293

To say such a thing is a grave offence and a resort to arbitrary judgement in the Law through desires and inclinations; we seek God's protection from it. Legal evidence, as we said, is either decisive or preponderantly probable, with action on the latter required by a certainly established principle. In either case the ruling undoubtedly follows from the evidence itself, according to its signification, not according to each person's natural disposition.

Hence an indication undecided equally between contradictories is called indeterminate in this discipline and is not accepted as legal evidence at all. In general, denying that evidence itself yields what is sought —whether the evidence is rational or legal—is a thoroughly sophistical claim, to be avoided because of its great harm to the Law. Since evidence leading to the object sought exists, requiring one to attain it is not an obligation beyond one's capacity.

R 242 · BA 294

His other argument is drawn from obligation. Since the obligatory was defined as that whose omission incurs punishment, he argues: if the obligation concerning a thing were a determinate ruling, failure to attain it would incur sin. But consensus establishes that independent jurists are not charged with sin. Therefore, the absence of sin entails the absence of error.

R 243 · BA 295

We say that exemption from sin does not entail absence of error. Unintentional error is pardoned in the Law; it occurs through forgetfulness, inattention, and inadvertence. We have repeatedly said that legal evidence is either decisive or preponderant. The path to decisive evidence is plainly accessible, and inadvertence and mistake are rare in it; hence error there seems to entail sin. With probable evidence, however, mistake and inadvertence occur often, so error does not entail sin.

The definition of the obligatory as that whose omission incurs punishment means that punishment attaches to omission after its obligatory status has become known, where decisive evidence leads to that knowledge. If someone errs or is inadvertent in a matter liable to error and thus has no way to know its obligatory status, how could he incur sin? The Prophet, peace be upon him, has said, "Error and forgetfulness have been lifted from my community."

R 244 · BA 296

If it is said that this entails freedom from sin even when a jurist unintentionally misses something established by decisive evidence, we reply: this requires examination. The difference is clear. Decisive evidence is seldom hidden from someone who has attained the rank of independent inquiry. Its being hidden is conceivable only through desire, partiality, something opposing it, or other psychological impediments. This has degrees corresponding to the degrees of evidence. Hence some cases incur a judgement of unbelief and others a charge of sin; the Law determines these differences.

R 245 · BA 297

Our discussion has shown that not every independent jurist is correct, in what respect he is free from sin when he errs, and that he is charged with attaining something that is itself attainable. When he errs, he is forgiven out of mercy and pardon.

R 246 · BA 298

It remains to consider the jurist's position when evidence conflicts for him on a question, and what course he should take. Abū Ḥāmid reports three views: suspending judgement, adopting the more cautious course, and the Judge's view that the jurist may choose. This last view is weak, because granting a choice is permission, whereas contradictory evidence concerning the command about a single matter is more apt to produce doubt and perplexity than to be thought to establish such permission.

Suspending judgement likewise makes no sense, since it leaves rulings inoperative. It is also impossible where a person must do one of two opposite things. Consider the reports about ritual bathing because of the emission of fluid, and bathing because of the meeting of the circumcised parts. When such reports conflict, suspension is impossible: one must adopt one or the other.

In such a case, adopting the more cautious course appears plausible. Although it may seem preferable because it avoids blame, one must equally fear blame for adding to the Law something that does not belong to it.

R 247 · BA 299

The Ẓāhirīs have a fourth view: when the evidence is equally balanced, the independent jurist returns to original freedom from obligation. An obligation imposed through contradictory evidence exceeds one's capacity and is like an obligation lacking evidence. Just as original freedom from obligation is presumed to continue where there is no evidence—or where evidence exists but cannot be reached—it likewise continues where available proofs appear to conflict. And just as a ruling supported by evidence does not bind someone whom that evidence has not reached, so apparently opposed proofs cease to bind the person for whom they conflict.

These two conditions occur only relative to particular people or people of a particular period: those whom the legal evidence has not reached, or who have not distinguished the abrogating from the abrogated, or other matters producing conflict. For contradictory evidence cannot occur within the Law itself.

R 248 · BA 300

Having completed the discussion of independent inquiry and its subject matter, let us discuss following authority and the person who does so.

Chapter Two. On following authority

R 249 · BA 301

Following authority (تقليد) is accepting someone's statement whose truth is judged preponderantly probable because of confidence in that person. It differs from following the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace: following him is accepting a statement of which one attains certainty, because the miracle indicates his truthfulness, God bless him and grant him peace.

R 250 · BA 302

Those permitted to follow authority are ordinary people. The proof is that people must fall under one of three arrangements. Either all are independent jurists; this is impossible both in practice and as an obligation, since, even if everyone could attain that rank, it would bring the means of livelihood to a halt.

Or all lack the qualifications for independent inquiry. This too is impossible, because it would lead to the neglect of most rulings: independent jurists are those who discharge the obligation of knowing most prescribed duties and practices and teaching them to people.

Or both classes exist: one group preserves the prescribed duties and practices for the public, lays them upon people, requires their observance, and derives what may be derived from them at each time and in each case. Another group, ordinary people, follows the authority of the first because of confidence in them and a preponderant judgement of their truthfulness.

Here it is as though preponderant judgement based on confidence has been made a sign that the rulings bind them, just as the independent jurist's preponderant judgement is a sign that a ruling binds him. This is rightly called a collective obligation (فرض كفاية), since its performance by some suffices on behalf of others.

R 251 · BA 303–304

It is therefore clear that people are of two classes. One is obliged to follow authority: ordinary people who have not attained the rank of independent inquiry defined earlier. The second comprises independent jurists who fully possess its qualifications.

Whether those in the second class may follow one another's authority requires examination. Ordinary people's following authority is required by necessity and established by consensus. Nevertheless, one should say that an independent jurist may follow another who is more knowledgeable than he, when his confidence in the other's judgement outweighs the probable judgement he himself reaches through independent inquiry into the matter.

Section

R 252 · BA 305

There is a group resembling ordinary people in one respect and independent jurists in another: those mostly called jurists in our time. We should examine to which class they more properly belong. Their condition plainly shows that their rank is that of ordinary people and that they are followers of authority.

They differ from ordinary people by memorising independent jurists' opinions and reporting them to others, without themselves possessing the qualifications for independent inquiry. Their rank is thus like that of transmitters from independent jurists. Had they stopped there, matters would have been more fitting. Instead, they go beyond it, analogising cases for which no ruling has been transmitted from their authorities to cases for which one has. They make a source of what is not a source, turning independent jurists' statements into sources for their own inquiry. That is sufficient error and innovation!

R 253 · BA 306

May they, however, remain in the first condition: transmitting from an independent jurist whom they judge probably correct, with successors carefully transmitting from predecessors, so that, for example, no one in our time discharges the obligation of independent inquiry, apart from those of the past? Would it suffice that someone in the earliest period discharged it, even one man or more, as we find among these groups—the Mālikīs, Shāfiʿīs, and Ḥanafīs?

By my life, consensus proves that this is impermissible: for every collective obligation there must be someone in every period who performs it; only then does it cease to bind the others. Moreover, the cases that arise are without limit. It is impossible to transmit from earlier independent jurists a separate pronouncement for every case.

R 254 · BA 307

This leaves only three possibilities: to make earlier independent jurists' legal opinions into sources from which rulings are derived; to leave many rulings inoperative; or, since both alternatives are impermissible, to accept the third—that no period should be without an independent jurist.

You know that the period just past was in this condition: it had no practising independent jurist. Although it cannot be denied that someone in it had attained the rank of independent inquiry, he nevertheless acted only as a follower of authority.

R 255 · BA 308

This discussion has clarified who follows authority, what following authority is, and where it is and is not valid.

Chapter Three. On weighing transmission routes

R 256 · BA 309

There remains the third chapter, concerning the comparative weight of transmission routes and of what expressions signify through their understood meanings. This concerns evidence of the same kind, since the relative weight of different kinds has already been established. The relevant rules attach to particular items of evidence and particular chains of transmission, and are virtually without limit.

Practitioners of this discipline have attempted to enumerate them. We have no need to do so, since a person can determine for himself which produce a preponderant judgement and which do not. Anyone with leisure who wishes to record them here may do so. However, the contextual indications establishing the superiority of transmission routes should be placed in the discussion of reports, and those establishing the superiority of an understood meaning in Part Three of this book.

R 257 · BA 310

That adopting and acting upon the stronger of two probable judgements constitutes legal evidence is shown by the Companions' consensus on this, and by what a person finds in himself: he turns to the stronger of two probable judgements when they conflict.

R 258 · BA 311

Here our purpose in this abridgement is complete. It resembles an abridgement in removing prolixity, and an original work in its additions and completions. This was during the middle ten days of Dhū al-Ḥijja in the year five hundred and fifty-two.

Later copyist’s colophon and ownership notice

Copyist’s colophon and ownership note

Later copyist and owner · separate from Ibn Rushd’s authorial conclusion

The copying of the abridgement was completed on the tenth of Rajab, the solitary sacred month, in the year six hundred and six, by the hand of Muḥammad ibn ʿAlī ibn ʿAfīf. Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds, and blessings upon Muḥammad, the Seal of the Prophets.

Owned by the servant of his Lord, Aḥmad ibn Aḥmad al-Muṭarrifī. May God treat all with His hidden kindness.

Applications in the Bidāyat al-mujtahid

Illustrative legal comparisons. These are editorial commentary, separate from the authorial al-Ḍarūrī.

18 · Marriage: one form of act, different legal rulings

Marriage · ch. 1, preliminaries, issue 1: the legal status of marriage

The majority recommend marriage; the Ẓāhirīs require it; later Mālikīs distinguish obligatory, recommended and permitted marriage according to the person's circumstances. Ibn Rushd identifies both the interpretation of imperative expressions and an appeal to welfare as causes of the disagreement. This illustrates the distinction between an act's general description and the ruling applicable to a situated agent. It does not prove that an imperative by itself encodes all those contextual differences. The welfare argument reported here should also be compared with the stricter controls of Darūrī §§146 and 217.

§18 · §197 · §200 · §217

23 · Wiping the head: a minimum performance and a contested particle

Purification from ritual impurity · Book of Wuḍūʾ, ch. 2, issue 6: the extent of wiping the head

Mālik requires the whole head, al-Shāfiʿī allows part, and Abū Ḥanīfa specifies a quarter. Ibn Rushd relates the disagreement to the bāʾ in Q 5:6[54]—whether emphatic or partitive—and to reports describing the Prophet's wiping. Even on the emphatic reading, the amount satisfying the name of the act remains disputed. This is a representative application of the Darūrī's minimum-sufficiency problem, but one in which grammar and transmitted practice jointly determine the legally adequate minimum.

§23 · §165 · §205

28 · Proposing over another proposal: prohibition and contractual effect

Marriage · ch. 1, preliminaries, issue 3: proposing over another man's proposal

Jurists distinguish the prohibition of intervening in an existing proposal from the validity of the ensuing marriage. Ibn Rushd records invalidation by Dāwūd, validity according to al-Shāfiʿī and Abū Ḥanīfa, and differing Mālikī outcomes. The question is whether the forbidden preliminary act vitiates the contract or is an independently culpable circumstance. Read this alongside the Darūrī's distinctions of aspect and the later question whether prohibition entails invalidity; the note identifies a legal parallel, not an explicit cross-citation between the books.

§28 · §56 · §206

38 · Zakāt on a child's property: worship or a claim upon wealth?

Zakāt · first division: those liable; property belonging to minors

Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī and others impose zakāt on a minor's property; other views exempt it or distinguish agricultural produce. Ibn Rushd identifies the underlying question: is zakāt principally worship requiring adult responsibility, or a financial right of the poor in wealth? The latter need not depend on the owner's puberty. This demonstrates why exemption from direct moral obligation does not automatically remove every legal consequence affecting a child's property.

§38 · §42 · §55

43 · Intention in ablution: devotional act and intelligible cleansing

Purification from ritual impurity · Book of Wuḍūʾ, ch. 2, issue 1: intention as a condition of validity

Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī and others require intention; Abū Ḥanīfa and al-Thawrī do not. Ibn Rushd locates ablution between pure devotion and an act whose cleansing purpose is intelligible. The relevant inquiry is which resemblance governs its legal classification. Read beside Darūrī §43, this shows that intending obedience and performing an objectively effective act are distinguishable questions, and that a condition of worship cannot simply be transferred to every act associated with worship.

§43 · §56 · §218

54. Qurʾān 5:6.

47 · Coerced divorce: voluntary utterance is not sufficient freedom

Divorce · second division, ch. 2: the person whose divorce is legally effective; coerced divorce

Abū Ḥanīfa treats the coerced utterance as effective, whereas Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī and others do not. Ibn Rushd locates the dispute in the sense of choice: the speaker chooses the words, but the threat may still make him "coerced" in the Law's usage. He invokes Q 16:106[55] against identifying every chosen utterance with unqualified freedom. This sharpens Darūrī §47: physical possibility, intention, legal coercion and the effect of an act must be distinguished.

§47 · §43 · §45

55 · Financial maturity: an operative condition or its official recognition?

Interdiction · ch. 2: release of minors from interdiction; those under an executor

Some Mālikī positions continue to invalidate transactions until an executor or judge formally releases the ward. Ibn al-Qāsim gives decisive weight to actual maturity or improvidence. Ibn Rushd criticizes treating the continued formal status as controlling when maturity is established: the operative consideration is maturity, not the judge's declaration. This provides an institutional illustration of the difference between a condition's existence and a procedure which establishes or announces it, without reducing all judicial acts to mere factual reports.

§55 · §42 · §56

56 · A remoter guardian: invalidity, permission, or ratification

Marriage · ch. 2; conditions of contract; guardians, third topic, issue 1: a remoter guardian contracts while the nearer is present

For the cases under discussion, Mālik's transmitted positions include invalidity, validity and dependence on the nearer guardian's approval. Ibn Rushd explains the alternatives through three questions: is priority a rule of revelation at all; if so, is it the nearer guardian's right; or is it a right of God? These yield, respectively, validity, a ratifiable contract, or invalidity. The ruling is not produced simply by attaching the word "condition" to priority. The discussion excludes certain father–virgin-daughter and executor cases from that threefold variation.

§56 · §36 · §54

58 · A traveller who fasts: an implied condition in the verse

Fasting · ch. on those permitted to break the fast; the traveller's performance of the fast

A minority requires the travelling person to make up the days even if he fasts; the majority accepts his fast. Ibn Rushd connects the disagreement to whether Q 2:184[56] implicitly says "and breaks the fast" before requiring other days, alongside reports allowing travelling Companions to fast or refrain. This illustrates both the classification of a concession and the interpretation of an omitted condition. It must not be read as though the mere grammatical form settled the whole dispute.

§58 · §155 · §194

64 · The basmala: Qurʾānic wording and membership in a sūra

Prayer · third division, verbal constituents, issue 4: reciting the basmala

The practical disagreement concerns reciting the basmala[57] and whether aloud or silently. Ibn Rushd separates uncertainty about its status as a verse of al-Fātiḥa from denying that the wording is Qurʾānic at all. He also analyses conflicting reports of the Companions' practice. This parallels Darūrī §64, while warning against an over-simple appeal to mass transmission: the identity of transmitted words and their structural membership in a particular sūra are distinct propositions.

§64 · §75 · §112

55. Qurʾān 16:106.
56. Qurʾān 2:184–185. The phrase "and breaks the fast" is an interpretive supply.
57. Qurʾān 27:30. This does not settle the basmala's membership in al-Fātiḥa.

146 · An absent father: welfare within a structured legal situation

Marriage · ch. 2; guardians, third topic, issue 3: the father's absence

The Mālikī distinctions turn on distance, knowledge of the father's whereabouts, maintenance, protection and the woman's need to marry. Ibn Rushd then suggests that urgent risk might justify the ruler's intervention even when the father is relatively near. This is a concrete use of welfare-oriented reasoning, not an unrestricted power to legislate. Its relation to the Darūrī's demand for an acknowledged warrant remains a question of interpretation: the later case develops an existing institution's purpose, but does not expressly cite that earlier restriction.

§146 · §217

158 · Touching women: equivocation, generality and counterevidence

Purification from ritual impurity · Book of Wuḍūʾ, ch. 4, issue on touching women

Ibn Rushd explains that touching in Arabic[58] can mean contact by the hand or signify intercourse. Among those taking bodily contact, some require pleasure and others do not; reports about contact between the Prophet and ʿĀʾisha enter the assessment. The first disagreement concerns competing meanings, the second the scope of a selected meaning. This clarifies why the Darūrī distinguishes equivocation from generality: collecting two possible meanings is not the same operation as including all instances under one universal.

§158 · §167 · §177

160 · Minimum dower: clarification cannot be postponed beyond need

Marriage · ch. 2; conditions of contract; dower, first topic, issue 2: its amount

In Sahl's marriage report, the request for even an iron ring is taken against a fixed minimum. Ibn Rushd expressly argues that a required threshold would have needed explanation at that moment. He also disputes the premises that dower is purely worship and that worship must always be quantitatively fixed. This is a direct application of the rule against delaying clarification beyond need, rather than a merely suggestive similarity supplied by the present editor.

§160 · §23 · §166

167 · The sales-session option: what counts as "separation"?

Sales · part 3, conditions of validity, ch. 1: the contract and the parties' option before separation

Mālik and Abū Ḥanīfa make the completed exchange binding without physical separation; al-Shāfiʿī and others retain the session option. Ibn Rushd examines whether the report concerns bodily separation or completion of bargaining. He weighs the strong Ibn ʿUmar report against Medinan practice, another report's weakness, analogies to other contracts, and the general command to fulfil contracts[59]. The case joins semantic interpretation to evidential preference: a plausible lexical reinterpretation is not enough unless proportionate evidence supports it.

§167 · §138 · §166 · §256

171 · Guardianship: a disputed condition cannot be established by ambiguity alone

Marriage · ch. 2, conditions of validity; guardians, first topic: whether guardianship is a condition

In examining marriage guardianship, Ibn Rushd tests the scope of Qurʾānic expressions and the guardian-permission reports rather than treating every apparent address to guardians as a decisive condition of validity. He also considers whether such a widespread requirement could have remained insufficiently explained. The case exemplifies the evidential burden for a restrictive interpretation. It is especially pertinent to Darūrī §171, which rejects an excessively remote narrowing of the permission report; the Bidāya's fuller argument must not be reduced to that single objection.

§171 · §160 · §166

58. Qurʾān 4:43 and 5:6.
59. Qurʾān 5:1.

201 · Pilgrimage now or later: a control against a simplistic application

Pilgrimage · first kind of inquiry: when the pilgrimage obligation falls due

Ibn Rushd explicitly denies that the dispute is merely whether an unrestricted command demands immediacy. The competing arguments compare the first available pilgrimage season with the beginning or end of prayer-time, consider the interval when pilgrimage cannot be performed, and assess the risk of death before another year. This is a useful counterexample to a mechanical concordance: Darūrī §201 supplies distinctions, but the Bidāya warns that the applied dispute has additional temporal structure.

§201 · §21 · §25

204 · Completing ʿumra does not by itself prove an initial duty to begin it

Pilgrimage · first kind of inquiry: the legal status of ʿumra

One argument for obligation invokes Q 2:196[60]'s command to complete pilgrimage and ʿumra. The opposing reading takes completion to govern an observance once begun, whether its initiation was obligatory or voluntary. Ibn Rushd also records conflicting reports. The lesson is the distinct scope of commands: an obligation to complete an undertaking need not establish an obligation to undertake it. Compare the Darūrī's insistence that a further performance needs its own warrant, rather than extending a command beyond its demonstrated conditions.

§204 · §49 · §205

206 · Menstrual divorce: a forbidden act may still have legal effect

Divorce · first division, ch. 2: Sunnī and irregular divorce; divorce during menstruation

The majority count a divorce pronounced during menstruation, while another position does not. Ibn Rushd distinguishes conditions of validity from conditions of proper or complete performance and examines the command that Ibn ʿUmar take his wife back. This provides an especially clear application of the Darūrī's question about prohibition and invalidity. Whether an act is forbidden and whether it produces a legal consequence are different inquiries; their relation must be demonstrated from the relevant address and reports.

§206 · §28 · §56

211 · Foetal compensation: the identity of the right-holder matters

Offences and injuries · second part, compensation; accidental loss of a foetus, question "to whom is it due?"

Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī and Abū Ḥanīfa treat the compensation as inheritable by the foetus's heirs. Rabīʿa and al-Layth assign it to the mother, comparing the foetus with one of her bodily parts. The dispute illustrates that identifying the legal subject precedes assigning a consequence. It is related to Darūrī §211's caution about the original and derivative terms of an analogy, not a textual claim that the two passages explicitly cross-reference each other.

§211 · §218 · §238

214 · Jewellery: resemblance to usable possessions or to monetary wealth?

Zakāt · second division: assets subject to zakāt; gold and silver jewellery

The Ḥijāzī jurists exempt jewellery intended for adornment; Abū Ḥanīfa includes it. Ibn Rushd attributes the disagreement chiefly to its double resemblance: usable possessions on one side, gold and silver serving exchange on the other. Conflicting reports matter, but he regards them as weak, especially the exemption report. This is a particularly accessible example of competing analogical descriptions; disagreement about the case's legally relevant likeness need not amount to disagreement about the underlying commodity itself.

§214 · §218 · §238

60. Qurʾān 2:196.

217 · Deathbed divorce: blocking an evasion without erasing doctrinal difficulty

Divorce · second division, ch. 2: irrevocable divorce during fatal illness

Some jurists preserve the divorced woman's inheritance because the husband may be evading her entitlement; others apply divorce's ordinary consequences. Ibn Rushd expressly identifies blocking the means (sadd al-dharāʾiʿ) as the issue, but also questions a hybrid status retaining only selected effects of marriage. He rejects a claim of Companion consensus because Ibn al-Zubayr's disagreement is known. Thus purposive prevention and proof of consensus require distinct warrants; the case is not evidence that every welfare argument is self-validating. The Darūrī itself cites this case in §217 while rejecting excessively remote welfare arguments; the difference of framing is therefore substantive.

§217 · §135 · §137

218 · Ribā in foodstuffs: competing identifications of the operative feature

Sales · part 2, causes of invalidity; ribā in the named foodstuffs and their analogues

Mālikī analysis emphasizes staple, storable food; al-Shāfiʿī emphasizes edibility; Ḥanafī reasoning emphasizes weight or measure. Ibn Rushd treats the dispute as identifying the meaning behind the named commodities, while also evaluating the rival rationales. This corresponds closely to the Darūrī's account of resemblance and uncertain grounds. Yet the Bidāya's comparative assessment is more developed than a blanket dismissal: no uniform verdict on all "analogy" should be imported from either book into the other.

§218 · §212 · §214 · §238

223 · Dower and the theft threshold: verbal resemblance is not one legal meaning

Marriage · ch. 2; dower, first topic, issue 2: critique of the minimum-dower analogy

The proposed analogy sets the minimum dower by the monetary threshold for theft. Ibn Rushd objects that the shared description of bodily "authorization" masks different meanings: punishment and injury differ from lawful marital enjoyment and affection. The relevant similarity must be one in meaning, not merely words, and must ground the original ruling. He distinguishes using this weak analogy to select an amount from establishing that a minimum exists at all.

§223 · §158 · §218

227 · Triple divorce after mutual imprecation: the limits of tacit approval

Divorce · first division, ch. 2: whether three divorces may be pronounced together; the report of ʿUwaymir

One argument relies on the Prophet's not objecting when ʿUwaymir pronounced three divorces after mutual imprecation (liʿān). The counterargument is that liʿān had already severed the marriage: the utterance then effected no further divorce. Silence cannot establish permissibility for an act whose legally relevant object was absent. This is a precise application of Darūrī §227's contextual restriction: approval must concern the very act and circumstances for which authority is being claimed.

§227 · §150 · §229

237 · A mistaken qibla: required success or adequately conducted inquiry?

Prayer · second division, conditions; facing the qibla, second issue

Al-Shāfiʿī requires repetition when an error in direction becomes known; Mālik and Abū Ḥanīfa do not impose the same unconditional repetition after due inquiry. Ibn Rushd identifies disagreement about whether correct orientation or the act of inquiry is required, and weighs a report against analogy with prayer before its time. The case illuminates Darūrī §§237–245 without proving that every mujtahid's conclusion is true: excusing an error and making its conclusion correct remain different claims.

§237 · §204 · §243

243 · A physician’s mistake: compensation need not imply moral wrongdoing

Offences and injuries · second part, compensation; accidental injury caused in medical treatment

Ibn Rushd reports compensation for a treatment error, while also recording a Mālikī exemption for a qualified practitioner and agreement on liability for an unqualified intruder. The analogy is with accidental injury; there is further disagreement about which fund bears payment. This is an illustrative legal parallel to the Darūrī’s distinction between error and sin. It does not assimilate medical judgement to every form of juristic inquiry, nor does compensation alone establish culpability.

§243 · §38 · §244

246 · Cupping while fasting: three ways of treating conflicting reports

Fasting · ch. on acts from which the fasting person abstains; cupping

A report invalidating the fast of cupper and cupped is set beside the report that the Prophet was cupped while fasting. Ibn Rushd describes disagreement over prohibition, dislike and permissibility, and examines preference, reconciliation and relinquishing the conflicting proofs. This makes concrete the Darūrī’s alternatives when evidence appears equipollent. Returning to an original rule is itself a reasoned response to evidential failure; it is not the same as choosing whichever report one happens to prefer.

§246 · §214 · §247

256 · Deferred animal barter: conflict can concern scope as well as authenticity

Sales · part 2, ribā; exchanging animals with deferred delivery

Reports allowing an animal to be exchanged for more animals with later delivery stand against a prohibition of deferred animal-for-animal exchange. Ibn Rushd records different evaluations and reconciliations, including Mālikī attention to whether the animals have distinct uses. The disagreement is not only over which chain is stronger: a proposed distinction of legal purposes may reconcile reports which otherwise conflict. This illustrates why Darūrī §§256–257 insist on a stronger judgement rather than an exhaustive mechanical list of preference rules.

§256 · §213 · §257

Subject index

Begin with a subject below or use the alphabetical entries. The groupings are editorial browsing aids; a concept may belong to several subjects. Each subentry links to its exact numbered passage.

Purpose, method and knowledge
The aims of uṣūl, disciplined inquiry, and the difference between certainty and probable judgement.
Knowledge · Certainty · Probability (ẓann)

Rulings, actions and responsibility
Kinds of ruling, the conditions of responsibility, and the validity or consequences of actions.
Obligation · Legal responsibility (taklīf) · Validity

Sources and legal authority
Revelation, consensus and original nonliability, with questions of authority, continuity and abrogation.
Qurʾān · Consensus (ijmāʿ) · Original nonliability (barāʾa)

Reports, transmission and reliability
How reports are transmitted, evaluated and used as evidence.
Solitary reports · Probity (ʿadāla) · Written transmission

Language, grammar and interpretation
Wording, context, grammar, commands and the interpretation of legal expressions.
Interpretation (taʾwīl) · Generality · Commands (amr)

Inference, analogy and legal grounds
The grounds and methods used to extend, establish or distinguish rulings.
Analogy · Effective ground (ʿilla) · Testing and division

Juristic expertise, disagreement and error
Independent inquiry, following authority, conflicting evidence and the responsibility of the jurist.
Ijtihād · Taqlīd · Correctness and error

Legal examples and applications
Concrete cases from worship, family life, transactions and injuries, including editorial Bidāya applications.
Purification · Marriage · Bidāya applications

Alphabetical index

Abrogation (naskh)
what remains after removal of obligation · §26
prohibition of wine · §40
Qurʾān and Sunna · §114
definitions · §115
before performance · §115
fact established by transmission · §116
parts and conditions · §117
addition to a text · §118
replacement not required · §119
greater and lesser burdens · §120
recitation and ruling · §121
cessation of revelation · §122
mass and solitary reports · §123
Qurʾān by Sunna · §124
analogy excluded · §126
mistaken classifications · §127
constitutive conditions · §128
express declaration · §129
continuity of texts · §142
requisite knowledge · §232
unknown chronology and apparent conflict · §247

Absence of evidence
not simply a positive proof · §141

Abū Ḥanīfa
restrictions on analogy · §219

Acquisition (kasb)
choice and compliance · §43
voluntary contraries · §44
critique of al-Ashʿarī · §45

Acts
forms and conditions · §206

Additional wording (ziyāda)
reliable narrator · §108

A fortiori indication
priority of the unspoken case · §215

Al-Zarkashī
editorial supplements · §110

Ambiguity
multiple meanings and apparent contradiction · §65

Analogy
passage from observed to unobserved · §2
disputed authority · §6
suitability and plausible grounds · §11
analogy with testimony · §82
competing original cases · §95
comparison with report authority · §112
transition from linguistic indications · §209
definition · §210
original and derivative cases · §210
semantic extension rather than syllogism · §212 · §223
degrees of evidential force · §214
certain extension · §215
equality of the derivative case · §216
resemblance (shabah) · §218
alleged Companion consensus · §225
place among legal indications · §226

Apostasy
make-up performance · §51

Apparent meaning (ẓāhir)
classification · §151
understood meaning · §155
authority · §166
understood rather than verbal · §224

Ashʿarī, al-
Ibn Rushd's criticism · §45

ʿĀshūrāʾ
fast and Ramaḍān · §120

Assent (taṣdīq)
miracles and recurrent transmission · §15
necessity and motivation · §44
degrees produced by reports · §74
implicit premises · §76
certainty · §78
strength of transmission · §125
degrees of evidence · §159

Assertions
compound expressions · §156
conclusion · §196

Atom
indivisible part · §2

Attestation (taʿdīl)
organization · §94
number · §95
reasons · §96
express and implicit · §97

Authenticity
knowledge of a route · §104

Authority
rulers and parents · §37

Authorization (ijāza)
transmission · §103
relation to munāwala · §104

Authorship and method
abridgment of al-Mustaṣfā · §1 · §7
historical need for uṣūl · §3
fourfold organization · §5
proper subject of uṣūl · §6 · §148
comparative reconstruction of schools · §6
purpose, rank, and divisions · §8
limits of theological discussion · §20
organization of linguistic inquiry · §30
avoiding misplaced digressions · §41
transition to sources · §61
limits of theological inquiry · §116
brevity and sufficiency · §140
completion of sources · §147

Bāqillānī, al- (the Qāḍī)
definition of make-up performance · §59

Basmala
Qurʾānic status and recitation in prayer · §64

Benefit (maṣlaḥa)
attestation of kind · §146
proximity of the relevant genus · §213
recognised goods and proximate genus · §217
rejected remote or unrestricted grounds · §217
recognised proximate genus · §224

Bequests
no bequest for an heir · §121 · §124

Bidāya applications

Marriage: one form of act, different legal rulings · §18

Wiping the head: a minimum performance and a contested particle · §23

Proposing over another proposal: prohibition and contractual effect · §28

Zakāt on a child's property: worship or a claim upon wealth? · §38

Intention in ablution: devotional act and intelligible cleansing · §43

Coerced divorce: voluntary utterance is not sufficient freedom · §47

Financial maturity: an operative condition or its official recognition? · §55

A remoter guardian: invalidity, permission, or ratification · §56

A traveller who fasts: an implied condition in the verse · §58

The basmala: Qurʾānic wording and membership in a sūra · §64

An absent father: welfare within a structured legal situation · §146

Touching women: equivocation, generality and counterevidence · §158

Minimum dower: clarification cannot be postponed beyond need · §160

The sales-session option: what counts as "separation"? · §167

Guardianship: a disputed condition cannot be established by ambiguity alone · §171

Pilgrimage now or later: a control against a simplistic application · §201

Completing ʿumra does not by itself prove an initial duty to begin it · §204

Menstrual divorce: a forbidden act may still have legal effect · §206

Foetal compensation: the identity of the right-holder matters · §211

Jewellery: resemblance to usable possessions or to monetary wealth? · §214

Deathbed divorce: blocking an evasion without erasing doctrinal difficulty · §217

Ribā in foodstuffs: competing identifications of the operative feature · §218

Dower and the theft threshold: verbal resemblance is not one legal meaning · §223

Triple divorce after mutual imprecation: the limits of tacit approval · §227

A mistaken qibla: required success or adequately conducted inquiry? · §237

A physician's mistake: compensation need not imply moral wrongdoing · §243

Cupping while fasting: three ways of treating conflicting reports · §246

Deferred animal barter: conflict can concern scope as well as authenticity · §256

Blocking the means

deathbed divorce; comparison with remote welfare reasoning · §217

Book structure

relocation of discussions · §207

avoiding misplaced discussions · §256

abridgement and original completion · §258

Booty

thread and needle · §191

threads and greater amounts · §215

Branches of law (furūʿ)

allocation of individual cases · §48

Bukhārī, al-

accurate copies · §105

reliance on authority · §233

Capacity

condition rather than obligatory act · §23

physical conditions of an act · §33

understanding the address · §38

reason and puberty · §42

impossibility of the impossible · §45

acquired conditions · §50

impossible commands · §52

Bidāya: Financial maturity: an operative condition or its official recognition? · §55

Cases

inexhaustibility · §253

Cats

circulation among people · §212

Causality

human proximate and remote agency · §45

legal signs versus perceptible causes · §55

vegetation called dew · §164

Causes and signs

manifestation of rulings · §54

appointed legal signs · §55

prohibiting cause remains · §60

Caution

danger of adding to the Law · §246

Certainty

priority over apparent wording · §38

psychological production · §76

graded acquisition · §77

degrees · §125

agreement and transmission · §130

understood meaning · §214

Change of attributes

change of ruling · §142

Children
guardian's financial responsibility · §38
instruction in prayer · §38
transmission · §84
testimony about injuries · §84

Choice (takhyīr)
act and time · §18
exhausted alternatives · §21
equipollent harms · §53

Chronology
evidence of solitary reports · §126
determining abrogation · §129
general and specific evidence · §181
authorial completion in 552 AH · §258
copying in 606 AH · §colophon

Claimant and defendant
burden of proof · §141

Clarification (bayān)
general definition · §159
time of need · §160
questions and delay · §161
misleading apparent meanings · §162
delayed specification · §163

Clientage (walāʾ)
emancipator · §195

Coercion (ikrāh)
compliance and disobedience · §47

Collective obligation
dissemination · §113
preservation of sources · §145
division of intellectual labour · §250
renewed in every generation · §253

Commands (amr)
relation to prohibition of the contrary · §32
eternal command and future subjects · §41
prior to fulfilment of a condition · §49
a Companion's interpretation · §69
obligation to warn · §82
distinction from requests · §152
transition · §196
superior and subordinate · §197
obligation and recommendation · §198
immediacy and delay · §198
repetition · §198
method of inquiry · §199
imperative form · §200
obligation presumed cautiously · §200
one performance · §201
contextual timing · §201
related questions · §202
after prohibition · §203
sufficiency and repetition · §205
symmetry with prohibitions · §206
place within legal hermeneutics · §209

Community
protection from error · §131
two or three surviving jurists · §132
temporal reference · §134
earlier generations · §135

Companions
implicit legal competence · §3 · §4
disputed authority of opinions · §62
levels of reporting language · §68 · §72
requests for corroboration · §83
rejection of reports · §88
general probity · §98
civil wars · §99
assertions of abrogation · §127
direct observation · §136
opinions not independently binding · §144
governing the general by the specific · §182
reports about analogy · §225
consensus on evidential preference · §257

Compensation
Bidāya: Foetal compensation: the identity of the right-holder matters · §211
Bidāya: A physician's mistake: compensation need not imply moral wrongdoing · §243

Concession (rukhṣa)
interpretation of fasting verses · §58
definition · §60

Concomitance
positive and negative · §220
positive (ṭard) · §222
negative (ʿaks) · §222

Conditions (shurūṭ)
acquired legal conditions · §49
legal and existential · §50
completion of worship · §117

Conflicting evidence
criticism and attestation · §96
assertion and uncertainty · §107
three proposed responses · §246
original freedom from obligation · §247

Conjunction wāw
shared and distinct meanings · §187

Consensus (ijmāʿ)
deferred prayer and death · §25
disputed historical claims · §111
evidence of an earlier abrogator · §122
chronological evidence · §129
definition · §130
strengthening solitary reports · §130
meeting contemporaries · §130
knowledge of earlier agreement · §130
Qurʾānic and prophetic warrant · §131
revealed rather than numerical warrant · §132
qualified jurists and laypeople · §133
contemporaneous scope · §134
agreement after disagreement · §135
analogy as a basis · §136
dissent of one jurist · §137
tacit agreement · §137
extinction of the generation · §139
later dissent · §139
silence and nonunanimity · §225
avoiding contradiction of an established consensus · §234

Contextual indications (qarāʾin)
shifting prohibition to disapproval · §29
length of companionship · §68
number of informants as one factor · §75
converging reports · §77
solitary reports · §79
children's testimony · §84
individual assessment · §90
silence and coercion · §102
collective omission · §108
access to the Prophet · §123
silent approval · §137
weight of early opinions · §144
nonverbal kinds · §150
selecting senses · §153
degrees of clarity · §155
particularizing a general statement · §174
interpersonal relations · §197
degrees of prohibitive force · §208
recognised legal genus · §213

Contracts
defective and void · §56

Contradiction
false dichotomies · §113
relative to the inquirer, not the Law · §247

Contrariety
intermediates and negation · §26 · §34
same thing, time, and respect · §28
distinct respects of one act · §31
obligation and prohibition · §32
legal and perceptible · §33
exhaustive opposites · §52

Contrary implication
weaker than generality · §189
definition · §194
descriptive qualification · §195
condition · §195
restrictive particles · §195
endpoint · §195

Conversation
intelligibility · §186

Conversion
remission of previous obligations · §51

Correctness and error
question of universal correctness · §237
objections to universal correctness · §238
author's rejection of universal correctness · §239
rejection of subjectivism · §241
error distinguished from sin · §242
nonculpable error · §243
decisive evidence · §244
determinate but fallibly known truth · §245

Cow of the Israelites
successive questions · §163

Craft (ṣināʿa)
disciplined method · §1
compass and straightedge analogy · §2

Crescent sighting
Bedouin testimony · §89

Culpability
psychological impediments · §244

Dāwūd al-Ẓāhirī
reporting commands · §69
general and specific texts · §181

Definite article
generality · §170

Definitions
legal judgement · §10
objections that do not affect practice · §211

Derived rulings
produced rather than memorised · §235

Disagreement
verbal disputes · §22

Disapproval (karāha)
definition · §17
distinguished from unlawfulness · §208

Discourse
verbal and understood indications · §239

Discretionary punishment (taʿzīr)
reasonable risk · §25

Disposition
moral conduct · §86

Divine attributes
istiwāʾ and place · §168

Divine knowledge
contingent choice · §19

Divine unity
Q 112:1 · §157

Divorce
during menstruation · §28
remarriage after third divorce · §195
inheritance following deathbed divorce · §217
Coerced divorce: voluntary utterance is not sufficient freedom · §47
Menstrual divorce: a forbidden act may still have legal effect · §206
Deathbed divorce: blocking an evasion without erasing doctrinal difficulty · §217
Triple divorce after mutual imprecation: the limits of tacit approval · §227
Bidāya: Coerced divorce: voluntary utterance is not sufficient freedom · §47
Bidāya: Menstrual divorce: a forbidden act may still have legal effect · §206
Bidāya: Deathbed divorce: blocking an evasion without erasing doctrinal difficulty · §217
Bidāya: Triple divorce after mutual imprecation: the limits of tacit approval · §227

Dower
remitting half · §158
Bidāya: Minimum dower: clarification cannot be postponed beyond need · §160
Bidāya: Dower and the theft threshold: verbal resemblance is not one legal meaning · §223

Dual
distinct grammatical form · §180

Earlier revealed law
disputed authority · §62
authority · §145

Effective ground (ʿilla)
common feature · §210
expressly stated · §212
underdetermination · §218
methods of identification · §220
correlation is not sufficient warrant · §222

Ellipsis
implicit breaking of the fast · §58

Emancipation contract (kitāba)
interpreting a report · §171

Equivocation (ishtirāk)
equally available senses · §153
opposites · §158
ṣarīm as night or morning · §161
conventionalized transfer · §168
not inclusive generality · §177
obligation and recommendation · §201

Error
distinction from deliberate falsehood · §132

Evidence
wording and transmission distinguished · §182
objective signification · §241
degrees of clarity · §244

Exception (istithnāʾ)
attachment · §183
connected and disconnected · §184
multiple sentences · §184
theoretical objection · §185
semantic explanation · §186
scope across clauses · §187
numerical proportion · §188

Existence
goat-stag as a non-existent composite · §75

Expertise
comparative competence · §251

Expiations
consecutiveness in a variant reading · §64
scope of analogy · §219

Faith
assent without rational inquiry · §235

False accusation (qadhf)
repentance and testimony · §187

Fasting
restraint as an act · §48
feeding alternative · §120
intention during the night · §172
validity and completeness · §194
A traveller who fasts: an implied condition in the verse · §58
Cupping while fasting: three ways of treating conflicting reports · §246
Bidāya: A traveller who fasts: an implied condition in the verse · §58
Bidāya: Cupping while fasting: three ways of treating conflicting reports · §246

Fāṭima bint Qays
report · §88

Fear or awe
suppressing an opinion · §137

Figurative usage (majāz)
omission and addition · §154
magnification · §180

Forgetfulness
pardon · §243

Garlic
mosque attendance · §191

Gender
masculine plural · §178

Generality
small and large groups · §82
authority after specification · §135
continuity until specification · §142
linguistic reality · §169
plurals, genera, and particles · §170
specific intention · §174
disputed applications · §175
contrast with equivocation · §177
people and believers · §178
conclusion · §190
extending the specific · §225
clarification by action · §228

Genus
exception from another genus · §184

Ghazālī, Abū Ḥāmid al-
structure retained but method qualified · §7
logical introduction omitted · §9
placement of prohibition question · §30
parallel text as control · §39
quoted definition of the Book · §63
criticism of arguments · §81
extended disputation · §140
minimum plural · §179
command after prohibition · §203
withholding judgement · §229
correctness of every mujtahid · §240
argument from absence of sin · §242

Ghusl
intercourse and emission · §246

Gold and silver vessels
common ground · §212

Goodness and badness
intrinsic and relational attributes · §11
consensus about truthfulness · §12
insufficiency of opposing arguments · §13

Guardian
marriage bond in Q 2:237 · §158
permission to marry · §171
Bidāya: A remoter guardian: invalidity, permission, or ratification · §56
Bidāya: An absent father: welfare within a structured legal situation · §146
Bidāya: Guardianship: a disputed condition cannot be established by ambiguity alone · §171

Hadith collections
corrected reference copy · §233

Ḥanafīs
certainty and obligation · §17
prohibited acts and validity · §28
distinction between fāsid and bāṭil · §56

Harm
comparing coerced alternatives · §47
choosing the lesser injury · §53

Head-wiping
minimum extent · §23

Homicide
coercion by threat of death · §47
unavoidable injury · §53

Ḥudaybiyya
shaving and imitation · §229

Hunting
after consecration · §203

Identity
numerical and specific · §118

Ijtihād
qualifications of the jurist · §5
correctness and error · §11
degrees of coercion · §47
unresolved hard cases · §53
disagreement without unbelief · §64
contextual variation · §90
sinlessness and correctness · §99
case-sensitive report evaluation · §108
access to original wording · §110
place in the book · §230
definition · §231
partial and unrestricted competence · §236
determinate object of inquiry · §237
obligation proportionate to capacity · §245
relation to taqlīd · §248
required in every period · §253
possession versus exercise of competence · §254

Illness
postponing the fast · §57
dangerous fasting · §58

Impossible obligation
argument from indeterminate evidence · §240

Indeterminacy
suspension of interpretation · §214
equally plausible grounds · §218
clarification by action · §228
not independent legal evidence · §241

Indeterminate wording (mujmal)
classification · §151
understood meaning · §155
no independent ruling · §160
unspecified restriction · §174

Indication (dalāla)
rules of evidence · §2
cumulative evidence · §131
wording and context · §148
parts of compound expressions · §152
practical classification · §156

Indirect expression (kināya)
low ground and touching · §164
intercourse · §167

Induction (istiqrāʾ)
principles from the Companions' opinions · §4
establishing meanings · §70
Arabic usage · §161
incomplete generalization · §163
reception by Companions · §200

Infallibility
proof of protection · §144

Inference (istidlāl)
opening invocation · §1

Infinite regress
obligation of inquiry · §14
successive acts of willing · §44

Innovation
treating derivative opinions as principles · §252

Inquiry (naẓar)
revealed obligation · §1
obligation before acceptance of revelation · §13
regress of justifying inquiries · §14

Intelligible meaning (maʿqūl)
indication · §149

Intention
resolving to perform a deferred duty · §22
prostration before an idol · §31
obedience as the purpose of action · §43
coerced act and reward · §47

Interdiction
Financial maturity: an operative condition or its official recognition? · §55

Interpretation (taʾwīl)
rational impossibility as a control · §49
Qurʾān 2:106 · §119
classification · §151
strength of contrary evidence · §166
degrees of remoteness · §167
certainty · §168
evidential proportion · §170
strained specification · §171

Interpretive wrongdoing
testimony · §91 · §99
probable evidence · §92

Intoxication
responsibility and divorce · §38
incipient intoxication · §39
advance prohibition · §40

Irrigation
different levy rates · §173

Judgement (ḥukm)
place in uṣūl · §5
four questions · §10
divine address · §11
fivefold classification · §17
universal questions · §24
divisions concluded · §35
lawgiver, subject, and act · §36
reliance on testimony · §97
not attributes of essences · §223

Jurist
qua jurist · §116

Juristic preference (istiḥsān)
relation to analogy · §146

Justice
the balance · §167

Juwaynī, al-
al-Risāla al-Niẓāmiyya · §45

Karkhī, al-
alternative days of fasting · §58
forgotten reports · §107

Khārijites
transmission · §91

Knowledge
theoretical and practical ends · §2
instrumental or criterial science · §2
definition of knowledge · §9
necessary and acquired · §14
necessity versus universal agreement · §15
access to the occurrence of rulings · §55
future possibilities not objects of tawātur · §75
inference and immediacy · §76
condition of culpability · §243

Language
Bedouin speech and metre · §3
conventional and legal usage · §27
figurative legal usage · §57
literal and figurative speech · §65
arabicized loanwords · §65
native competence as evidence · §69
induction and transmission · §70
literal reporting formulae · §101
figurative reporting formulae · §103
form and understood meaning · §149
noun, verb, and particle · §152
simple and compound · §152
original assignment (waḍʿ) · §153
riddles and mockery · §161
prevalence of usage · §168
cross-linguistic signification · §169
established and extended usage · §180
occurrence and explanation · §185
economy of expression · §188
form and meaning · §192
ordinary communication · §213
prerequisite for inquiry · §234

Lawgiver (ḥākim)
God as source of obligation · §37
intelligibility of commands · §45

Legal convention
burden of proof · §177
relation to language · §199

Legal practice
danger of inoperative rulings · §254

Legal responsibility (taklīf)
burden and terminology · §27
constituent elements · §36
the act commanded · §43
supplementary questions · §46
potential fulfilment · §50

Legal terminology
acquired meanings · §153
explanation before performance · §163

Legislation
distinguished from interpretation · §217

Livelihood
universal expertise would obstruct it · §250

Logic
disciplinary separation · §9
non-convertibility of predicates · §12
non-entailment between contraries · §26

Lost reports
evidence from consensus · §136

Make-up performance (qaḍāʾ)
separate command · §51
literal and extended senses · §57
expected death does not end the time · §59
fasting intention · §172
renewed command · §204

Mālik
attribution and criticism · §217

Manuscript voices
copyist and owner distinguished from author · §colophon

Marriage
witnesses of probity · §189
prohibited degrees · §194
intelligibility of legal grounds · §219
Marriage: one form of act, different legal rulings · §18
Proposing over another proposal: prohibition and contractual effect · §28
A remoter guardian: invalidity, permission, or ratification · §56
An absent father: welfare within a structured legal situation · §146
Minimum dower: clarification cannot be postponed beyond need · §160
Guardianship: a disputed condition cannot be established by ambiguity alone · §171
Dower and the theft threshold: verbal resemblance is not one legal meaning · §223

Mass transmission (tawātur)
conditions · §78
meaning rather than wording · §131
universally known duties · §133

Memory
knowing where to consult evidence · §232

Menstruation
fasting and make-up liability · §57
endpoint of abstinence · §195

Mercy
pardon of juristic error · §245

Miracle
recognition of prophecy · §15

Muʿādh
exercise of judgement · §126

Mujtahid
knowledge of sources · §231
inferential instruments · §231
Qurʾānic competence · §232
hadith competence · §233
awareness of consensus · §234
disputed theological prerequisite · §235
qualifications proportionate to the question · §236
preserving and teaching legal practice · §250

Mursal reports
definition and authority · §111

Muslim
reliance on authority · §233

Musnad reports
connected transmission · §111

Muʿtazilites
moral rationalism · §11 · §12
pre-revelation acts · §16
welfare and the best · §19
nonexistent things · §211
rulings as attributes of essences · §238

Nabīdh
interpretive disagreement · §92

Narrator criticism (jarḥ)
organization · §94
reasons · §96

Necessity
wine for choking and carrion · §60
practical use of probable evidence · §166

Negation
general scope · §170
distinguished from privation · §211

Nonexistence
mental existence and comparison · §211

Oath expiation
alternative acts · §187

Obligation
what exceeds capacity · §15
definition and threat of punishment · §17
farḍ and wājib · §17
determinate and alternative acts · §18
extended times · §18 · §21 · §22
alternative duties · §19
expiation alternatives · §20
extended prayer times · §20
resemblance to recommendation · §21
indispensable means · §23 · §33
for itself and for another · §23
death before the end of the time · §25
punishment for omission · §242

Occasion of revelation or report
general wording · §176

Offences and injuries
Foetal compensation: the identity of the right-holder matters · §211
A physician's mistake: compensation need not imply moral wrongdoing · §243

Omission (ḥadhf)
signification · §193
certain supplied meaning · §194

Omission (tark)
active restraint and mere absence · §48

Ordinary usage
distinction from legal meanings · §200

Original nonliability (barāʾa)
definition · §17
figuratively called a source · §62
not an abrogated revelation · §128
rational presumption · §141
matters without indication · §239

Original requirement (ʿazm)
definition · §60

Parents
prohibition of uff · §191
prohibition of reproach and greater injury · §215

Penalties
added lashes · §118
confinement, lashes, and stoning · §124
scope of analogy · §219

Permission (ibāḥa)
before revealed address · §16
definition and original non-liability · §17
outside the genus of demand · §26
not itself commanded · §27
not universal obligation · §227
not inferred from contradiction · §246

Pilgrimage
immediate or deferred performance · §25
place · §204
completing an invalidated rite · §205
taking the rites from the Prophet · §228
Pilgrimage now or later: a control against a simplistic application · §201
Completing ʿumra does not by itself prove an initial duty to begin it · §204
Bidāya: Pilgrimage now or later: a control against a simplistic application · §201
Bidāya: Completing ʿumra does not by itself prove an initial duty to begin it · §204

Plural
minimum number · §179
three, two, and one · §180

Poetry
evidence for disconnected exception · §185

Political coercion
apparent agreement · §138

Possibility
choice and foreknowledge · §19 · §20

Practice of Medina
transmission · §77
not numerical majority · §138
intergenerational transmission · §138

Prayer
stillness in bowing · §23
bathhouses and camel resting-places · §31
increase in cycles · §118
no sixth obligation · §141
catching one cycle · §194
manner of performance · §228
The basmala: Qurʾānic wording and membership in a sūra · §64
A mistaken qibla: required success or adequately conducted inquiry? · §237
Bidāya: The basmala: Qurʾānic wording and membership in a sūra · §64
Bidāya: A mistaken qibla: required success or adequately conducted inquiry? · §237

Preference (tarjīḥ)
indefinitely varied grounds · §93
additional knowledge · §96
place in the book · §230
same-kind and different-kind evidence · §256
contextual and virtually unlimited · §256
stronger probable judgement · §257

Pre-revelation acts
permission, suspension, and prohibition · §16

Presumption of continuity (istiṣḥāb)
five uses · §142

Private consultation
preliminary charity · §119

Probability (ẓann)
expectation of survival · §25
belief versus objective time · §59
different epistemic roles · §106
weighing indications · §181
preponderant and undecided · §193
understood meaning · §214
obligation to seek preponderance · §237
alleged dependence on personal inclination · §240
liability to mistake · §243
confidence as a practical sign · §250
stronger trust than one's own judgement · §251
introspective recognition of preponderance · §257

Probable indications
certain foundations · §138

Probity (ʿadāla)
definition · §86
major and minor sins · §87
outward Islam · §87
competing arguments · §88
probability of truthfulness · §90
interpretive disagreement · §91
revealed attestation · §98

Prohibition (nahy)
intrinsic attribute or external cause · §28
form and understood meaning · §29
external respects · §31
whether its contrary becomes obligatory · §34
intrinsic qualification and invalidation · §56
invalidity and legal effect · §206
relation to obligation · §207
absolute and qualified · §208
Bidāya: Proposing over another proposal: prohibition and contractual effect · §28

Pronouns
determinate reference · §157
ambiguous reference · §158

Proof
affirmative and negative claims · §141

Prophecy
recognition of a prophetic claim · §13

Prophet
protection from error · §227
certainty grounded in the miracle · §249

Prophetic action
evidence · §150
contextual rather than verbal evidence · §226
explanatory function · §228
peculiar to the Prophet · §229
unspecified legal force · §229
conflict with speech · §229

Prophetic teaching
public clarification · §113
modes of understanding · §148

Puberty
legal sign of maturity · §42

Purification
condition of prayer · §23
command to pray before ablution · §49
general report · §176
Bidāya: Wiping the head: a minimum performance and a contested particle · §23
Bidāya: Intention in ablution: devotional act and intelligible cleansing · §43
Bidāya: Touching women: equivocation, generality and counterevidence · §158

Purification from ritual impurity
Wiping the head: a minimum performance and a contested particle · §23
Intention in ablution: devotional act and intelligible cleansing · §43
Touching women: equivocation, generality and counterevidence · §158

Qibla
change at Qubāʾ · §123
direction as condition · §204

Quantification
minimum denoted by an act-name · §23

Qurʾ
menstruation or purity · §158

Qurʾān
interpretation of 4:43 · §38 · §40
apparent and unambiguous indication · §49
eternal divine speech · §63
boundaries of the transmitted corpus · §64
seven aḥruf · §64
muḥkam and mutashābih · §65
detached letters · §65
establishing formerly recited wording · §121
highest transmitted certainty · §125
incorporating an earlier law · §145
specification by solitary reports · §182
verses containing rulings · §232
completeness and what is passed over · §239

Qurʾānic quotations
conflated wording · §185

Qurʾānic readings
solitary additions and legal effect · §64
plural masākīn · §121

Ranking
internal inconsistency in enumeration · §218

Rational knowledge
grounds of obligation · §13

Recommendation (nadb)
definition · §17
commanded but not obligatory · §27
relation to probity · §86
distinct from obligation · §201

Relation
non-intrinsic moral evaluation · §11

Repetition (iʿāda)
correction of a defective act · §57

Reports (akhbār)
direct hearing and later transmission · §66
explicit direct-hearing formula · §67
attribution without explicit hearing · §68
paraphrase of legal force · §69
linguistic evidence · §70
passive command formula · §71
contemporary communal practice · §72
ranks of attribution · §73

Requests (ṭaliba)
lexical form · §152
equals · §197

Restriction
removal versus recommendation · §203

Revelation
authoritative instruction · §223

Reward and punishment
power to impose obligation · §37
coerced conduct · §47
omission · §48

Ribā
four food commodities · §191
edibility, staple food and measurement · §218

Sacrificial meat
storage · §119

Sales
intelligibility of legal grounds · §219
The sales-session option: what counts as “separation”? · §167
Ribā in foodstuffs: competing identifications of the operative feature · §218
Deferred animal barter: conflict can concern scope as well as authenticity · §256
Bidāya: The sales-session option: what counts as “separation”? · §167
Bidāya: Ribā in foodstuffs: competing identifications of the operative feature · §218
Bidāya: Deferred animal barter: conflict can concern scope as well as authenticity · §256

Ṣāʿ measure
Mālik and Abū Yūsuf · §138

School affiliation
transmitters and independent jurists · §252
critique of the preceding period · §254

Schools
Mālikīs, Shāfiʿīs and Ḥanafīs · §253

Shāfiʿī, al-
prohibited acts and validity · §28
basmala · §64
transmitter criticism · §91
cross-source abrogation · §124
interpretation of an attributed position · §125

Sībawayh
use of grammatical evidence · §180

Signs
predominance rather than exceptionless correspondence · §42

Silence
nonacceptance is not necessarily criticism · §97
multiple possible reasons · §137

Silver vessels
eating and drinking · §191

Sinlessness
not required of transmitters · §87

Slavery and emancipation
inclusion in human terms · §178
male and female slaves · §216

Slave women
marriage and dower · §171

Solitary reports
exceptional certainty · §79
organization · §80
rational possibility · §81
legal authorization · §81
Qurʾānic warrant · §82

Sophistry
denial of evidential force · §241

Sources of law
relation to derivation · §5
principles and branches · §6
Book, Sunna, consensus, and original negation · §62
two revealed sources · §114
fourfold account · §143
rejected independent grounds · §146
three principal transmitted sources · §231
earlier juristic opinions not revealed sources · §252
earlier opinions cannot replace revelation · §254

Speaker and addressee
contextual understanding · §161
error and deception · §162

Specification (takhṣīṣ)
distinction from abrogation · §126
remainder of a general expression · §135
intermediate plausibility · §172
agriculturally taxed kinds · §173
reduction to one · §179
relation to conflict · §181
earlier and later evidence · §182
distinction from exception · §183
contextual indication · §225

Specific expressions
transition · §190
relative scope · §191

Speech
inward command and verbal form · §198

Stoning verse
evidential reservations · §121

Substitution (ibdāl)
synonyms · §109
understood import · §154
universal and particular · §165
implied universal · §186
particular for universal · §191
particular expression for universal meaning · §212
conditions of warrant · §213
a named individual for a class · §216
limits of inferential recovery · §221

Sufficiency (ijzāʾ)
complete compliance · §205

Sunna
authority through the prophetic miracle · §66
ambiguous attribution · §71
recommended observance · §117

Sunni theologians
moral predicates · §11

Supplication
subordinate to superior · §197

Suspension of judgement
before revelation · §16
uncertain scope · §187
practical limits · §246

Syllogism
certain deduction contrasted with reports · §75

Synonymy
certain and inferred · §109

Tacit approval (iqrār)
knowledge of a practice · §72
teaching · §102
evidence · §150
contextual rather than verbal evidence · §226
permissibility · §227
approval of a legal judgement · §227

Taqlīd
asking a jurist · §105
accepting another’s paraphrase · §110
lay participation · §133
following fallible authority · §144
place in the book · §230
transition from inquiry · §248
definition · §249
ordinary people · §250
by an independent jurist · §251
limits of analogising from an imam’s opinions · §252
scope and limits · §255

Teaching and learning
introductory questions · §8
one science at a time · §9

Temporary marriage
abrogation · §120

Testimony
relation to transmission · §81 · §83 · §95
non-Muslim witnesses · §85
doctrinal disagreement · §92
witness and judge · §106

Testing and division
identifying a legal ground · §220
exclusion of rival grounds · §221
limits without contextual warrant · §225

Textual difficulties
defective prohibitive-form clause · §29
المستثنى and المنتشي · §39
acquisition and belief in obligation · §44
command and commander · §71
defective readings · §89
supplied paragraph numbering · §143
lacuna and marginal addition · §145
until and beyond · §160
omitted conjunction · §192
conjectural supplement · §224
incomplete classification · §229

Textual explicitness (naṣṣ)
exclusion of alternatives · §67
classification · §151
understood meaning · §155
simple and compound · §157
scarcity · §166

Theology (kalām)
proper place of foundational proofs · §37
questions excluded from uṣūl · §41 · §63
divine action · §115
first obligation of rational inquiry · §235

Threat
imperative usage · §200

Time
temporary and perpetual prescriptions · §115
expiry and repeal · §128
constitutive condition of worship · §204

Timely performance (adāʾ)
distinct from make-up liability · §51
definition · §57

Touching the penis
purification report · §112

Touching women
intercourse or contact · §167
combining incompatible readings · §177

Transfer (istiʿāra)
resemblance and relation · §153
sky and rain · §162
kinds · §164
relation to substitution · §165

Translation
Arabic and other languages · §109
limits of substitution · §110

Transmission
dispersal and disagreement · §3
necessary knowledge · §15
Qurʾānic certainty · §64
recurrent and solitary routes · §66 · §74
language and widespread usage · §70
definition of tawātur · §75
sensory and temporally determinate objects · §75
no fixed numerical threshold · §75
sensory basis · §77
reception and performance · §80 · §100
reporting from a narrator · §97
five levels · §100
direct hearing (samāʿ) · §101
reading before the teacher · §102
permission and direct hearing · §105
certainty of direct hearing · §106
denial by the source · §107
forgetfulness · §107
meaning rather than wording · §109
excerpts and context · §110
ʿanʿana · §111
duty to disseminate · §112
time and place · §113
wording and interpretation · §127
location of relevant preference rules · §256

Transmitters
qualifications · §80
number · §83
accurate retention (ḍabṭ) · §85
Islam · §85
conditions and preferences · §93
age and conversion not decisive · §129
reliance on an expert's accreditation · §233

Travel
postponing the fast · §57
validity of fasting during travel · §58

Trust
probable truth of an authority · §249

Truthfulness
reporting formulae · §102

Umm walad
sale · §142

Unbelievers
liability for branches of law · §49
inclusion in human terms · §178
distinct from lesser culpability · §244

Understood import (mafhūm)
division · §149
contextual certainty · §193
location of relevant preference rules · §256

Universal and particular
practical knowledge · §2
inductively established principles · §4
universal craft · §6
hard cases do not refute a universal · §53
incomplete but genuine knowledge · §163
semantic direction · §165
relation to general wording · §169
contextual enlargement · §186
recovering the relevant universal · §221

Unknown transmitters
investigation · §88
outward Islam · §89
identification · §111

Unqualified and qualified (muṭlaq, muqayyad)
qualification after an absolute command · §29
same context · §189
different contexts · §189

Usurped land
validity of prayer · §31
leaving a cultivated field · §53

ʿUthmān
killing and interpretive error · §99

Validity
prohibition and invalidation · §28
place in the four-part scheme · §54
theologians and jurists · §56
discharge of make-up liability · §56
conditions of discharge · §205

Vows
fasting · §172

Water
well of Buḍāʿa · §176

Welfare reasoning (istiṣlāḥ)
limits · §146

Welfare (ṣalāḥ)
equal alternatives · §19

Whole and part
integral action · §117

Widely accepted propositions (mashhūrāt)
not convertible with rational truth · §12

Widespread need (ʿumūm al-balwā)
solitary reports · §77 · §112
contextual assessment · §113

Will (irāda)
desire and hope or fear · §44

Wine drinking
comparison with false accusation · §223

Written transmission
handing over (munāwala) · §104
handwriting · §105
verified copies · §105

Ẓāhirīs
legal inference without analogy · §6
fasting on other days · §58
requirement of actual wording · §69
consensus · §136
continuity and rejection of analogy · §142
critique of analogical warrant · §223
admitting meaning-based indication · §224
original freedom from obligation · §238
equal evidence · §247

Zakāt
advance payment · §58
crops and vegetables · §173
grazing sheep · §195
Zakāt on a child’s property: worship or a claim upon wealth? · §38
Jewellery: resemblance to usable possessions or to monetary wealth? · §214
Bidāya: Zakāt on a child’s property: worship or a claim upon wealth? · §38
Bidāya: Jewellery: resemblance to usable possessions or to monetary wealth? · §214

Technical dictionary

Short editorial definitions for use with the reading translation. Section references return to the text.

adāʾ أَدَاء

Timely performance: discharging an act within its legally appointed time; distinguish repetition and make-up performance.

§57 · §59

ʿadāla عَدَالَة

Probity: a disposition supporting a transmitter's reliability, not a claim that every lapse destroys credibility.

§86 · §87 · §90 · §98

ʿāmm عَامّ

General expression: wording embracing the instances of a meaning. Do not confuse this linguistic scope with several equivocal meanings.

§169 · §170 · §174 · §177

ʿaql عَقْل

Intellect or reason; its relation to goodness, obligation and revealed authority is discussed without making theology the whole of uṣūl.

§11 · §13 · §37 · §45

aṣl أَصْل

Foundation, source, original case, or governing principle. In qiyās it is the case or meaning from which extension proceeds.

§62 · §141 · §210 · §212

ʿazīma / ʿazm عَزِيمَة / عَزْم

Original legal requirement, contrasted with a concession. The text uses the vocabulary of the unrelaxed requirement in defining the contrast.

§60

barāʾa aṣliyya بَرَاءَة أَصْلِيَّة

Original freedom from liability: obligation requires a warrant; absence of such a warrant is not itself a newly revealed duty.

§141 · §142 · §247

bāṭil / buṭlān بَاطِل / بُطْلَان

Invalid / invalidity. In contracts, absence of the intended legal effect; invalidity is not interchangeable with moral prohibition.

§28 · §56 · §206

bayān بَيَان

Clarification: whatever validly brings a meaning to understanding, including wording, context and explanatory action.

§159 · §160 · §161 · §228

burhān بُرْهَان

Demonstration or conclusive proof. Its logical analysis belongs to a different discipline from the present abridgement's immediate task.

§9 · §15 · §75

dalāla دَلَالَة

Indication or signification: the relation by which words, understood meanings, acts or approval make a ruling intelligible.

§148 · §149 · §150 · §193

dalīl دَلِيل

Evidence, indicator or proof. Its strength may be conclusive or probable; "proof" does not always mean logical demonstration.

§62 · §74 · §81 · §241

dalīl al-khiṭāb دَلِيل الْخِطَاب

Contrary implication inferred from a restriction, condition or qualification. Its force depends on context, not form alone.

§193 · §195

ḍamīr ضَمِير

Pronoun: an expression whose referent can be determinate or ambiguous; reference is one component of verbal indication.

§152 · §157 · §158

ḍarūra ضَرُورَة

Necessity or constraint. In practical law it can ground a concession; this is distinct from the epistemic sense of necessary knowledge.

§53 · §60

ḍarūrī ضَرُورِيّ

Necessary; in knowledge, immediately or inevitably known rather than acquired through a consciously constructed argument. In the title, what is indispensable to the craft.

§1 · §2 · §15 · §76

ḍidd ضِدّ

Contrary: opposed acts or qualities. Whether alternatives exhaust the possibilities is crucial to the argument about commands and prohibitions.

§26 · §32 · §33 · §34 · §52

farʿ فَرْع

Derivative case or branch of law; in qiyās, the case whose ruling is sought through a relation to the original.

§2 · §210 · §211

farḍ فَرْض

Obligatory requirement. The discussion records a distinction from wājib made by some jurists and its evidential basis.

§17

fasād فَسَاد

Corruption or invalidity; in legal use, failure of an act or contract in the respect relevant to its ruling.

§28 · §29 · §56 · §206

fiʿl فِعْل

Act: voluntary human performance or Prophetic action. An act has no imperative grammatical form of its own.

§43 · §150 · §228 · §229

fiqh فِقْه

Understanding of practical legal rulings. Detailed branch-law learning is related to, but not identical with, the requirements of independent inquiry.

§2 · §235 · §252

furūʿ فُرُوع

Branches or derivative rulings, distinguished from sources and the general method for understanding their indications.

§2 · §235 · §252

ghalabat al-ẓann غَلَبَة الظَّنّ

Preponderant judgement: the balance of probable evidence which guides action; it does not create truth merely through preference.

§90 · §237 · §241 · §257

ghāya غَايَة

End or limit. In a temporal expression such as “until night,” it means an endpoint, not a purposive final cause.

§2 · §195

ḥadd حَدّ

Definition or boundary. In another context, a prescribed penalty; these senses must not be collapsed into one English rendering.

§10 · §11 · §219

ḥadīth حَدِيث

A transmitted report, especially one attributed to the Prophet. The discussion distinguishes its wording, content, chain and resulting degree of assent.

§66 · §80 · §109 · §233

ḥākim حَاكِم

One who determines or commands; in the account of legal judgement, ultimately God, with derivative human authority distinguished.

§36 · §37

ḥaqīqa حَقِيقَة

Proper or literal usage, opposed to transferred or figurative usage; context determines which sense is established.

§65 · §153 · §162 · §164

ḥaraj حَرَج

Restriction, difficulty or legal impediment; removing a prohibition need not itself issue a positive recommendation.

§60 · §203

ḥarām حَرَام

Forbidden: subject to legal prohibition. Whether a forbidden act is also invalid is a further issue.

§17 · §28 · §206

ḥaṣr حَصْر

Restriction or exclusive limitation, conveyed by expressions such as innamā; its contrary implication is assessed contextually.

§195

ḥiss حِسّ

Sense perception. Actual sensory apprehension, not mere perceptibility, matters in the account of transmitted certainty.

§15 · §45 · §77 · §78

ḥujja حُجَّة

Authoritative evidence or argument capable of supporting a legal conclusion; its authority and degree of certainty are separate questions.

§1 · §81 · §130 · §144

ḥukm حُكْم

Judgement or ruling: the legal determination concerning an act, with its author, addressee and object analysed separately.

§10 · §11 · §17 · §36 · §239

ḥusn / qubḥ حُسْن / قُبْح

Goodness / badness: evaluative terms whose intrinsic, relational and revealed senses are distinguished at the beginning of the book.

§11 · §12 · §13

ʿibāda عِبَادَة

Worship or devotional observance. Its valid performance, intention and timing are analysed without identifying all legal consequences with worship.

§43 · §56 · §57

ibāḥa إِبَاحَة

Permission: a legal allowing of alternatives, distinguished from obligation and from mere absence of an established prohibition.

§16 · §17 · §27 · §203

ibdāl / tabdīl إِبْدَال / تَبْدِيل

Substitution: expression of a universal through a particular or vice versa, central to Ibn Rushd's account of semantic extension.

§154 · §165 · §191 · §212 · §221

idhn إِذْن

Permission or authorization; its context matters in reports about guardianship and in a teacher's authorization to transmit.

§103 · §171

ijāza إِجَازَة

Authorization to transmit, distinguished from hearing a reading, reading before the teacher, and receiving a written text.

§100 · §103 · §104

ijmāʿ إِجْمَاع

Consensus: agreement of those competent in the relevant inquiry. Mere majority, silence and unidentified Medinan practice are not equivalent to it.

§130 · §133 · §134 · §137 · §138

ijtihād اجْتِهَاد

Independent juristic inquiry: exertion of competent judgement concerning a ruling not already determined by conclusive evidence.

§231 · §236 · §237 · §250

ijzāʾ إِجْزَاء

Sufficiency or discharge: performance which fulfils the legally required act, including its relevant conditions.

§23 · §56 · §204 · §205

ʿilla عِلَّة

Effective ground or explanatory feature connecting a ruling with a case. It must be distinguished from a general benefit or an accidental concomitant.

§210 · §213 · §217 · §218 · §222

ʿilm عِلْم

Knowledge, sometimes certain cognition and sometimes a discipline. Its theoretical, practical and instrumental ends are distinguished.

§2 · §8 · §74 · §75

imkān إِمْكَان

Possibility: physical capacity to perform an act is not the same as the presence of every legal condition governing it.

§45 · §49 · §50

iqrār إِقْرَار

Tacit approval: the Prophet's non-objection in relevant circumstances, indicating permissibility rather than automatically establishing obligation.

§150 · §227

irāda إِرَادَة

Will or volition. Its relation to desire, assent and intending obedience is discussed in the account of voluntary action.

§43 · §44

ishtirāk اشْتِرَاك

Equivocation: one expression's established use for distinct meanings, not the inclusion of many instances within a single general meaning.

§158 · §177

istiʿāra اسْتِعَارَة

Transfer or metaphorical borrowing of an expression, one way words can signify beyond their original assignment.

§153 · §164 · §180

istidlāl اسْتِدْلَال

Inference or reasoning from an indication to what it establishes. It need not be a formal syllogism.

§1 · §2 · §81 · §148

istiḥsān اسْتِحْسَان

Juristic preference. A judgement so named needs a recognized evidential warrant; its name does not confer authority.

§146

istiqrāʾ اسْتِقْرَاء

Induction: discerning a pattern from cases, including the recovery of early jurists' implicit methods from their decisions.

§4 · §217

istiṣḥāb اسْتِصْحَاب

Presumption of continuity: retaining an established judgement, subject to whether the relevant case or attribute has changed.

§141 · §142

istiṣlāḥ اسْتِصْلَاح

Welfare-oriented reasoning. The Darūrī asks what makes a proposed benefit legally authoritative rather than merely attractive.

§146 · §217

istithnāʾ اسْتِثْنَاء

Exception: exclusion related to a statement's scope, with distinct problems of connection, reach and the genus excepted.

§183 · §184 · §185 · §186 · §187 · §188

jarḥ جَرْح

Criticism of a narrator's credibility or probity; the grounds and relative force of such criticism require assessment.

§94 · §95 · §96

jins جِنْس

Genus or kind: a grouping by an intelligible common feature, important in classification and in recognized suitable grounds.

§185 · §217 · §224

juzʾī جُزْئِيّ

Particular: an individual case or more restricted meaning relative to a universal. It is not simply a grammatical "specific expression."

§2 · §165 · §191 · §212

kalām كَلَام

Speech; also rational theology. Which sense applies depends on the argument, and the latter is not the whole subject of uṣūl.

§9 · §41 · §63 · §235

karāha كَرَاهَة

Dislike or disapproval, sometimes distinguished from strict prohibition; the required contextual indication must be examined.

§17 · §29 · §208

kasb / iktisāb كَسْب / اكْتِسَاب

Acquisition: the disputed account of human agency, choice and voluntary action. The reported theological positions are not all Ibn Rushd's own.

§43 · §44 · §45

khabar خَبَر

Report: a communicated assertion assessed through its source, wording and evidential consequences.

§66 · §74 · §80 · §109

khabar al-wāḥid خَبَر الْوَاحِد

Solitary report: a report not attaining the certainty of mass transmission; "solitary" does not necessarily mean only one transmitter at every stage.

§79 · §81 · §83 · §112

khāṣṣ خَاصّ

Specific expression: wording directly designating a restricted subject, which may nevertheless indicate an intended universal through context.

§165 · §191

khaṭaʾ خَطَأ

Error: failure to attain the true ruling or perform correctly. It can be pardoned without becoming correctness.

§237 · §243 · §244 · §245

khiṭāb خِطَاب

Address or discourse: the Lawgiver's communication as directed to an addressee concerning an act; context is constitutive of understanding.

§11 · §36 · §38 · §239

kināya كِنَايَة

Indirect expression: signifying by an associated meaning rather than simply naming the referent directly.

§164 · §167

kullī كُلِّيّ

Universal: a meaning under which particulars fall, crucial to understanding legal extension beyond a named example.

§2 · §165 · §191 · §212 · §221

lafẓ لَفْظ

Expression or wording; its verbal form is distinguished from the meaning indicated in the whole discourse.

§109 · §148 · §149 · §153

mafhūm مَفْهُوم

Understood import: the meaning apprehended through an expression and its context, including but not limited to contrary implication.

§149 · §193 · §194 · §195

maḥkūm ʿalayhi مَحْكُوم عَلَيْهِ

The person to whom the ruling applies; understanding, capacity and other conditions affect the nature of the address.

§36 · §38 · §42

maḥkūm fīhi مَحْكُوم فِيهِ

The act or matter about which a legal judgement is made; distinguish the person addressed by it.

§36 · §43

majāz مَجَاز

Figurative or transferred usage. It includes omission, addition and substitution, not merely literary metaphor.

§65 · §153 · §154 · §162 · §164

makrūh مَكْرُوه

Disapproved or disliked, one of the fivefold legal classifications; use in context can require distinction from outright forbiddance.

§17 · §208

maʿlūl مَعْلُول

That explained or grounded by an ʿilla; correspondence with a feature does not by itself establish explanatory dependence.

§210 · §220 · §222

maʿnā مَعْنَى

Meaning, intelligible content or relevant feature. Translating it uniformly as “cause” would conceal important distinctions.

§149 · §158 · §193 · §212

mandūb مَنْدُوب

Recommended: an act commended without being obligatorily demanded. Its contrary does not acquire a ruling by a purely verbal inversion.

§17 · §32 · §208

manṭūq مَنْطُوق

What is explicitly expressed, contrasted with the unmentioned case or the meaning understood beyond verbal form.

§149 · §191 · §210 · §212

maqṣūd مَقْصُود

What is intended: the intelligible aim of the address, recovered through indications rather than supplied by arbitrary preference.

§161 · §191 · §217 · §239

maʿqūl مَعْقُول

Intelligible meaning or object of understanding. In legal interpretation it contrasts with reliance upon verbal form alone.

§149 · §193 · §212

mashhūrāt مَشْهُورَات

Widely accepted propositions; general acceptance alone does not establish rational necessity or demonstrative truth.

§12

maṣlaḥa مَصْلَحَة

Benefit or welfare. Its legal authority depends on its relation to recognized purposes or evidence, not on attractiveness alone.

§146 · §217

mithāl مِثَال

Example or illustrative case; its relation to a universal meaning must be distinguished from a merely verbal likeness.

§1 · §6 · §212

muʾawwal مُؤَوَّل

Interpreted wording: an expression taken in a less immediately apparent sense because an adequate indication supports that reading.

§151 · §164 · §166

mubāḥ مُبَاح

Permitted: not demanded or forbidden in the respect being considered. Its status as “commanded” is itself disputed.

§16 · §17 · §27

mudrak مُدْرَك

Source or means of apprehension: where or how a judgement is known. The lexical vocalization has an initial ḍamma.

§13 · §47

mujmal مُجْمَل

Indeterminate wording or indication, insufficient by itself to select the required meaning; clarification can come through several kinds of evidence.

§151 · §155 · §158 · §214 · §218

mujtahid مُجْتَهِد

One qualified to undertake independent juristic inquiry; competence may concern a determinate question rather than every branch of law.

§231 · §232 · §233 · §234 · §236

mukallaf مُكَلَّف

A person subject to legal responsibility; physical action, comprehension and the relevant legal conditions must be distinguished.

§38 · §42 · §45 · §50

mukhayyil مُخَيِّل

A ground presenting a plausible rationale for a ruling, often considered with suitability. Not “imaginal” in the metaphysical sense.

§217 · §224

mulāʾim مُلَائِم

Congruent or fitting: a proposed ground related to a kind of consideration which revelation has recognized.

§217 · §224

munāsib مُنَاسِب

Suitable: a proposed ground connected intelligibly with a legally recognized benefit or prevention of harm.

§217 · §224

munāwala مُنَاوَلَة

Handing over a written text with authorization to transmit; distinct from direct hearing and a bare written attribution.

§104 · §105

muqaddima مُقَدِّمَة

Premise, or an introductory discussion. Premises can contribute to assent without being consciously arranged as a syllogism.

§9 · §75 · §76

muqayyad مُقَيَّد

Qualified: wording limited by a condition or attribute. Moving a qualification between contexts requires a warrant.

§189 · §195

mursal مُرْسَل

A report whose chain leaves an intermediary unmentioned; acceptance is discussed separately from connected transmission.

§111

musnad مُسْنَد

A report with an articulated connected attribution; its comparative force still depends on the relevant transmitters and circumstances.

§111

mutawātir مُتَوَاتِر

Mass-transmitted: a mode of communication yielding certainty through the circumstances of its transmission, not a universally fixed count.

§75 · §76 · §78

muṭlaq مُطْلَق

Unqualified: wording without a stated restriction in the relevant respect. Unqualified and general are not simply interchangeable categories.

§189 · §201 · §203

nadb نَدْب

Recommendation, distinct from obligation; its establishment depends on the relevant usage and indication.

§17 · §200 · §208

nahy نَهْي

Prohibition or prohibitive address. Its force, contextual restriction and possible effect on validity need separate analysis.

§28 · §197 · §206 · §208

naql نَقْل

Transmission; also a word’s transfer from one usage to another. Context distinguishes the two technical senses.

§66 · §153 · §256

naskh نَسْخ

Abrogation: termination of an earlier legal ruling by later revelation; not identical with specification or additional explanation.

§114 · §115 · §118 · §126 · §181

naṣṣ نَصّ

Unambiguous indication: a determinate meaning, not simply any “text.” The book admits unambiguity through understood import as well as wording.

§151 · §157 · §193 · §215

naẓar نَظَر

Inquiry or reflective consideration, including the disciplined examination of evidence; more specific than casual “looking.”

§1 · §13 · §45 · §148

niyya نِيَّة

Intention: aiming at obedience or distinguishing a particular performance; not every legal effect depends on such an intention.

§22 · §43 · §47

qaḍāʾ قَضَاء

Make-up performance outside the appointed time; also judgement in other contexts. Whether it needs a distinct command is a central question.

§51 · §57 · §204

qarīna قَرِينَة

Contextual indication: verbal or circumstantial evidence that guides meaning, interpretation or an extension beyond the named case.

§161 · §166 · §193 · §213

qaṭʿī قَطْعِيّ

Conclusive: an indication or judgement not merely probable. Degrees of evidential clarity remain important for culpability.

§74 · §125 · §237 · §244

qiyās قِيَاس

Analogy or syllogistic inference, depending on context. Much juristic qiyās is analysed here as substitution within an understood meaning rather than a syllogism.

§210 · §212 · §223 · §226

qiyās al-shabah قِيَاس الشَّبَه

Analogy of resemblance: extending a ruling because a likeness is thought to contain a shared ground, without identifying that ground securely.

§218 · §224

qurʾ قُرْء

An equivocal legal expression for a menstrual period or a period of purity, used as an example of indeterminate wording.

§158

rāwī رَاوٍ

Narrator or transmitter. Reception, retention, probity, attribution and denial are separate aspects of assessment.

§83 · §85 · §94 · §107

rukhṣa رُخْصَة

Concession: a legally warranted relaxation under an impediment or need; not mere indulgence outside the Law.

§58 · §60

sabab سَبَب

Cause, occasion or sign. A legal cause may manifest a ruling without producing it as a physical cause produces an effect.

§54 · §55 · §176

sabr wa-taqsīm سَبْر وَتَقْسِيم

Testing and division: enumerating and examining candidates for a relevant ground, then eliminating those not warranted.

§220 · §221

ṣaḥīḥ / ṣiḥḥa صَحِيح / صِحَّة

Valid / validity; also soundness of a report in transmission. The intended legal or hadith sense must be specified.

§56 · §93 · §205

ṣalāḥ صَلَاح

Welfare, right ordering or fitness; its appearance in a proposed rationale must be disciplined by the Law’s recognition.

§19 · §146 · §217

sharʿ شَرْع

Revealed Law or revelation as normative authority; distinguish its address from the jurist’s reconstruction of a ruling.

§11 · §13 · §37 · §239

sharṭ شَرْط

Condition: a qualification for a legal ruling or valid performance; not every legal condition is a condition of physical possibility.

§23 · §49 · §50 · §56 · §195

shubha شُبْهَة

Ground of uncertainty or apparent likeness. Its exact force varies between evidential doubt and a proposed analogy.

§92 · §218 · §238

sibār سِبَار

Probe or testing instrument: the opening image for a discipline that guides the mind. It is not the name of a separate metaphysical science.

§2

ṣīgha صِيغَة

Verbal form: grammatical or conventional expression as distinct from the meaning understood in context.

§149 · §151 · §197 · §223

ṣināʿa صِنَاعَة

Craft or disciplined art: an organized competence governed by methods and standards, not modern industrial production.

§1 · §2 · §6 · §9

sunna سُنَّة

Prophetic normative teaching and practice; “it is Sunna” as a transmission formula must be assessed for its source and scope.

§66 · §71 · §114

taʿāruḍ تَعَارُض

Conflict of evidence: an apparent opposition requiring assessment of reconciliation, chronology, preference or suspension.

§96 · §181 · §229 · §246

taʿdīl تَعْدِيل

Attestation of probity, distinct from criticism and from an automatic guarantee of every report.

§94 · §95 · §96 · §97

takhṣīṣ تَخْصِيص

Specification: restricting a general expression’s scope on adequate evidence; chronology helps distinguish it from abrogation.

§174 · §181 · §182 · §190

taklīf تَكْلِيف

Legal responsibility or imposition of a duty, directed to an agent under conditions of comprehension and capacity.

§17 · §38 · §42 · §45

ṭaliba طَلِبَة

Request or petition, one of the forms of complete discourse. This is the noun for a request, not the plural ṭalaba, “students.”

§152 · §197

tamthīl تَمْثِيل

Exemplification or reasoning by a comparable particular; do not assume that every legal extension has this structure.

§1 · §210 · §212 · §223

tanbīh تَنْبِيه

Indication or directing attention to an unstated meaning, often through the relation between a named particular and an intended universal.

§191 · §209 · §212 · §215

taqlīd تَقْلِيد

Following another’s authority. Trustworthy expert reliance is distinguished from treating memorized school opinions as independent evidence.

§249 · §250 · §251 · §252 · §255

tarjīḥ تَرْجِيح

Giving greater weight: preferring the stronger evidence or judgement on a relevant ground, not free personal choice.

§96 · §246 · §256 · §257

taṣdīq تَصْدِيق

Assent to an assertion. Its cause, necessity and degree are discussed especially in the analysis of mass transmission.

§15 · §44 · §74 · §75 · §76

taṣwīb تَصْوِيب

Declaring juristic conclusions correct; the debate asks whether every qualified conclusion is true or whether one determinate ruling is sought.

§237 · §239 · §240 · §243

taʾthīm تَأْثِيم

Attribution of sin. Its absence does not entail the absence of error; knowledge and the accessibility of evidence matter.

§242 · §243 · §244 · §245

tawaqquf تَوَقُّف

Suspension of judgement when the evidence does not justify a determinate conclusion; distinct from arbitrary choice.

§229 · §246

tawātur تَوَاتُر

Mass transmission producing certainty, whose conditions are contextual and not captured by a single numerical threshold.

§74 · §75 · §76 · §78

taʾwīl تَأْوِيل

Interpretation supported by evidence, especially departure from an expression’s apparent meaning to a less evident one.

§164 · §166 · §171

tawqīf تَوْقِيف

Dependence on revealed instruction; in §229 the printed term is understood contextually as withholding judgement. Note the distinct usages.

§49 · §229

ʿumūm عُمُوم

Generality: inclusion of the instances falling within a meaning. Its force differs across forms and contexts.

§169 · §170 · §174 · §178

ʿumūm al-balwā عُمُوم الْبَلْوَى

Widespread practical need: a consideration in assessing whether a solitary report plausibly preserves a generally required observance.

§112 · §113

ʿurf عُرْف

Established usage or convention, linguistic or legal; a command's force must be learned in its relevant convention.

§153 · §199 · §200 · §203

uṣūl al-fiqh أُصُول الْفِقْهِ

Principles of jurisprudence: in this abridgement, above all the disciplined understanding of revealed indications and the means of reaching rulings.

§1 · §2 · §5 · §6 · §148

waḍʿ وَضْع

Assignment or institution of a word's meaning; distinguish original linguistic assignment from subsequent transfer and specialized legal usage.

§153 · §199

wājib وَاجِب

Obligatory: legally demanded. Alternative duties, extended times, necessary means and culpability prevent a merely schematic definition from doing all the work.

§17 · §18 · §21 · §23 · §243

yaqīn يَقِين

Certainty: assent not merely outweighed probability. Its sources and possible degrees are discussed without reducing it to a transmitter count.

§74 · §75 · §78 · §125

ẓāhir ظَاهِر

Apparent or prima-facie indication: the meaning more readily warranted, though another remains possible. It can arise from understood import as well as verbal form.

§164 · §166 · §193 · §224

ẓann ظَنّ

Probable judgement: an evidentially grounded but nonconclusive assent, not necessarily a pejorative "guess."

§74 · §79 · §90 · §237 · §257

ziyāda زِيَادَة

Addition: extra wording in a report, an added legal requirement, or linguistic surplus; these distinct contexts have different rules.

§108 · §118 · §154